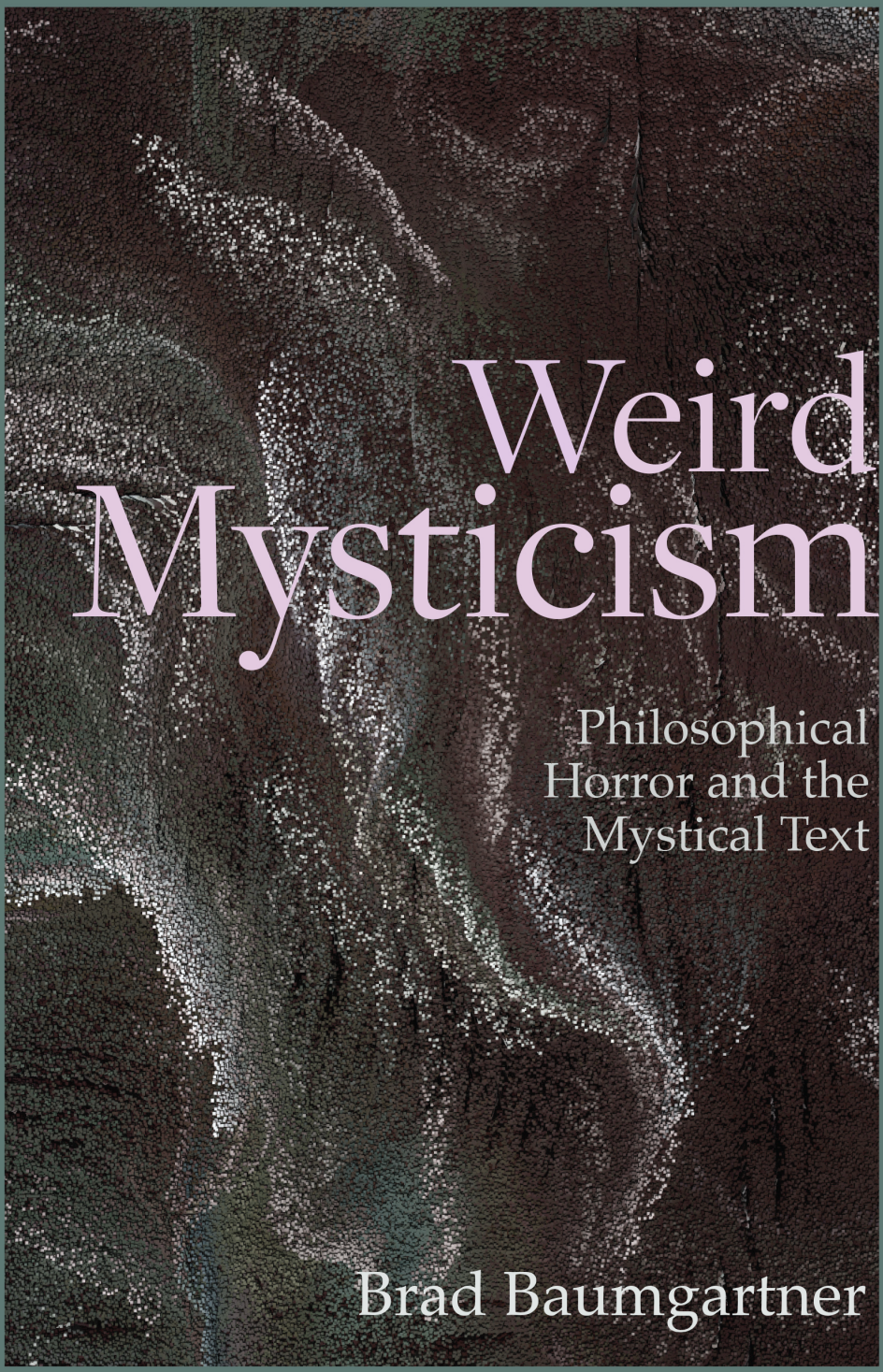

Weird
Mysticism
Philosophical
Horror and the
Mystical Text
Brad Baumgartner

Weird Mysticism

Critical Conversations in Horror Studies

General Editor: Dawn Keetley, Lehigh University

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Weird Mysticism: Philosophical Horror and the Mystical Text, by Brad Bumgartner

Weird Mysticism

Philosophical Horror and the Mystical Text

Brad Baumgartner

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Contents

Introduction: The Path to Nowhere 1

1 Piercing the Cosmological Horizon 7
2 Thomas Ligotti: The Poetics of Darkness 25
3 Georges Bataille: Opening Up the Infinite 63
4 E. M. Cioran: The Horror of Being Oneself 103

Afterword: Toward the Mystical Death of the Speculative Critic 147
Works Cited 151
Index 159
About the Author 163

Introduction

The Path to Nowhere

This book presents a theoretical exploration of mysticism, philosophy, and horror, particularly regarding the works of Thomas Ligotti, Georges Bataille, and E. M. Cioran. Though a study of each of these writers would prove interesting no matter the focus, one centered on the interplay of mysticism, philosophy, and horror appears an especially fascinating vista based on the recent turn toward (or perhaps return to) speculative thinking in philosophy and literary studies. Our present time in history implicates critics in a bending-away from theories on the nature of reality that have remained virtually unchanged in philosophical discourse in the centuries since the Enlightenment. This is not necessarily pejorative. The Enlightenment's pervasive presence in the evolution of modern Western thought and culture is here taken as a given, thus validation is allotted to those revolutions in science, literature, philosophy, politics, and the arts that we have come to know as beneficent to modernity. Yet, much of the intellectual climate of post-Enlightenment thought is steeped in asymmetrical power relations that lead to suffering, causing stark damage to human—not only intellectual, but also emotional, bodily, and political—freedom, and relegating speculative, potentially liberating discourse to the margins. Thus critics are now faced with the unique opportunity to partake in radical forms of knowledge production that seek freedom from hegemonic discourses. The potentiality of the speculative to usher in new modes of thought that, while harkening back to spiritual discourses of the Middle Ages, also advance a radicalization of reality—not only social conceptions of "reality" but an opening up of divine Reality—becomes the explicit focus of this book.

Despite much excellent work on mysticism, literature, and philosophy in their respective fields, scholars have not yet fully explored the importance of viewing these traditions in an interdisciplinary context. Our analysis will move against the grain of research which relegates them to all-too-typical historical or social contexts without opening up lines of discourse to other fields of study. Moving alongside recent interdisciplinary scholarship that speculatively reconsiders the way one might understand reality and our relationship (or lack thereof) to it—as in Eugene Thacker's work on "the horror of philosophy"—this book investigates the possibility and necessity of considering these three distinct and histori-

cally diverse traditions in relation to one another. Hence, by implicating readers in a writerly aporia in which these three seemingly distinct traditions simultaneously attract and negate one another, the work herein helps us to expand our understanding of genre horror. For instance, this book will trace how these writers utilize an alternating dialectic between materialism and mysticism to develop epigrammatic modes of thought that indicate textual sites of synthesis between the human and non-human. Broadly, the book builds on existing speculative theories in order to proffer its own new one. More closely, it defines several key components: what "weird mysticism" is as a theory and a practice, how weird mysticism relates to horror fiction and philosophy (i.e., pessimism and speculative realism), and how weird mysticism is a mode of speculative criticism capable of creating critical conversations among other disciplines, methodologies, and critics.

One critical conversation begun in this book revolves around a key inversion that horror itself substantiates: one that views philosophy as a kind of fiction and fiction as philosophy. The inversion of this hermeneutic polarity, so to speak, is the compass to traversing what we might call the "path to nowhere," for at the end of the day, as Thomas Ligotti says, "there is nowhere to go and there is no one to be." Simultaneously, this path to nowhere serves as a metaphysical bridge of sorts, that is, it figuratively attempts to bridge the notion of mystical death with the death of the literary critic. It thus seeks to theorize mystical death in literature, philosophy, and traditional mysticism via the figure of a critic who exists beyond the grave of meaning, to engage in a critical conversation with a critic who shares a common question with our study here: in what ways does contemporary theory fail to account for speculative forms of thinking that seek to transgress the limits of philosophy? Or, put another way, in what ways can we articulate a theoretical viewpoint that is also non-philosophical, allowing for a simultaneous challenge to philosophical authority via the literary (i.e., the mystical text)?

Attempting to answer this common question will bring readers closer to understanding how the mystical in some way recuperates the limits of philosophical thinking in order to possibly *think through* such limits and come out on the other side. The *other side* here is twofold: it indicates a walking through to but also a "crossing over" (to the other side); it means to think *through* and *with* the Other Side and with what horrors may reside there. This book is benevolently haunted by the ghostly doubleness of this figure/figural, creating the conditions of possibility to engage in a critical conversation not only with other scholars and disciplines, but one curated by the reader's own communicative interest in speaking with the ghost of the text, for just as it has been said that "the translator is the translated," so also it can be said that "the reader is the read." This critical conversation on mystical death with the spectral figure of the dead critic also allows us to further consider how the materiality of horror fiction

and the mystical text complicates mysticism's relation to immanence, bringing the weird mystic closer to Oneness with the beyond and yet exacerbating the agonistic experience of being human via individuation.

In this way, the book advances an interdisciplinary approach that also accounts for the complicity of the reader/writer of the analyzed texts. That is to say, it discusses the facticity of reading and writing, and how one might produce a knowledge that erases the knower by actually doing what you are reading about (i.e., putting theory into the practice). It also provides concrete treatment of literary form, philosophical method, and a lot of scope for a comparative understanding of medieval mystics versus weird mystics, fiction versus philosophy, and how those dichotomies also tend to break down under hermeneutic scrutiny. Keeping these remarks in mind, one of the implicit desires of this book is to trace the movement of this bewildering path to nowhere, for just as Austin Osman Spare once noted that "it was the straying that found the path direct" ("On Myself"), we might say that following this path to nowhere (i.e., staying put in our own facticity) is to go everywhere, to *pierce the cosmological horizon*.

In chapter 1, "Piercing the Cosmological Horizon," we will begin by tracing a trajectory of weird mysticism, from its ties to medieval mysticism, to its pessimistic and artistic expression in speculative/horror fiction and modern philosophy. This chapter introduces the portmanteau term "weird mysticism" and presents relevant historical and theoretical background material in order to frame and coin the term's meaning. It also discusses the characteristics of the genre, presents its formal features as well as defines it as an actual praxis, and explains the key conversation among horror, mysticism, and philosophy. Noting that these three distinct categories are indeed interrelated and have strange effects on one another when analyzed, the long tradition of "the weird" becomes this modern mysticism's *sanctues divinae*, or divine sanctuary, blurring the boundaries between horror and philosophy, materialism and mysticism.

By electing this method, subsequent chapters will explore how Ligotti, Bataille, and Cioran are based firmly both within and without the medieval mystical tradition, engaging the infinity of the beyond in its irreducibly individual character at the absolute limits of human thought while managing to make the beyond a theoretical priority. In so doing, we will also strive to reveal the contingent and irreducibly textual dimension to these works, which, on the one hand, denies the purely mystical experience by linking it to writing and genre and, on the other hand, transcends this textual dimension vis-à-vis the mode of mystical auto-commentary.

Unlike traditional mystics, horror writers do not seek union with the divine. Through an analysis of Thomas Ligotti's horror fiction, in chapter 2, "Thomas Ligotti: The Poetics of Darkness," we instead show how horror fiction deploys apophatic techniques in order to describe negatively the indescribable. In so doing, this chapter will consider Ligotti's horror

fiction, especially the logic of negation found in *Noctuary* (1996), in relation to the horror of reality—a horror effectuated by our alienation from absolute unreality, horror's analog to the medieval mystic's God. Ligotti's characters are forever banished to wander the world in a state akin to John of the Cross's "dark night of the soul," never to find oneness with their own unreality. He sees in human consciousness not only "a vortex of doleful factuality" (*Conspiracy* 41), but additional fodder for existential suffering because the horrors we cannot yet comprehend are rooted within us. In Ligottian horror fiction, we find a perverse darkness mysticism: always already living in immanent darkness, a state of, we might call, noct(e)rnity, there is nothing to "wake up" to, and even if there were, it wouldn't be worth waking up *for it*.

Chapter 3, "George Bataille: Opening Up the Infinite," will focus on one of the central features of weird mysticism, a vertiginous attempt but an incapacity to think the object of desire: a world-without-us. Keeping this in mind, we will attempt to show how several of Georges Bataille's mystical texts help to create/write a bridge between the intellectual and the mystical, reviving discussions about the importance of studying esoterica to introduce new compositional methods of critique, modes of thinking, and practices of representation. We will find in Bataille's concept of the impossible at once a mode of writing and a form of non-knowledge, a logic of negativity severed from the mystical tradition in order to be appropriated as anti-philosophy.

Considering the writings of late-twentieth-century pessimist philosopher E. M. Cioran as its main focus, chapter 4, "The Horror of Being Oneself," extends the book's analysis to analyze the relation between philosophical pessimism and mystical discourse. Cioran's aphoristic work focuses on themes such as nothingness, despair, suffering, personal crisis, and mysticism. Though many may read Cioran's work as pessimistic and incomplete, we will argue that these are important features in his work: they are the textual remnants of a rigorous—albeit subtractive—process of un-making oneself and the world via a practical mysticism of intense, pessimistic mindfulness. Cioran challenges systematic philosophical discourse to present a series of meontological dictums that allow readers to come into a mystical awareness of their complicity in the horrors of existence. For Cioran, horror is tied directly to existence, a paradox that is as much cosmic as it is human. In opposition to identifying with oneself as oneself, his fragments and aphorisms position readers in a marginal space between being and non-being. Cioran's work forms a bridge between mysticism and non-philosophical thinking as it forms a way to recuperate what is lost in one's existence through what is paradoxically gained vis-à-vis non-existence.

The afterword, "The Mystical Death of the Speculative Critic," returns to the question of ethics—or lack thereof—that is raised toward the end of chapter 4. In a concise reflection connecting the question of ethics to

the notion of mystical death, we will note that there are limits to both criticism and weird mysticism. As a literary mode, weird mysticism often utilizes the identifiable narrative technique of mystical auto-commentary, yet it can also be considered a genre of writing, or category of literary composition (i.e., the mystical text). But we will also posit that these limits might be overcome by focusing on how performing an "apophatic weird criticism" of this sort is a kind of mystical death in and of itself, wherein the apophatic critic annihilates herself via weird criticism. Thus we will posit just how a mystical death as such (i.e., the mystical death of the weird critic) might add to future research on the nexus of mysticism, pessimism, and horror by being a form of criticism that becomes what it describes, potentially speculatively opening thought to a limitlessness un-inhered by its own anarcho-mystical liberation via the mystical death of the one-who-thinks.

And, finally, a quick note on the aims of the critical reading method deployed throughout this book. The weird mysticism(s) found herein might also be said to cast a kind of shadow, or better yet, a "cloud of unknowing," to borrow a key phrase from the medieval text, over their reading publics. Haziness ensues, as is the cloud's wont, and readers are left to find their way through the haze. To recuperate formal analyses from the works of Ligotti, Bataille, and Cioran, then, the critical reading method and/or mode of criticism deployed in this book seeks a hand in operationalizing the darkness, if you will, to pierce the cloud in its utmost anarcho-mystical capacity to essentially, but not without critical rigor, *see what happens*.

ONE
Piercing the Cosmological Horizon

ANATOMY OF A PORTMANTEAU TERM

In his two-volume anthology entitled *What Cannot Be Said: Apophatic Discourses in Philosophy, Religion, Literature and the Arts* (2007), William Franke theoretically frames apophasis, the mystical language of no-saying, as both a mode of discourse and a genre. By tracing its usage beginning with Platonic and Neoplatonic commentaries, moving through a corpus of medieval mysticisms, and into its post-medieval usage in modern poetry and philosophy, he notes that the apophatic tradition maintains a vested interest in discoursing on the ineffable. Keeping in mind Franke's double theoretical framework, the notion of negativity as both a genre and a mode of discourse will percolate this book. In short, what is of interest to us here is how certain aspects of medieval mysticism, specifically the logic of negation found in the apophatic tradition, make their way into modern horror fiction and philosophy. Modern horror fiction deploys a peculiar use of negation in narrative language; for instance, in the tradition of supernatural or "weird fiction" initiated by H. P. Lovecraft. Soon we will find that Thomas Ligotti deploys apophatic logic as he works both within and without the Lovecraftian tradition. We also find aspects of medieval mysticism in the heterogeneous philosophical project of Georges Bataille, which contains works of speculative fiction, and in modern philosophy, specifically in the aphoristic work of E. M. Cioran. As we think about the logic of negation in the apophatic tradition's use of language, an important question arises that will be central to our understanding of these three modern writers. Simply put, it is: What can this negative logic do that affirmative logic cannot?[1] In the spirit of Clarice Lispector's Angela Pralini, who writes that "the only thing that interests me is what cannot be thought—whatever can be thought is too little for

me" (*A Breath of Life* 97), we will attempt to answer this question by showing that what negativity can do—precisely through what it does *not* do or show—is give us a way to think about the unthinkable. Negative logic allows us to speculate about what is not in this world or, conversely, what is in this world but cannot be readily seen, and in these ways the "labor of the negative," as Benjamin Noys calls it, holds a productive quality.[2]

An interconnection of apophatic discourse, philosophical fragments, and the horrors of individuation distinguishes the work of Ligotti, Bataille, and Cioran. Thus, for the purposes of this book, these three authors are gathered among one another utilizing a tripartite rubric: a) philosophical pessimism, b) derivation or deviation from traditional mysticism, and c) a direct engagement with or indirect relation to modern horror fiction. Recognizing that each author's speculative writings simultaneously shape and are shaped by this tripartite rubric, we will now also posit that "weird mysticism," as we will call it, *is a praxis*, not a central feature adjacent to a praxis. Thus, weird mysticism, as praxis, propels and is propelled by a very peculiar authorial attitude/impetus and is enacted via the experience of a limit. This praxis at once denies formality by bringing readers to a crucial limit-moment that resists theorization yet sees this very limit-experience as fodder *for* theoretical speculation. Being that this tripartite rubric deals with a nexus of mysticism, philosophy, and horror, it is important to deploy a term, which also serves as the book's title, that attempts to account for the interdisciplinary relations found in this nexus. It is the mystical repository for a ficto-philosophical coincidentia oppositorum, a portmanteau term we will henceforth call *weird mysticism*.

The term "weird mysticism" is an allusion to a notion Allan Stoekl gestures toward in his book *Bataille's Peak* (2007), wherein he writes that Georges Bataille was unable "to separate entirely materialism from a 'weird mysticism'" (208). Aside from deploying the term in a content note on Bataille's relation to the work of Giordano Bruno, Stoekl does not go on to define the term. Nor does he perhaps hope that it imbues his remarkable book with anything more than a passing significance. We will briefly return to Stoekl's reading of Bataille in chapter 3, but for now let it suffice to say that his deployment of the term evokes an insightful moment that merits some further consideration. What comes to mind when one thinks of a "weird mysticism"? Obviously, the modifier "weird" seeks to signify a superlative or at least different level of strangeness. But is not mysticism itself *sufficiently* strange? If the term serves to qualify or typify, and with one adjectival swipe of the pen ushers mysticism into a new generic realm, then perhaps this point of departure is also a semantic juncture, an opportunity to unite and contextualize mysticism within an entirely different tradition altogether, what is commonly referred to as "the weird."

In order to frame these introductory remarks more fully, perhaps this is a good time to define the two words in our portmanteau term. Let us begin with the first word, "weird." Etymologically speaking, the term "weird" is synonymous with becoming. In her essay entitled "Weird Reading," Eileen Joy notes that "the word 'weird' (traditionally related to 'wyrd,' or 'fate') is related to the Old English weorðan ['to become'], rooted in Indo-European *wer- ['to turn, bend']" (30). "Weird," as we use it here, places emphasis on "becoming." For our purposes in this book, this becoming will be explicitly associated with individuation, the transformation in consciousness one undergoes to become more fully human. Thus, individuation is the ultimate weird, the fateful process or means by which one becomes oneself. And by this, we can also highlight our common understanding of the term "weird," in that the process of individuation is inherently strange and off-putting. In *The Weird and Eerie* (2016), for instance, Mark Fisher, observing how the weird is fundamentally tied to the Outside, remarks that "the concept of fate is weird in that it implies twisted forms of time and causality that are alien to perception" (12). The very fact of being oneself, then, becomes an uncanny experience of finding the Outside *in* oneself and vice versa, a haunting alienness which suggests that being human is contingent on its own inhumanness, resulting in an *excess* of humanity.

Typically understood, the second term, "mysticism," means the process or act through which a person seeks to attain union with the divine.[3] In *Mystics: Presence and Aporia* (2003), Michael Kessler and Christian Sheppard, following Bernard McGinn, note that mysticism is the component in Christian and other religious traditions "that concerns the preparation for, the attainment of, and the effect of what is described as an immediately conscious 'presence' of God (often presence realized in absence). This 'presence realized in absence,' this aporia, has its discursive analogue in the aporetic moment thought through by negative theology" (viii). Thus, if we combine the two terms, with individuation as the ultimate "weird" on the one side, and the particularly negative theological understanding of mysticism, emphasized by Kessler and Shephard as being the "presence realized in absence" of God on the other, then we find in this merging a kind of weird individuation that is specific to the living out of a mystical life.

To recap, by placing emphasis on the term "weird" as "becoming," individuation being the ultimate weird, and by subsequently individuat*ing* vis-à-vis the life of the mystic (i.e., via the apophatic or negative theological aporia of presence through absence), then we find in the merging of these two terms an etymological ground for "weird mysticism." For the sake of this book, then, let us posit the term *weird mysticism* as a portmanteau term with which we seek to describe a writerly impetus to wander through the auto-blackening landscape of negativity in order to fully become oneself through one's own negation. Our interest in "the

weird" is thus vested as much etymologically as it will be generically.[4] In other words, we will not be making the argument that Georges Bataille, for example, is writing weird fiction in the tradition developed by Lovecraft, but rather that his fictions are written in the etymological spirit of the weird. In this sense, Bataille's anti-philosophy itself becomes a kind of speculative fiction, and a weird one at that, which might best be described as the fulfillment of an effort to challenge the lines between theory and literature. We will come back to this very point in chapter 3.

Being that this book does in some ways resemble a genre study, however, and being that weird mysticism is a form of writing, we can also posit a generic definition of weird mysticism that reads as follows. Weird mysticism is an anti-genre, a genre that's precipitating and essential main feature is that it negates itself as genre. As such, it is a category of literary composition that's distinguishing characteristic is to in-distinguish, that is, to elude categorization. This aporetic or puzzling characteristic blurs lines of genre discourse and yet speculatively opens a new way to think about traditional mysticism and the long tradition of "the weird." S. T. Joshi describes the weird tale as the result of the "philosophical and aesthetic predispositions" of its author (6), serving as a compositional site to attempt synthesis between what is human and non-human. The writers and texts addressed in this book, which tend to merge immediately recognizable "philosophical and aesthetic predispositions" with mystical themes and approaches to writing, have a disturbing, uncanny quality to them, one which stems from being in the midst of a "cloud of unknowing" or preternatural mist, the result of an impossible desire to find oneness with the absolute. The affectively off-kilter tone and approach utilized by these authors is often the effect of a horrifying, atmospheric midst/mist characteristic of the tension between the material and the mystical. As such, the act of writing, the heart of weird mysticism, becomes an ontological hesitation that blurs the boundary between self and world, creating a third space which opens to the abyss.

What will not be argued in this book is that the mystical and weird traditions are—or do—the same thing. But they are strange bedfellows—sharing tropes in the double sense of "motif" and also having a certain affinity for changing or "turning" in the Classical sense (trope, from the Greek *trapein*, "to turn")—and will be analyzed as such. By teasing out relations among them, we will argue that each concept at once attracts and negates the other, divulging a relation that takes place in contradiction. In this way, Ligotti, Bataille, and Cioran's texts are neither purely weird nor mystical, but rather accelerate to its unknowable brink what happens at the very contradictory point of encounter between them. Just as Johannes de Silentio, the pseudonymous author of Kierkegaard's *Fear and Trembling*, notes the realm of contradiction between the "knight of faith," who is completely able to embrace life, and the "knight of resignation," who resides in a place of terrible alienation, we too, as readers of

these texts, must dwell in that realm. But, as weird readers, we will find that the realm of contradiction, even in its terrible alienation, is also beneficent, for its own very being unhinges the nature of constraint and inverts what holds us down into the very manner of its opposite, mystical liberation.

Now that we have defined this portmanteau term, we can sketch an anatomy of weird mysticism that attempts to account for the paradox to which Allan Stoekl refers to above in which he notices in Bataille a writerly wavering between materiality and mysticism.[5] To do this, we must first acknowledge weird mysticism's shadow-like, inherently palpable or textual dimension, its *weird materiality*, if you will, by localizing its mode of production, writing. The act of writing does indeed have an irreducibly textual dimension to it and corresponds to a writing process or the acts and behaviors that correspond to a text's composition and corollary dissemination to a writing public via different media. With this said, the material dimension mentioned here is ultimately problematized when it comes into view with mysticism. On the one hand, mystical texts would not exist without their materiality as texts. On the other hand, mysticism itself is contingent on and yet obliterates relations on the material plane. A fine example of this paradox is perhaps one's own living, breathing self. Embodiment, the conundrum which holds the mystic away from and yet spurs union with the divine, is the ultimate and inevitable paradox for the mystic. And individuation, perhaps best expressed via the words of H. P. Lovecraft's terribly lonely Outsider when he remarks, "Such a lot the gods gave to me—to me, the dazed, the disappointed; the barren, the broken" ("The Outsider" 43), serves as the ultimate weird, the baffling process whereby one becomes oneself. Hence this book will seek mainly to account for writing's essential *non-locality*, or rather, the way in which the mystical dimension of writing eschews or annihilates this textual dimension via its own negativity. This writerly aporia is the nihilistic hinge upon which weird mysticism swings, where writing itself is simultaneously writing's own secret, eviscerating double—the limit point at which writing negates itself as writing and itself becomes mystical.

Writing as such utilizes the language of an apophatic self, a bewildered and unknowing self that seeks to say the unsayable. Mary-Jane Rubenstein writes,

> The apophatic self, marked by an endless desire to represent that which she cannot represent, is thus marked by a certain absence—but also by an excess of presence, which constantly unspeaks her speech and speaks through her silence. Always interrupted and undone, "mystical speech" has no proper subject or object, and can only emerge through a full abandonment of the speaking self and spoken God. (396)

What is this apophatic self, this voice that flows through despite itself via a style of writing that utilizes the logic of negativity? This apophatic voice

is strangely a thing-that-should-not-be that endeavors to speak in unsaying tidbits of the horror of letting go of itself in order to reach divinity. On the production of a negative mode of being such as this, Clarice Lispector's mystic narrator in *The Passion According to G. H.* (1964) comes to mind, who puts it this way: "I was the image of what I was not, and that image of not-being overwhelmed me: one of the most powerful states is being negatively. Since I didn't know what I was, 'not being' was the closest I could get to the truth: at least I had the other side: I at least had the 'not,' I had my opposite" (23). The inversion established in this state of "being negatively" can be correlated to the traditional idea exhibited in the Latin phrase of *coincidentia oppositorum*, or the coincidence of opposites. Deployed in Nicolas of Cusa's famous fifteenth-century essay entitled *De Docta Ignorantia*, this Neoplatonic idea primacies the union of opposites, a mystical doctrine used to merge two contradictory attributes—human reason with that which is beyond reason—in order to know God.

To elaborate on Lispector's formulation of being negatively, let us take, for example, the economy of a rainstick. A rainstick is now commonly known for its use as a percussion instrument but has its origins in ancient Aztec culture where it was believed to hold the power to bring rain. A person holds a rainstick by grasping it in the middle and can tilt it in either direction, right or left. In order to trace the economy of both sides of this rainstick, then, let us say, by way of analogy, that on one side, or pole, of this rainstick is pain—specifically the *affective* pains or discomforts which come with one's existential predicament of being alive. On this side of the rainstick, then, is the affective pain a person undergoes in life, consisting of their sorrow and emotional turmoil. If all one knows is this pain and suffering, then the weight of this suffering will force that side of the rainstick to fall to that one side, becoming vertical or nearly vertical. But let us now imagine what is on the opposite end of the rainstick. On the opposite side of the rainstick is thus the opposite of affective pain. Let us call it joy. So, no matter how far down the weight of pain holds one side of the rainstick down, the other side will simultaneously experience, in equal measure, the exact opposite of pain, or pain's negative, joy.

Thus, if we take this rainstick as a metaphor for the economy between being and human affect, then the more pain one experiences in one's life equals the more joy they are actually capable of experiencing by being negatively. The experience of joy corresponds to the content and form of the opposite of pain.[6] Hence, understanding the horror of life is actually its profound mystical beauty and Truth; to realize that one is suffering by being oneself is to realize the opposite joy that one can undo oneself. Or, as Lispector's narrator G. H. puts it, "Painstakingly not-being, I was proving to myself that—that I was" (24). The mystical paradox of this formulation is that the mystic can and will experience both extreme sides

of the rainstick yet does so in such a way that she does not identify with either joy or pain, but rather becomes the hand in the middle which holds the rainstick itself, the impossible hinge through which a soft balance is not only possible but transcends its own possibility/non-possibility.[7] As Giorgio Agamben says of the single factical root of sorrow and joy: "The root of all pure joy and sadness is that the world is as it is" (*The Coming Community* 90). Here Agamben provides an ontological correlative to being negatively vis-à-vis his notion of "whatever-being." His emphasis on being in touch with the root, as opposed to being trapped by the opposition, denotes a negative mode of praxis which serves as the root of being negatively.

THE HORROR OF MYSTICISM

According to the apophatic logic exemplified in Lispector's notion of being negatively, then, the negative reciprocity of pain equates to immanently being pain's opposite. In the case of the rainstick formulation, "inversion" has a double meaning. In one way it implies that the mystic, following the hermetic maxim "as above, so below," inverts things upside-down. In another way, the mystic can be said to invert the self/world dichotomy inside-out. This inside-out inversion, to follow Rudolf Steiner, "re-establishes reality."[8] We can also apply this negative logic to another coincidence of opposites—on the one side, divine horror and, on the other side, mystical union or enlightenment. If one is indeed in touch with the root, so to speak, as opposed to being stuck in the opposition, then the difference between horror and enlightenment vis-à-vis mystical inversion is that there really is no difference. This idea is indeed the paradox of mystical negativity, the polar economy of the rainstick, in this case, of horror and enlightenment. In order to frame these remarks about the relation between horror and mysticism more fully, let us analyze two examples, one being from the premodern (or medieval) period and the other being from the modern period.

The role of terror and horror holds a role in premodern mysticism, finding expression, for example, in Hadewijch, the thirteenth-century Beguine mystic known for her love poems and prose letters. Hadewijch, whose writings were rediscovered only in 1838, emphasizes a living union with God through Love, the medium through which He lets himself be experienced. In Letter 13, "Love Unappeasable," Hadewijch writes,

> What satisfies Love best of all is that we be wholly destitute of all repose. . . . And this is a frightening life Love wants, that we must do without the satisfaction of Love in order to satisfy Love. They who are thus drawn and accepted by Love, and fettered by her, are the most indebted to Love, and consequently they must continually stand sub-

> ject to the great power of her strong nature, to content her. And that life is miserable beyond all that the human heart can bear. (75)

Keeping in mind our rainstick formulation, Hadewijch emphasizes a kind of spiritual pessimism in which divine Love remains unsatisfied or, rather, is satisfied only through its non-satisfaction. The life of Love is one filled with terror/horror, a life in which Love must be done without in order to realize divine union with Love. In this way, existence itself becomes ineffable. Hadewijch, who stresses the importance of non-ecstatic states, teaches that a life lived negatively in divine horror is the same life which, in the spiritual realm, fills one with Love. This aporia, or radical contradiction, is essential to a spiritual life lived in (i.e., without) Love. Hence weakness, which unveils strength's nothingness, is true strength, while terror and horror, or the miserable life lived via a non-ecstatic mysticism, paradoxically sharpen one's spiritual faculties.[9]

The example of Hadewijch's love poetry is indicative of a lived horror which replaces Love's fulfillment with its absence, thereby insisting on the "frightening life" wanted by Love. Her love poetry is slightly more existential and thus less semantically apophatic than mystics such as Marguerite Porete or Meister Eckhart, who replace actual lived horror with its divine unsaying. However, writing is an important and invariably necessary component for each of them. As Amy Hollywood points out, "Hadewijch, Porete, and Eckhart each (re)enact through their writing the experience of divine presence and absence and attempt to engender such experience in their readers" (*Sensible Ecstasy* 98). Their writings represent a central problematic found in traditional mysticism, which is the impossibility of human language to describe union with the divine. The attempt to attain God-consciousness is largely an ineffable matter, and typically one has not the words to describe what is or constitutes God. Thus, one way to describe God is to describe what He is not. Apophasis, a Greek word meaning "to speak away," is used in order to semantically represent their mystical union with divinity or horror that, remaining outside the realm of so-called human experience, is often regarded as ineffable. In this apophatic logic, we find what Michael T. Sells terms a "meaning event," "the semantic analogue to the experience of mystical union" (9), an anarchic and nihilistic moment, performative in its negation, which conjures union with divine nothingness—nothingness in this case being pureness or emptiness devoid of mind/ego.

Similarly, the terror/horror of mystical life is evidenced in modern mystical texts. One modern mystic whose writings blur the divisions between self and world by using apophatic logic is Simone Weil, the twentieth-century French philosopher and self-exiled Christian mystic, who expressed in her life and work revolutionary convictions of the extreme left. In *Gravity and Grace* (1947), for example, Weil writes, "I must love being nothing. How horrible it would be if I were something! I must

love my nothingness, love being a nothingness. I must love with that part of the soul which is on the other side of the curtain, for the part of the soul which is perceptible to consciousness cannot love nothingness. It has a horror of it. Though it may think it loves nothingness, what it really loves is something other than nothingness" (111). Weil speaks here of an inverse horror, the horror that persists in the face of loving something *other* than imperceptible nothingness.

In *Gravity and Grace*, Weil's conception of God revolves around two key terms. Gravity is the fundamental law that draws human beings away from God through the act of creation. Grace is that which "decreates" us; it is an act of humility on the part of God that allows human beings to find Him again. For Weil, the act of seeking God requires kenosis, or "self-emptying," a process wherein one must accept all the wounds of life, all emptiness, in order to receive grace and thereby gain union with God. Bernard McGinn notes, "In a more modern vein . . . Weil has expressed it thus: 'Contact with human creatures is given us through the sense of presence. Contact with God is us through the sense of absence. Compared with this absence, presence becomes more absent that absence'" (xix). One might think a thing and its opposite much in the same way one might think of the negative of a photograph: the positive image is revealed as we normally would see it, whereas the negative image contains the total inversion of the positive one. Weil's apophatic mysticism of decreation works via this series of negations. Framed in this way, the rhetorical Neoplatonic distanciations Weil makes between creaturely being and God are particular to her use of apophatic logic. Our brief analysis of the horror/terror of mysticism will be more fully explored in coming chapters. But for now, let if suffice to say that the mystical potency of apophatic logic lies not in what it recuperates from the human being's experience of divine union but precisely in what it cannot do, which is express the experience of this union in positive terms, thereby revealing a veritable limit to human thought.

THE MYSTICISM OF HORROR

The limit or failure of thought to positively conceive of the divine that is expressed in apophatic mysticism correlates to a similar form of thought-failure exhibited in genre horror. Just as apophatic mysticism problematizes anthropocentric views of Reality, genre horror, specifically the early twentieth-century tradition of weird fiction, problematizes concepts of life[10] and notes the limits of language when attempting to describe the indescribable. The work of H. P. Lovecraft, arguably the most famous writer in this genre, effectively instigates a blurring between subject and object, ancient and new, human and non-human. In the case of his 1921

poem, "Ex Oblivione," an unnamed narrator, at the moment of his mystical death, proclaims,

> as the gate swung wider and the sorcery of the drug and the dream pushed me through, I knew that all sights and glories were at an end; for in that new realm was neither land nor sea, but only the white void of unpeopled and illimitable space. So, happier than I had ever dared hope to be, I dissolved again into that native infinity and crystal oblivion from which the daemon Life had called me for one brief and desolate hour. (2)

This unnamed narrator is of course speaking about death from a place beyond death, where he ethereally drifts between the flux and flow of what is human and non-human, dissolving into infinity. In this poem, not only do readers get a sense that the narrator finds this non-place pleasant but that he has perhaps been there before, in a time before time, a time before life-as-*we*-know-it. With this, one might strongly wonder about literature and writing, about what particular roles inscription and textuality play in this apophasis. And what role does the reader play?

Yet regardless of the narrator's sense of ubiquity, a reader's understanding of this actual state of non- or beyond-being might be that it seems markedly other, a frame of reference located outside of conventional human understanding. Lovecraft's blend of horror fiction, one that blurs the boundaries between epistemological and experiential knowledge, refuses to give readers closure. One likely cannot say that she knows this place of "native infinity and crystal oblivion" or even that it is comprehensible. At best, we can associate certain things we do know about this world and project them onto the other one, the one which is beyond our comprehension—such is the task of language. But in this case, positive language would ultimately fail. Lovecraft, in his highly sophisticated prose, evokes an esoteric sagacity that points back on itself toward the failure of human thought. Ironically, his prose beckons us: inquisitive readers may wish to be there, in the non-place, with the unnamed narrator, to partake in his notion of limitlessness. This invites us to consider a more general set of problems: Just what is the ineffable? How does one access it? In what ways does this negative logic resemble that of apophatic mysticism? How does writing itself function as apophasis?

If medieval darkness mystics can be said to deal with the horror of apophasis, then certain elements of Lovecraft's work, particularly his peculiar use of negation in narrative language, could be said to deal with the apophasis of horror, a negative logic or language that attempts to describe the incomprehensible horror of confronting a non-human realm, the Outside. Although Lovecraft was a strident atheist and would not have considered himself a mystic in the traditional sense of the term, he often utilized apophatic writing techniques in his work. Let us take, for

example, "The Horror in the Museum." In this short story co-written with Hazel Heald, a character named Jones is killed by Rogers, the owner of a grotesque wax museum who is then also killed by one of Lovecraft's infamous Elder Gods, Rhan-Tegoth, and ironically turned into a display at the museum. Lovecraft and Heald write that

> To describe it with any ordinary vocabulary would be impossible, for nothing even roughly corresponding to it has ever come within the imagination of sane mankind. It represented something meant perhaps to be roughly connected with the vertebrates of this planet—though one could not be too sure of that. Its bulk was Cyclopean. . . . To say that such a thing could have an expression seems paradoxical; yet Jones felt that that triangle of bulging fish-eyes and that obliquely poised proboscis all bespoke a blend of hate, greed, and sheer cruelty incomprehensible to mankind because mixed with other emotions not of the world or this solar system. (135)

Finding that ordinary or positive language fails to describe this monstrous creature,[11] the narrator's language deploys a peculiar use of negation that attempts to describe this entity that can hardly be comprehended. Here we find, for instance, a poised moment of contemplation that suspends the narrative movement.

In the coming chapters, we will analyze how Ligotti, Bataille, and Cioran will morph both the traditionally mystical and Lovecraftian uses of apophatic logic to argue, in part, that the horrors of the divine and the Outside are horrors that are contingent on and informed by something that remains simultaneously and insidiously inside: one's individuation. Weird mysticism comments on a very particular type of individuation, a "dark night of the soul" at once liberating and horrific. To confront the horror of individuation, one must ultimately first admit and acknowledge, following E. M. Cioran in *The Trouble with Being Born* (1973), that we ourselves may well have invited—or be—the very monster that lurks in the room: "A monster, however horrible, secretly attracts us, pursues us, haunts us. He represents, enlarged, our advantages and our miseries, he proclaims us, he is our standard-bearer" (105). One cannot be *no one* without first being someone, and we are thus tied to our own fallible human natures. Only by contemplatively working through these faulty human natures, by removing them via moving backwardly out of them, can humans get to a place, which is a non-place, where to unknow oneself is to *move through* oneself. Our failures, it seems, are the first and only place to begin. Understood in this way, to think the unhuman is an essentially *humanistic*—perhaps even an ethical—endeavor.

Oddly enough, then, apophatic thinking and being negatively make one more fully human in the sense that this more fully human being brings one, as no one, closer to what Quentin Meillassoux calls "the great outdoors, the absolute outside of pre-critical thinkers: that outside which

was not relative to us, and which was given as indifferent to its own givenness to be what it is, existing in itself regardless of whether we are thinking of it or not" (7). *Thinking no one* in part means to restore oneself back to the pre-dialectical realm of self-knowledge, which is the space of the pure observation of thinking without taking action or attributing consequences to one's thoughts. The further one individuates the more oneself one becomes, which is often baffling, bewildering. There is also an inherent link here to the dialectical relationship between reading and writing, both of which are quite similar to this process of individuation. Moreover, Nicola Masciandaro sees the problem of individuation as such: "*As though foreign to it, absolutely foreign*. I am not an alien, but something stranger still, an insider whose essence is to actually be a virtual absolute outsider. The hellishly real impossibility that you are you is the true stupidity according to which the absolute is alone thinkable" ("Absolute Secrecy: On the Infinity of Individuation"). Put yet another way, the horror of individuation becomes one's negative call to spiritual awakening, a call to greatness which is actually the paradoxical call for self-dissolution.

Hence the horror with which one is plagued, that contemplative horror which prescribes the death of the self as individuation's own autofulfilling rite of passage, is the same and the earnest horror that actually brings one closer to accessing the absolute via their own negation. In this way, one can only think the absolute through the impossible conduit of horror itself: individuation is the perplexing instrument with which horror operationalizes and through which one becomes oneself. The horror of individuation, the horror of becoming oneself by leaving one's self, then, suggests a revelatory or epiphanic nature via its own doubleness. For the *real* horror is always reserved for those who remain ignorant of this mystical horror; who stay themselves without ever experiencing the intensity and corollary contentment of not being, or unknowing, themselves. This notion bridges with what Masciandaro in *Sufficient Unto the Day* calls "apophatic humanism," what "holds, has always held, the future of humanism: unknowing" (111), which is also to say, that unknowing is the only way for human beings to become *fully* human. Keeping this in mind, the epidemic horror of the masses, those who resist mystically becoming what they always already are via unknowing who and what they think they are but fail to see or ignore in order stay themselves, becomes the real horror of the world.

The central task of negation is a practical one and yet often derided as merely pessimistic. But what if pessimism is the true form of optimism, the strange non-delight in coming to know absolutely nothing; that, in a world with absolutely no hope,[12] there is actually nothing that can harm anyone? (Rather like writing itself.) To understand this point is to know that when (and only when) one has absolutely no expectations, never expects anything from anyone, then, and only then, can one expect every-

thing absolutely. By being negatively, a person becomes independent of their suffering. They may still take action, but their actions have no perceivable consequences because they have not set themselves up for the inevitable failure which secretly lurks in their desires. Being negatively, their actions are thus inconsequential in the sense that they already possess their nothingness; there is nothing to be gained and nothing to be lost. They are, in a sense, cosmic clay. Or, to use another figure, *writers*. Nothingness is pessimistic non-fulfillment, the aporetic un-container in which everything has already been acquired.

AN ABYSSAL COSMIC TWIST

Consequently, readers can think of weird mysticism in the most radical sense, in a sense which asks us, via being negatively, to hearken back to the ways of cosmic clay. To do so is to "recognize," as Reza Negarestani writes, "the abyssal cosmic twist that has given birth to her [the philosopher's] speculation and to adopt the cosmic perspective as the only viable commitment to reality," to cultivate an awareness that "speculation is not driven by our grounded experience or reflection but by the exteriority and contingency of a universe that always antedates and postdates us (that which thinks us from the other side)" (9). Taking heed of Negarestani's call to recognize this abyssal cosmic twist, the genre of weird mysticism, a genre that is by its very nature an anti-genre, contains texts which are rigorously speculative and revisionary, as they explore radical self/cosmic abysses that bear little resemblance to everyday life. The looming authorial impetus exhibited by weird mystics is to open the mind to its limit-point. By exercising their cosmically contingent creative organs, these writers exorcise society of conventional, anthropocentric reading methods—they are, in a way, *getting weird*, in the same way that Theodor Adorno might say we need to *think musically*. In this way, negativity vis-à-vis weird mysticism becomes a radical sub- or anti-culture of thought, a mode of thought that negates itself as thinking. To get to Reality, so-called, the weird mystic thinks by unthinking. In other words, it represents what a Westernized version of "martyring the self to get to Self" might look like.

Negativity, as such, is important to theory because it speculatively cultivates a mode of unthinking through which the human being undelivers oneself to oneself and comes closer to thinking a world not-according-to-us. As we will see, there are several ways that the logic of negativity is deployed to achieve such ends, namely three schools of thought that hold a close relation to one another—and sometimes overlap—on this front: the weird, apophatic mysticism, and philosophical pessimism. These three negative pathways ultimately become mystical roads to nowhere, to being negatively. But this is not to say that they are

merely roads to nowhere. In other words, the nihilism exhibited on these negative paths negates even itself.[13] This book calls for a revaluation of negativity that is not affirmative, per se, but rather productive or *creative*: "The essence of pure mysticism is creative activity. One becomes a mystic when one dares to elevate oneself—i.e. 'to stand upright', then even more upright, and ever more upright—beyond all created being as far as the essence of Being, the divine, creative fire" (*Meditations on the Tarot* 40–41). Here we stress a meaning of creativity not in the sense that it adds to what is not there, but rather in the aporetic sense that the essence of what is not there is indeed everything. Thus, weird mysticism indexes (i.e., the blurred boundary among pessimism, apophasis, and horror) and upholds negativity as its own without-end.

The principle aims of the remaining chapters, then, will be to look specifically at modern works in which this nexus of horror, apophatic logic, and philosophical pessimism happen not as singularities but as the interlocking hinges of a triumvirate or negative triptych, in short, what we have chosen to call *weird mysticism*. Against the risk of becoming just another narcissistic fabler, each author strives to speculatively open the rational to the unreasonable, that is, conjures ways to think about the unthinkable. Each author practices a writing that challenges conventional understandings of representation, communication, and aesthetics. They work at the polar limits of a paradoxical gap between what is "believed" to be human and what is inhuman (meaning in some cases, *fully* human),[14] between what can be known and what is unknowable. Just as the medieval author of *The Cloud of Unknowing* was met with a preternatural midst/mist that blurred the correlation between divine union and human understanding, these authors reminisce upon, discover, or aim to cross the limits of thought vis-à-vis non-experiences of the absolute.

Functioning as the literary expiation of a kenotic perversion, weird mysticism dutifully expresses themes of emptiness and excess. It arises from a threefold structure: the result of spiritual affliction and/or affiliation; in the midst of psychic oppression; and from a "cloud of unknowing" or preternatural mist, the result of an impossible desire to find or share in oneness with the absolute. The latter two elements form a horrific synergy, an atmospheric midst/mist characteristic of the tension between the material and the mystical, implicating the act of "writing" itself as the alien in the room—and perhaps the *way out*—via our very own facticity.

It also operates as the site of a particularly Lovecraftian inexplicability, negating any correlation between human thought and what is actually real. In the latter statement, what is real need not necessarily be human at all. In *Weird Realism*, for instance, Graham Harman notes the Kantian side of Lovecraft's writing, arguing that "Lovecraft's prose generates a gap between reality and its accessibility to us," but also notes a "new gap within appearance itself" (28). The latter allows Lovecraft's main stylistic

technique of "the separation and object from its qualities" to shine through, enabling him to denote his infamous alien lifeforms and maddening Great Old Ones.

Building on Harman's inventive formulation of "Lovecraftian ontography," we will go on to argue, in part, that "the weird" operates doubly as the site of a particularly Lovecraftian and mystical inexplicability. Founded at the cusp of a cosmic abyss, then, the act of writing, the heart of weird mysticism, as it blurs the distinction between materialism and mysticism, is an ontological hesitation or acosmic third space created by its author in order to think the abyss beyond the correlation between self and world. Mystical writing is thus a method of accessing the beyond (without a reliance on subject/object correlation).

As we will discover, Ligotti, Bataille, and Cioran, as they intentionally blur the lines among horror fiction, mystical text, and theory-fiction treatise, are fine candidates for speculative study of this sort, as they tend to both conjoin and obscure a link between traditional mysticism and philosophical horror fiction. Such writing in many ways foreshadows the "speculative turn" in continental philosophy, characterized by its return to "the great outdoors, the absolute outside of pre-critical thinkers" referenced by Meillasoux (7). As we attempt to probe deeper into this outside, always from the inside, we find an authorial impetus to blur the distinction between the correlation between self and world, thus generating a way to draft a map (or representation) of a world-without-us, even if we are unsure as to the fields of its territory. As such, this book endeavors to speak to one of the central questions Eugene Thacker poses in his book *In the Dust of this Planet*, to see if we are capable to propose "a new darkness mysticism, a mysticism of the unhuman, which is really another way of thinking about a mysticism of the 'without-us,' or really, a dark mysticism of the world-in-itself" (156). Thacker's recent work on "the horror of philosophy" is influential on this book in several ways. At the root of his work lies not an expansion of central motifs developed by writers in the horror genre, but rather what they tend to leave out, namely, the unthinkable itself, the direct intersection of horror and philosophy. Thacker's discourse on the horror of philosophy involves a certain way of thinking *through* horror *by* horror. In Thacker's formulation, supernatural horror offers readers a novel method by which to think about the unthinkable, to examine the mystical underbelly that lies underneath esoteric thought and the very liminal realms that readers of horror fiction so often confront.

We have now identified a key problematic. Obviously weird mysticism is a grotesque (or askew) mysticism, twisted to one side in order to delineate itself from traditional mysticism to the extent that it breaks generic ground. But to what extent and exactly how does this modern mysticism differ from traditional mysticism? To answer such questions, the three key authors studied in this book will be analyzed for their

refusal to accept the subject/object binary which, although fascinating in its own right, is a hindrance to thought, dislodging our ability to think in absolute terms. Hence, each writer begins under the paradoxical and horrific dilemma of trying to think the unthinkable (sometimes they are successful in this task and other times not), thereby allowing for critical acknowledgment of the absolute's very importance to human life during times of cultural, ecological, and economic crisis.

NOTES

1. This question correlates to another key problematic that is central to this book, which, following Eugene Thacker in *In the Dust of this Planet*, is: "How does one go about thinking the unthinkable?" (48).

2. Benjamin Noys opens *The Persistence of the Negative* (2012), his original and incisive critique of the state of contemporary continental theory, by challenging the affinity of present-day theory to rely on affirmation in ontological and political discourses of resistance. Noys challenges affirmative thinking by revealing the often overlooked and essential, if not essentially paradoxical, productivity that remains latent until it is realized and released through the "labor of the negative." According to this critique, then, there is a sense that returning to or ultimately revealing the current of the negative will allow theory to make its way back to its political vocation. Though we will not delve into particularly political analyses herein, this book shares a passion in helping to reorient contemporary critical theory to negative thinking.

3. Moreover, in her erudite work *Mysticism: A Study of the Nature and Development of Spiritual Consciousness* (1911), Evelyn Underhill writes, "In mysticism that love of truth which we saw as the beginning of all philosophy leaves the merely intellectual sphere, and takes on the assured aspect of a personal passion. Where the philosopher guesses and argues, the mystic lives and looks; and speaks, consequently, the disconcerting language of first-hand experience, not the neat dialectic of the schools. Hence whilst the Absolute of the metaphysicians remains a diagram —impersonal and unattainable—the Absolute of the mystics is lovable, attainable, alive" (23).

4. We will try to take due care when speaking about the literary genre of weird fiction, specifically in the next chapter on Thomas Ligotti.

5. One might note an analogical rift between materiality/immateriality observed by H. P. Lovecraft's narrator in "Beyond the Wall of Sleep": "Sometimes I believe that this less material life is our truer life, and that our vain presence on the terraqueous globe is itself the secondary or merely virtual phenomenon" (51).

6. Angela of Foligno explains how struggle and torment work to purify the soul. In the *Memorial*, she dictated that she "became aware that the more a soul is laid low, abased, impoverished, and thoroughly humiliated, the more it is prepared, purged, and purified for a greater elevation. For the extent of the soul's elevation corresponds to the content of its humiliation and abasement" (202).

7. On the idea of synthesizing the polarity of two disparate sides—the inner and outer worlds—of the mystic's existence, Sri Aurobindo writes of a similar phenomenon: "It is tempting to regard [the outer world] as only a contradiction of the Divine, an incomprehensible mystery-play, masque or travesty of the Infinite–and so it irresistibly seems to his experience at times, on one side the luminous verity of Brahman, on the other a dark illusion or Maya. But something in him will not allow him to cut existence thus permanently in two and, looking more closely, he discovers that in this half-light or darkness too is the Eternal—it is the Brahman who is here with this face of Maya" (112).

8. Steiner formulates this inside-out inversion as such: "Our very presence in the world divides it for us into a world of percepts and a world of ideas. Anyone who

accepts this division as absolute and says, 'There is the world and here am I,' will never be able to get over into the phenomenal world with his ideas. But the facts are as follows. I look at the phenomenal world and see it everywhere incomplete and lacking something. But I myself, with my whole existence, once came out of the very same universe of which the world of percepts is also part. Now I look inside myself, and what this enables me to see is just what is missing in the phenomenal world. I must put together again with my own effort the wholeness that was split in two by my ego's appearance on the scene. My effort re-establishes reality."

9. Cf. "The same woman who can sink in abysmal fruition is immediately placed again in herself: the human being truly dies in God, but not in order, as human being, to come to its end. One who experiences the blessed 'feeling that surpasses all things' is sent back into the world with impressionable senses and sharpened spiritual powers—'pure man like myself,' says Jesus in Visions" (Paul Mommaers, "Preface" xvi).

10. On the different forms of life found in H. P. Lovecraft's stories, see Eugene Thacker's section entitled "Supernatural Horror as the Paradigm of Life" in *After Life*.

11. Thacker notes that "the third type of life described in Lovecraft's stories is not a monster in [the] traditional sense. The Shoggoths or Elder Things do not even share the same reality with the human beings who encounter them" (*After Life* 23).

12. Keeping in mind the motif of walking through Hell as the only way to Paradise, this notion of abandoning hope has an explicitly Dantean significance. Cf. "O ye who enter, every hope resign" (*Inferno* 18).

13. Cf. Cioran in "The Mockery of a New Life": Nailed to ourselves, we lack the capacity of leaving the path inscribed in the innateness of our despair" (*A Short History of Decay* 46).

14. In the Preface to *Inner Experience*, Bataille references Nietzsche in *Ecce Homo*: "*the ideal of a human, super-human well-being and benevolence will often appear* inhuman" (xxxi).

TWO

Thomas Ligotti

The Poetics of Darkness

ALL IS UNREAL

"We may hide from horror only in the heart of horror" *(Noctuary* 17), writes Lucian Dregler, the young philosopher who appears as the protagonist in Thomas Ligotti's short story "The Medusa," a sinister tale first published in the winter 1991 edition of *Fantasy Tales*. Dregler's scholarly work focuses on the Greek mythological figure of the Medusa, the monster that, when directly gazed upon, turns her onlooker to stone. Reflecting on the ontological implications for such an onlooker, a part he himself will fatefully come to play, his work attempts to explicate the plight of one who has strayed "along the pathway to the void" only to be frozen in time and space (*Noctuary* 35). The story is infused with literary techniques associated with "weird fiction"[1] and operates as a repository for several complex philosophical concepts. As such, "The Medusa" delves into the multifarious and obscure world of dreamers, those oft-maddened wanderers of new dimensions and fates beyond the human world. Dregler's obsessive search works literally, leading him from the intellectual rigors of academic writing to the halls of decrepit basements and abandoned rooms, and metaphorically, equating the toils of his quintessentially modern existential predicament as the effect of an obscure fate. Ligotti terms this fate *macabre unreality* (*Noctuary* 12)—foremost a condition in which one's fate is auto-possessed by the horror of being itself, an impending doom forever enshrouded in mystery. This auto-possession, which connects to the idea of petrification displayed in the mythology of the Medusa, is exemplified in a gesture by Maurice Merleau-Ponty, who writes in *The Phenomenology of Perception* of a philosophical "freezing of

being" (63). Initially Dregler seeks the origin of the Medusa via movement, taking walks around the city in an effort to stumble upon her in some way, yet this search soon gives way to petrification. In the end, it is not Dregler's will that leads him to find the Medusa, but rather a freezing of his being as he comes face to face with his own contingent macabre unreality. The horror in this story thus exemplifies, following Eugene Thacker, "the moment of frozen thought, the enigmatic stillness of everything except the furtive, lurking revelation of a limit" (*Tentacles* 111), the mysterious (non-)cosmogenesis of a void coming to know itself that looms just beyond the point of his own comprehension.

As he walks the streets in search of the Medusa, Dregler is what we will call a *flâneur of the unreal*.[2] He is a figure whose being-in-the-world is intoxicated with idling about his own horizon: "For in the mind the Medusa fascinates much more than she appalls, and haunts us just *this side* of petrification. On the other side is the unthinkable, the unheard-of, that-which-should-not-be: hence, the Real" (Ligotti, *Noctuary* 36). On *this side* of the non-human boundary, Dregler hides from horror only in the heart of horror, which is to say that as a being whose own being obstructs access to the unthinkable world, and, as such, resides in a world-for-us, Dregler "evokes the world-without-us as a limit . . . a 'negative philosophy'" (Thacker 9). Dregler's horror is represented not by his fear of the unknown but rather the horror of failing to properly think it: a world *without* him.

A connection can be drawn here to the traditional, mystical intolerability of being someone, which is imperative for self-annihilation. In the early fourteenth-century mystical text *The Mirror of Simple Souls*, for example, Marguerite Porete emphasizes a particular *coincidentia oppositorum* in which the wretched soul must become nothing in order to return to divine goodness. According to Porete, a soul must first completely recognize its own wretchedness to go on "to attain the annihilation in which God and the Soul become absolutely once more" (McGinn 257). This notion of the intolerability of being someone also suggests a correlative limit within the world-without-us formulation in regard to Dregler's situation, namely that world is no less horrendous than self, and that what Reality promises is equally a "world" without worldhood.

Dregler's fateful encounter with the Medusa in the tale's final pages is the emblem of dwelling at the point of impassability between the world-for-us and the world-without-us, a place where he is inevitably turned to stone. Dregler's philosophical "freezing of being," exemplified by a literal petrification, as it were, provides us with a formulation that runs parallel to the very specificity of stone itself. First, there is the traditional connection between becoming-stone and despair. This notion is memorably formulated by Dante in the story of Count Ugolino with the phrase, "I wept not, so to stone within I grew." Ugolino's eternal damnation, it has been interpreted, is that "he is so turned to stone that he cannot read through

the real to its eternal significance" (Shoaf 197). And secondly, there is the emblematic position of stone as a rudimentary form of being. Dregler's horror narrative can also be viewed a kind of allegorical story which stonily exposes the passage of consciousness to an impossible cosmic origin point.

Traditionally speaking, narrative works well as a medium to transcribe the relationship between fiction and philosophy because it curates an inherently dialogic model between being and thinking. In other words, narrative fiction preserves a larger narrative of communication between the acts of reading and writing, setting a precedent for both creating and interpreting the world-for-us. "In the act of reading," Paul Ricoeur writes, "the receiver plays with the narrative constraints, brings about gaps, takes part in the combat between the novel and the anti-novel, and enjoys the pleasure that Roland Barthes calls the pleasure of the text" (77). When construed in this way, the acts of reading and writing that take place in narrative fiction become corollary to the philosophic acts of "hermeneutics," or interpretation, and "ontology," the study of being, or the transcription of what is-ness consists of and how it is so. Insofar as narrative fiction is a kind of storytelling which relays certain events that happen in life, it aims to meaningfully communicate experience to others. In this way, communication can be understood as the "glue" or adhesive that binds the self-world correlation.

Horror fiction, in particular, adds a new element to this narrative process, however, because it problematizes the relation between being and thinking. In doing so, horror fiction dissolves the communicative glue and deteriorates the method of adhesion of the self-world correlation. By narrativizing philosophical concepts, the character of Lucien Dregler becomes suggestive as an allegory for the modern philosopher whose challenge is "comprehending the world in which we live as both a human *and* a non-human world" (Thacker 2). On the one hand, to comprehend a non-human world might entail circumscribing a world outside of human thought. On the other hand, we ought to be careful not to lay too much weight on the preposition "outside," for to do so is to assume that "human thought" is human to begin with and not an oxymoronic term that hides its own intrinsic outsideness. One limit to human thought, then, is thinking that thought is human at all. And if one thus stretches this limit to understand the notion of thought as something that is already inherently unhuman, in other words, if we lay bare the inherent outsideness that hides within thought itself, then we see that the world-for-us is really imbued with a sense of "macabre unreality." The crux of Dregler's dilemma lies in his *inability* to think a non-human world because he has not yet understood that thought itself may not be "human" at all.

In an effort to disrupt his isolation from the unknown, his flâneury of the unreal ultimately serves "to excavate within [his] soul a chasm which

waits to be filled by a landslide of dread, an empty mold whose particular dimensions will one day manufacture the shape of [*his*] unique terror" (Ligotti 28). Dregler's "famous walks around the city" are literal and regarded among his commentators to be a habitual quirk, a way to satisfy an existential obsession (35). They are also *hauntological* walks,[3] the fleeting and enigmatic journeys of a philosopher whose thought about the non-human world sits neither between intellection nor annihilation, where the world-without-us becomes the specter that haunts thought—the horror of macabre unreality made flesh. Flâneury of the unreal, then, or, more so, the horror of a philosophy that confronts the world as unthinkable, is a parallel (or negative) reality of the weird tale. "The Medusa" provides a literary record of a philosophical attempt to think the unthinkable. It comprehends itself namely in terms of narrative, character, and metaphor, but as horror fiction it puts pressure on the self-world correlation, eroding the communicative glue with which it was initially bound. This short story suggests that, like Dregler, readers hide from horror in the heart of horror. How so? What awaits us there? As we will see, Ligottian horror fiction gives fragmentary literary commentaries in response—and equivalent—to philosophical discourse in order to account for these dark depths that exist within the blurred boundaries of self and world.

The logic of negation is among the oldest and most resolute expressions of thought. It has been utilized in Eastern mystical traditions as well as in Western philosophical pessimism and negative theology. It has also manifested within modern weird fiction,[4] especially the genre of supernatural horror. Like we mentioned in the introduction, weird fiction writers lean in favor of speculation, apophatic language, and paradox. The phenomenon has produced numberless fan magazines (*Nyctalops*, *Eldrich Tales*), anthologies, presses (*Subterranean Press*, *Centipede Press*), and professional journals (*Weird Fiction Review*). There is both irony and contradiction in the mass cultural affirmation of the negative, however, given that this popularity and fandom can be seen as a kind of religious or pseudo allegiance to the weird. Yet, even though this growing body of scholarship indicates a wide readership, for many years, supernatural horror fiction, exemplified in work by writers such as H. P. Lovecraft, Ashton Clark Smith, Lord Dunsany, and others, was a largely ignored subject of philosophical investigation. We noted previously that narrative fiction sets a precedent for thinking the world-for-us. We are also able to make the argument that horror fiction in particular, being a fiction that is not the opposite of non-fiction but rather a kind of grotesque poetry, represents a new way to speculatively think about an increasingly unthinkable world. By participating in a larger narrative about the relation between thinking and being, Ligotti's short stories acknowledge the interminable relation between metaphysical and narrative speculation, but also exemplify the point at which this relation begins to bend. Char-

acterized by philosophical concepts such as the void, darkness, and self-annihilation, but also narrative strategies such as supernatural plots, mystical language and "weird" characters, this mode of speculation accesses uncharted areas of thought and mediates the very conditions of reading within a *non-experience* that continually destroys its own substance.

By making these claims, we journey alongside a growing number of scholars. In his *In the Dust of This Planet*, Eugene Thacker links the interactions between modern horror fiction and philosophy as evidenced in histories of the occult. To confront the idea of thinking the absolute limits of human thought, Thacker appeals to genre horror to help readers understand more about the varieties of esoteric thought, be it in mysticism, Black Metal, or Dante. Similarly, with particular attention paid to the horror of being—or rather *not* being—a self, James Trafford executes a reading on the stark similarities between philosopher Thomas Metzinger's monograph *Being No One* (2004) and the contemporary horror fiction of Thomas Ligotti, wherein the idea of human consciousness itself becomes the vehicle of monstrosity. Similar arguments connecting genre horror to philosophy are made in the 2008 issue of the philosophy journal *Collapse*, *Collapse IV: Concept Horror*, including Thacker and other prominent speculative realist philosophers such as Reza Negarestani, Quentin Meillassoux, and Graham Harman. The shared claim is that there is an inherent bond between genre horror and philosophy, though the contributions on the matter itself is quite far-ranging, among whose numbers are China Miéville, notable writer of the New Weird. There have also been recent scholarly efforts to connect speculative realism to the genre of science fiction. *Speculative Realism and Science Fiction*, for instance, advances an understanding of science fiction and speculative realism as an approach whereby we can begin to challenge anthropocentrism.[5]

In chapter 1, we argued that the bond between horror and philosophy is both problematic and productive in the sense that it implies an equivalency in discourse between literature and philosophy. For the purposes of this chapter, we will utilize the pathbreaking scholarship on genre horror and philosophy, in which we share with these scholars in an effort to understand horror's location, to offer a link between darkness mysticism and the work of Thomas Ligotti, the inexorable cosmic pessimist who Matt Cardin calls "arguably the preeminent living writer of horror fiction" (85). More specifically, Ligotti's cosmic pessimism alerts readers to what Nicola Masciandaro claims is "the greater horror still that cosmic horror perforce precludes and flirts with in the form of madness, namely, the fact that one's pathetically finite human being is so abyssically *in* universe that neither is there anywhere to hide nor any reason to, *because the life on whose behalf one trembles was itself never one's own* ("Paradiscial Pessimism" 189). This is the site of intersection that allows Ligotti's work to exist in tension with the genre: despite the historical and formal liter-

ary conditions that Ligotti comes to acknowledge, there are perennial questions being raised regarding the concept of the Absolute, which make up, in large part, an extended and implicit mystical commentary within his short stories.

Ligotti's philosophical horror fiction is created at once within and outside the subgenre of "weird fiction" first initiated by H. P. Lovecraft in the 1920s and 1930s. Certainly, he bears witness to Lovecraft's subgenre, commonly referred to as supernatural horror fiction or, more recently, the Old Weird,[6] as progenitor. S. T. Joshi notes that "Ligotti has flatly declared that he is mostly attracted to Lovecraft's early tales . . . in which the dream element is more prevalent and the supernatural elements not always satisfactorily accounted for" ("Thomas Ligotti" 143), and thus transforms the supernatural realism perfected by Lovecraft into an unrealism dominated by an immanence in which the Real is always already unreal. "It is not, in the end," writes S. T. Joshi, "a replacement of the real world by the unreal, but a sort of turning the real world inside out to show that it was unreal all along" ("Thomas Ligotti" 139). By introducing this *un-realism* to the genre, Ligotti unveils the "ultimately peculiar and ultimately ridiculous qualities that are immanent and absolute in all existence" (*Teatro Grottesco* 51). Lovecraft's influence paradoxically propels Ligotti even further into the depths of consciousness, the "parent of horror" (Ligotti, *Conspiracy* 15). But in contrast to Lovecraft's infamous "Dreamlands mythos," in which dreams give characters access to an other-worldly Outside,[7] Ligotti's style of New Weird[8] favors a dream world that is closed off to any such mythos, creating an anti-systematic Inside in which characters, as they wander aimlessly about a world devoid of any entrance or exit, are given no recourse: "There are no means for escaping this world," writes Ligotti, "it penetrates even into your sleep and is its substance . . . caught in your own dreaming where there is no space . . . held forever where there is no time" ("I Have a Special Plan for this World"). Ligotti uses this technique in collections such as *Songs of a Dead Dreamer* (1989) and *Teatro Grotesco* (2008) to fashion derelict characters that experience a sense of claustrophilia, the desire for enclosed spaces or confinement, but to keep these characters themselves skeptically suspended to the point at which they remain unaware of such a desire.

As such, Ligotti's work pivots on a double movement that Ligotti "refuses to separate: the subject's passive dispossession of self-consciousness, and the 'enlightenment of inanity' . . . unmask[ing] the reality within which the characters have always been," posits Trafford, and "this process is intensified by a staunch repudiation of any recourse to the supernatural; there is no possibility of escape" (201). Readers, too, through a dialectical interplay intrinsic to a phenomenon that, following Eileen Joy's essay of the same name, we can call "weird reading," witness this claustrophilia, but inversely so via a sense of claustrophobia, in which it is not the desire for confinement but rather alienation due to

such confinement that forms a sort of hermeneutic square-circle failing to produce a border between horror *as* consciousness and the horror *of* consciousness.

The deictic conjunction of horror and consciousness, one finely expressed via the *Cloud of Unknowing's* definition of ultimate, perfect sorrow as the sorrow "that wote and and felith that he is" (71), is exemplified in "The Mystics of Muelenberg," a short story in his collection *Grimscribe: His Lives and Works* (1991). The eponymous narrator, Grimscribe, recalls the charismatic hermit and formidable esotericist Klaus Klingman, a man well known to have "attained, by laborious effort, an unwavering acceptance of the spectral nature of things" (*The Nightmare Factory* 282). As the story proceeds, Klaus Klingman recounts the tale of Muelenberg's residents, a group of people who have forgotten about the dreams of old, struggling every day to keep their minds busy, to ward off the subconscious threat of ancient formlessness. As if a messenger from this occult realm, Klingman recites with piercing insight the dissipation of these people, a dissolution where psyche and matter are un-realized. In short, the macabre unreality that lurks among them begins to manifest itself as horror; the world is suddenly transformed into a "senseless nightmare" (281). Whereas affect is conventionally restricted to the "subjective" or "internal" side of being, here the ontology of affect is exploded, so that consciousness itself might *be* horror. Divulging a Lovecraftian investment in the "palpability" of the horrible—its weird materiality, as it were—this brink where horror *as* consciousness and the horror *of* consciousness converge harbors the fate of a people "no more [able to] recognize themselves than they could one another" (285). Unable to consciously comprehend the horror of their own being, the fate of the townspeople echoes Klingman's great truth: "that all is unreal" (280).

Recalling the example of "The Mystics of Muelenberg," we can return again to our ill-fated friend Lucian Dregler, who, before the hand of doom made itself known, gives readers insight into what the ecstatic insanity of confronting a world-without-us—here in the form of meeting the Medusa—might cause, for "the only elevation allowable, the only valid transcendence, was a sardonic one: a bliss that annihilated the visible universe with jeers of dark joy, a *mindful* ecstasy. Anything else in the way of 'mysticism' was a sign of deviation or distraction, and a heresy to the obvious" (32). Dregler's musings are both an insight and a warning. Here, Dregler wavers between a metaphysics of the unreal and an experientialist transcendentalism, but also warns that a mysticism of the unreal would be heresy. What are we to make of such a warning, coming from one, the human puppet *par excellence*, who meets his end as a stone fixture between the human and non-human world? Would a mysticism of the non-human world have given Dregler an opposite fate? Could it be that his wavering between a metaphysics of the unreal and an experientialist transcendentalism is a type of "weird mysticism" itself, one that

leads him to an inhuman, albeit absolute, unity with the Medusa on *that side* of petrification? Those who remain on this side of the border are, to borrow a term from Ligotti, *human puppets*. But puppetry as such, we can argue, is the analog to a weird mysticism that has no true subject or object.

As readers who confront characters that are devoid of speech, abandoned, and emblematic of a grotesque kenosis,[9] or self-emptying, in which "there are no people, nothing at all like that" (Ligotti, "I Have a Special Plan for This World"), we are predisposed to the same "macabre unreality." And yet Dregler's warning against mysticism is actually the invocation of a negative mysticism, which is also a necessity of mysticism itself, that mysticism negates itself as mysticism. Hence Ligotti takes literary steps to obscure mystically the distinction between self and world. He writes about a fictional world superimposed onto an occulted world, but it is an occulted world whose hiddenness is its very manner of suspension. Enshrouded in a darkness that not only blackens but, through blackening, becomes luminous, Ligotti's short stories hold a close relation to medieval darkness mysticism.

This chapter will consider Ligottian horror fiction through the lens of the tradition of darkness mysticism to propose that the fiction holds a relation to the mystical. By identifying this link, we also will suggest that readers can find, through his peculiar logic of negation, an implicit commentary on the horror of reality, which, put another way, is the paradoxical horror of realizing humanity's immanent alienation from the universe and its absolute unreality.[10] In other words, for Ligotti, absolute unreality serves as the modern analog to the medieval mystic's "divine" or God-consciousness. For Ligotti, reality, like his horror fiction, is oneiric—"the Gnostic nightmare par excellence" (Tibet, 115)—and uncanny—"a sibling term for supernatural horror" (Ligotti, *Conspiracy* 17). It is this sense of homelessness,[11] one that arises from within the ontology of dream-like life and condenses from without it as the cosmos makes known its indifference to its inhabitants, that is horror's shadow throne, an uncanny (non-)place that exists both everywhere and nowhere to displace the human race into a "nightmare of being" (Ligotti, *Conspiracy* 19). For just when "everything seems to be on the verge of disclosing its unreality" (*Noctuary* 158), Ligotti's characters are seized by an imposter, forever banished to wander the earth in a state similar to John of the Cross's "dark night of the senses," never to find oneness with the unreality they seek. For, in "Mad Night of Atonement," as the infamous Dr. Haxhausen reminds us, the "entire realm of the unreal—wherein He abides—is what He loves like nothing in this world" (120). And to enter this divinely dark realm, to be sure, is done by very few.

Ligottian horror is path-breaking in this regard. To the degree that the horror of consciousness is both a trope and a mode that work in unison or singularly, we can come to understand it as a unique aspect of Ligottian

horror fiction, especially as an authorial (or autobiographical) impetus that acknowledges a constant self-fashioning and artistry. Not only does he find in human perception our plight—for we will never attain absolute realization—we find even more speculative fodder for horror, of horrors incomprehensible. In an immanent state of nocturnal eternity like the one he imagines, there is nothing to wake up to, and even if there were, it lies beyond the depths of consciousness itself. As such, Ligotti's formulation holds a generically traditional mystical insight, in that the dreamer cannot wake up, that waking up always necessarily pertains to an order eluding the parameters of consciousness. His work depicts a world where "figures parade in a state of terror which is immortal, unchanging, and which endures . . . as their only inviolable birthright" (*Noctuary* 191),[12] and subsequently posits a discourse to depict such eternal suffering, one founded in a luminous darkness. And so it is to discourse born of the void that we now turn our attention.

ON SELF-SUBVERSION

Thomas Ligotti has achieved a considerable cult following in the genre of weird fiction, a circle that utilizes pulp magazines, fan-zines, anthologies, and story collections to disseminate material to readers, critics, and fan fiction writers, all who share in a taste for supernatural horror. Ligotti lurked as a cult hero in the literary underbelly for several decades, but he has also moved into the more mainstream literary sphere with the recent 2015 publication of a Penguins Classics edition and the attention drawn to his work through the success of the HBO series *True Detective* (2014), which also brought him out of the shadows. Despite his prominence in the genre, Ligotti's career is an irregular one. For more than twenty years, from 1979 to 2001, he worked in Detroit as an editor of literary reference books, writing most of his material, much like Franz Kafka did, while attending to the daily trials and tribulations of the white-collar forty-hour work week. His work does not rely on the use of monsters, but there is certainly plenty of grotesque, horrific violence to be found in it. The horror it invokes is more akin to the gothic tale of Edgar Allan Poe than to the modern realism of Stephen King, and yet there is a surreal element to Ligottian fiction that can bewilder even the most avid reader of Lovecraft.[13] Like Kafka, Ligotti's personal experience of the world is enshrouded in absurdity, and yet, unlike him and to our fortune, he seeks to publish his work rather than have it burned. Early in his career, he avoided major publication outlets, publishing in pamphlets and magazine special issues, until 1985 when his collection *Songs of a Dead Dreamer* was issued by Harry O. Morris in the form of a three-hundred-copy edition. Since that time, Ligotti has continued to publish in magazines and journals but has released several other collections including *Grim-*

scribe (1991), *Noctuary* (1994), *My Work is Not Yet Done* (2002), *Teatro Grottesco* (2006), and a work of non-fiction entitled *The Conspiracy of the Human Race* (2010), a pessimistic work of pulp philosophy which proffers a horrifying vision of reality. It is for the "extreme darkness of his philosophical vision" (Cardin, "Liminal Terror" 85), dutifully expressed in his writing as nightmarish and eccentric commentaries on reality, that he has become known. And yet, paradoxically, for a long time, what was known of him among his admirers was quite little.

At a time when the traditional novel reigns supreme, he shuns it in favor of the short story narrative, giving his readers glimpses into an extreme logic of negation, discoursing on a darkness which acts as both a trope and a mode that permeates his work. Ligotti holds deep pessimistic convictions and deploys the short story narrative to develop commentaries on reality that are philosophically bent. Ligotti's short stories do not fit into the conventional narratives that often circumscribe the corpus of twentieth-century horror fiction or even the subgenre of "weird fiction." Like H. P. Lovecraft, Ligotti undermines prevalent modern Western discourse in order to present pessimistic narrative theses, which comment upon the decay of the individual. But whereas Lovecraft's stylistic break utilizes the short story to continually reveal the intense realism of the human being when each narrator is faced with the unknown monstrosities of the *Outside*, Ligotti's writing style allows his narrators, in a way that guides readers through weird tales that deviate from even the harbingering of Lovecraft, not only to call into question normative visions of reality but also to rewrite the way his readers are to consider them. Liggoti's version of weird fiction allows him to present a gap between the thinkable and the unthinkable in which the characters themselves are representative of this disjunction. He employs a fragmented, or commentary-like, narrative style in opposition to the novel which uses entirety as a means to uphold itself.[14]

In an interview with E. M. Angerhuber and Thomas Wagner, he proclaims H. P. Lovecraft's influence to be an active and persistent agent in his own writing philosophy, one that negates even the thought of an "all-consuming darkness," stating, "I don't want a universe in which even nothing is going on" (Ligotti, "Disillusionment" 60). Here Ligotti identifies with a writing philosophy his contemporaries have not yet seen, one predicated on the negation of even universal negation. Ligotti's narrator in "The Voice in the Bones," for instance, suggests that non-being, different from the way that it is typically characterized by "fearful thought," is a joyous condition (*Noctuary* 147). This is not to suggest that each narrator serves as a philosophical soundboard, but to suggest that, as a fiction-philosopher who maps out a new space for speculating on the *really real* vis-à-vis notions of the unreal,[15] Ligotti exhibits a literary style that is also a mode of philosophical speculation. His philosophical worldview is proffered through the genre of supernatural horror fiction, but

although a deep link to the Lovecraftian tradition exists, he is disinclined to see himself working entirely within it, as he notes in "Devotees of Decay and Desolation": "My aim is the opposite of Lovecraft's. He had an appreciation for natural scenery on earth and wanted to reach beyond the visible in the universe. I have no appreciation for natural scenery and want the objective universe to be a reflection of a character" (qtd. in Woodard, 4). Although he pays homage to his predecessor, he remains an aberration, offering an entirely new brand of horror fiction altogether.

Ligotti's work, though a modern literary form and with its emphasis on darkness, void, and emptiness of self, actually holds a closer relation to medieval texts, namely those found within the traditions of apophatic (or darkness) mysticism, than to most contemporary weird fiction. For Ligotti, the brevity of the short form mirrors a similar emphasis between imminence and fear. The lack of context in his short stories evokes the terror of trying to communicate through narrative the dark precepts of a reality that is essentially incommunicable. Likewise, for darkness mystics such as Dionysius the Areopagite and John of the Cross, poetry and apophatic language address the implicit and bewildering issue of trying to express the inexpressibility of achieving divine union. As William Franke notes, since the Middle Ages, apophaticism has functioned as a mode of discourse primarily in literary and philosophical fragments written by the likes of Holderlin, Rilke, Kafka, Kierkegaard, and others—modern writers who find themselves writing about things that cannot be said. Franke writes, "Just as for mystic writers, who typically cannot define what they believe in or desire, so for apophatic writers the sense of their belief in . . . what they can neither know nor say nevertheless permeates all that they do say and write" (4). In this way, apophasis surfaces as a mode of discourse in Ligottian narrative horror fiction.

Moreover, in *Language and Death*, Giorgio Agamben examines the relation between language and death that Martin Heidegger once posited but did not fully explore in order to investigate the ungroundedness of being, for "as much as being takes place in the nonplace of the foundation (that is, in nothingness), being is the ungrounded (das Grundlose)" (xiii). This ungroundedness also serves as the dwelling place for the language deployed by medieval apophatic mystics who discourse on the nature of the Absolute. These mystics, as living beings, have language. But on an ungrounded ground they are double beings, incapable of knowing the totality of the divine that they seek, and yet capable of deploying speech. The language they use, mystical utterances that say without fully knowing, attends to the paradox of such double being: because they are conscious beings, they cannot know the consciousness of absolute being. So, the voice they use is the negative of what is actually speak-able; they speak without speaking about the actual object of their thought. This speech is the mystical dimension of the negative, or, to be more accurate, as Agamban puts it, "the mystical is nothing but the unspeakable founda-

tion" (91). For apophatic mystics, the ontological dimension is connected to the divine dimension through language (Agamben 27), but the object of their thought cannot be grasped through language.

Earlier, to address the result of writing that blurs the distinction between materialism and mysticism, subject and object, we cultivated a conceptual portmanteau, what we, to follow Allan Stoekl's reading of Bataille and Giordano Bruno, have identified as *weird mysticism*. The concept itself, like its subterms, is double. In other words, it abides by a logic in which each negative contains itself and the possibility of its opposite. Bataille, for instance, was drawn to writings from the traditions of Christian and non-Western mysticisms, and he made great efforts to emphasize a notion of sovereignty evoked within the context of a weirdly modern darkness mysticism that wished to free itself from any limitation. Whereas Bataille's interest in mysticism is in one way manifested as sacred mode of communication aimed to recover an intimacy that is lost in human communication, Ligotti's relation to mysticism comes less by a direct influence and more by a desire to provide a fictitious yet ontological discourse on reality. It is the literary representation of a world in a post-Nietzschean—for God is long since dead—and, thus, post-transgressional framework largely characterized by the uncanny, affectlessness, puppets, ruined factories, masks, and nightmares. Ligotti is not concerned with a Bataillean sense of communication, one in which "the impossible" takes us into the mystical, but rather with positing an ungrounded pessimo-mystical discourse, a negative and deictic mode of discourse designed to invoke the very darkness it describes. As such, what readers encounter is less of a worldview and more of a modern, skewed form of apophasis designed to speak away the absolute elements of unreality, evoking a stark sense of dread.

One key element that arises in Ligotti's brand of weird mysticism is evidenced in the relationship, proposed by James Trafford, between his horror fiction and the work of philosopher Thomas Metzinger. This relationship is unique in its treatment of the self as an ill-usion, in positing a discourse about abandoning the notion of modern selfhood. Metzinger's appeal to eliminate selves marks a radical departure from epistemology, proposing "to eliminate selves from the ontological horizon and to destroy our most cherished 'originary' institutions about 'ourselves' and our place in the world" (Trafford 185). To abandon the notion of selfhood in the modern world is an intuitive and radical view to take, but it is also a view that can be read as being historically conditioned, having not only ontological but also epistemological underpinnings.

The notion of the abandonment of self as a practice performed by an individual who has self-consciousness can be traced first and foremost to the tradition inaugurated by the sixth-century mystic and theologian commonly referred to as Pseudo-Dionysius or Dionysius the Areopagite. Dionysius writes that "by an undivided and absolute abandonment of

yourself and everything, shedding all and freed from all, you will be uplifted to the ray of the divine shadow which is above everything that is" ("Mystical Theology" 135). Dionysius also negates the opposite of selfhood, which is especially important for the possibility of eternal individuality, in the formulation "being neither oneself nor someone else" (137). This divinely radical individuality is especially important in the tradition of Western mysticism, as it stresses an essential alienness that places one, as Meister Eckhart expresses, "before" God. Such alienness is exposed when one begins to see the self as foreignness, beautifully professed by Georges Bataille when he writes that "the essence of myself arises from this . . . the feeling of my fundamental improbability situates me in a world where I remain as though foreign to it, absolutely foreign" (*Inner Experience* 69).

Dionysius's writings emphasized the Neoplatonic doctrines of the unity of God and of privative evil and endeavored to show how to account for knowledge of God. In *The Divine Names*, Dionysius delineates two primary ways to know God. The affirmative way validates attributes of the divine, while the negative way knows through "unknowing":

> The most divine knowledge of God is
> one which knows through unknowing
> in the unity beyond intellect
> when the intellect stands away from beings
> and then stands away from itself,
> it is united to the more than resplendent rays,
> and is then and there illumined
> by the inscrutable depths of wisdom. (66–67)

Via such mystical utterances, Dionysius practices the negative way to know God to poetically deny any predication of God's characteristics that apply to human beings, who were commonly referred to as creatures[16] in the Christian theology of the Middle Ages.

This logic of negation, in which knowledge of God is known through unknowing is characteristic of the "self-subverting utterance," a term coined by Denys Turner to define "the utterance which first says something and then, in the same image, unsays it" (21). In Dionysius's *Mystical Theology*, a mystical text that first develops a discourse of apophatic dialectics focused on "divine darkness," self-subverting utterances, in which "the divine light is a 'brilliant darkness'; the 'mysteries of God's word' are uttered in a 'hidden silence'" (Turner 21), abound, as do metaphors such as divine shadows, unknowing, ineffability, and the abandonment of speech and thought that will become tropes for the tradition. The text functions as the progenitor to a great lineage of Western Christian apophatic thought extending through the Middle Ages with Meister Eckhart, the Author of *The Cloud of Unknowing*, John Scotus Eriugena, and John of the Cross, each of whom used the *via negativa* to counter the

positive logic of cataphatic theology. *Mystical Theology*, centuries before Descartes develops his notion of *cogito ergo sum*, suggests that selfhood hinders the possibility of experiencing consciousness of the divine. The proto-epistemological misgivings about being a self, or, rather, as a being capable to individuate, accentuate a longing to "plunge into darkness," to move *beyond* individual being into he "that made his shadows his hiding place," into the divine darkness of God (*Mystical Theology*, 156). As such, to plunge into the divine shadow, that place which, beyond all that can be made known to an individual self, is the aim of the absolute abandonment of self, in which any epistemological understanding of oneself as a self is abandoned in favor of being uplifted into absolute darkness.

Understood another way, the notion of "divine darkness" is used by medieval mystics working in the tradition of the *via negativa* who seek to develop a discourse predicated on the inability to ever sufficiently describe the nature of mystical union with the divine. In such instances, the divine, conceived in this view as a limit to thought, is ineffable; apophasis, then, identified by Michael T. Sells as "the language of unsaying," becomes the mode of manifestation or linguistic medium to demarcate such a limit to human thought. Dionysius the Areopagite's work is primary for the tradition and helps to contextualize apophatic discourse within the context of the individual. Regarding selfhood, Dionysius

> shatters the myth of individualism, which even in the sixth century was bound up with certain over-confidence in epistemological self-constitution, leading Dionysius to warn Timothy not to share the mystical secrets with those "who imagine that there is nothing beyond instances of individual being and who think that by their own intellectual resources they can have direct knowledge of him who has made shadows his hiding place." Such people weigh themselves down with themselves, too dazzled by the meager light of their own intellect to ascend to the divine darkness. (Rubenstein 397)

Thus, negative language speaks away knowledge of God in such a way as to attain true knowledge of God. The self passes away, is annihilated, to be filled with divine knowledge.

A modern corollary to the theological self-subversion exemplified by apophatic mysticism and negative theology would have to hinge on not only a critique of the notion of modern existential selfhood but also on a complete rejection of the possibility of subjective experience. Trafford states, "Ligotti invokes the expropriation of subjective experience thus: 'There are no people, nothing at all like that, the human phenomenon is but the sum of densely coiled layers of illusion, each of which winds itself upon the supreme insanity that there are persons of any kind'" (200). Hidden in Ligotti's work, then, rests a latent framework for evacuating subjective experience, one that unhinges from modern connotations of selfhood in order to reject them.[17]

The evacuation of subjectivity as such is suggested in Ligotti's story entitled "The Strange Design of Master Rignolo." In this story, the fallen protagonist Master Rignolo, an aged painter, inverts the notion of art as a form in favor of a perverse formlessness.[18] He paints *not individuals* but landscapes, borderless territories that blur any relation between self and world:

> [T]o inhabit my landscapes one must, in no figurative sense, grow into them. At best they are a paradise for sleepwalkers . . . who forget their destination and who may thus never reach that ultimate darkness beyond dreams, but may loiter in perpetuity in these lands of mine, which neighbor on nothingness and stand next door to endlessness . . . what we have in these little pictures is a perpetual communion with the void, a vital annihilation. (133)

Much like Dionysius does, Rignolo uses the self-subverting utterance to enrich the paradox of his metaphors: he does not paint individuals, but one can "grow into" his paintings; it is a paradise for sleepwalkers, but only those who do not rise; "perpetual communion" and yet "vital annihilation." We have here a weird mysticism of the "darkness beyond dreams" wherein the self transmogrifies into a derelict, inorganic state.

In the next section, we will return to the inventive ways that the role of mystical darkness permeates the Ligottian universe. At present, however, it is worthy of note that is not only Rignolo's mysticism, but also the way in which Ligotti write *about* Rignolo's mysticism, including the first-person narrative and the abstract description of concrete creations, which suggest an inherent relation to Thomas Metzinger's position. Asserting that subjective existence is mere illusion, as he "avers that it is 'practically impossible' for us to attain realization of our unreality due to inbuilt manacles of human perception that keep our minds in a dream state" (Ligotti, *Conspiracy* 106). Rignolo's paintings, bearing titles like *Inorganic Universe* and *The Tract of Extinction*, it was said, "did not depict as much as suggest the promised subjects," obscuring the "vague hint of forms [that] might emerge here and there . . . a rejection of material being, an objection to presence and a devotion to absence" (*Noctuary* 132). The implication of art work as such is something like an inversion or negative mimesis in which one simultaneously sees in the work itself the non-presence of aesthetics and non-aesthetics of the present. That he mixes a waning materialism with the pursuit of voidic communion is important to note, for Rignolo himself is a weird mystic. There is also an implication that his paintings are not only a work of art but also art *work*; in other words, Rignolo's weird mysticism is a labor, a cryptic mode of production by way of self-subversion. As this tale of inorganic horror nears its end, readers are met with an invocation of the ineffable, a vignette of silence or "scene which makes no sound" (Ligotti, *Noctuary* 136),[19] where Rignolo himself via a grotesque act of self-annihilation finds oneness

with the landscape, captured in the bounds of unreality he once thought boundless, caught up in perpetual communion with obscurity. Such an oneiric state[20] holds a relation to darkness and its poetics, as captured by Ligotti through the medium of the "noctuary," what he specifies as a "nocturnal diary," a medium able to show the true horror beyond horror which is actually the horror of reality.

Insofar as Ligotti appropriates apophatic discourse, he also perverts it. According to psychoanalytic historian Élisabeth Roudinesco, much of the mystical discourse that flourished between the thirteenth and eighteenth centuries set a precedent for confronting the divine as unthinkable. She states that, "based upon a challenge to the idea that the unity of the world could be restored at the expense of the individual, the literature of mysticism therefore displays all the features of what it is fighting and postulates that 'The mystics were wrestling with the dark angel of mourning'" (12). Thus, for Ligotti, the logic of negation is less an expression of the mystical sensibility to restore the world and more a speculatively medieval aesthetic that is capable of discerning (i.e., narrating) the modern world as unthinkable. This perversion of mystical discourse describes the inherently inconsistent nature of accessing the Real in our contemporary culture, attesting to a creative element specific to the horror genre that performs the very paradoxical task that the medieval mystic's apophatic discourse once sought to display, namely that human consciousness itself can be a limit.

DOLEFUL DISCOURSES: ON DARKNESS AND BLACKNESS

Noctuary (1994) is a collection of dark and uncanny short stories that work at once within and outside the genre of supernatural horror fiction, especially in regard to the weird fiction tales of H. P. Lovecraft and Irish writer Lord Dunsany,[21] each of whom wrote mythos in the 1920s and 1930s that were specifically oneiric in nature. Ligotti draws influence from the scientifically modeled Lovecraftian *Outside*, a universe filled with alien life forms that exist just beyond the realm of human knowledge, but breaks tethers with that influence, inverting Lovecraft's scientific discourse into a modern discourse on absence in which the Outside is transmuted into an inside that retains no mythos. As such, it is akin to an inversion of the Hermetic adage, "as above, so below" into "as without, so within." It marks an important shift for the genre because it invokes a novel trope altogether, one which inheres an implicit darkness as a result of the absence of an Outside. Matt Cardin notes that we can distinguish three central philosophical themes that recur in Ligotti's work:

> first, the meaninglessness—or possible malevolence—of the reality principle behind the material universe; second, the perennial instability

> of this universe of solid forms, shapes, and concepts as it threatens to collapse or mutate into something monstrous and unforeseeable; and third, the nightmarishness of conscious personal existence in such a world. ("Thomas" 19)

To this list we can add one more theme: Ligotti's nightmarish universe is dark.

Part two of *Noctuary*, "Discourse on Blackness," is composed of four short horror tales ranging in subject from Manichean binarism to the deformity of God. This section opens with "The Tsalal," a story of prophetic inversion in which the inhabitants of a town called Moxton, characterized as "the aristocrats of insanity whose nightmares confront them on either side of sleep," are said to "dwell on the highest plane of madness" (80). Due to the dark powers of an unholy black book called TSALAL, the town, which is filled with an atmosphere of stark decay created by "structures of serene desolation that had settled into the orbit of a dead star" (Ligotti 81), is abandoned by its inhabitants. The word Tsalal, a Greek word meaning "to grow dark," is, as S. T. Joshi reminds us, "a term taken consciously from Poe's *Narrative of Arthur Gordon Pym*" and is deployed in *Noctuary* to mean "a perfect blackness" (Joshi, "Thomas" 150). There is a phenomenal and intuitive relation between darkness and blackness, but there is also a fundamental difference and distinction, of which Ligotti seems to be aware. The conscious reference to Edgar Allan Poe's only novel, *Pym*, a gothic sea narrative[22] in which we find mutiny, the revivification of corpses, and other horrors of the sea, suggests the preservation of a gothic motif. During the mid-nineteenth century American writers such as Poe, Nathaniel Hawthorne, and Margaret Fuller found in literature a place to apply their interest in hermetic science, especially its themes of regeneration and transformation. In this way, Ligotti's narrator gives the impression that modern conceptions of darkness fail to impress upon us the hermetic Neoplatonic symbolism it once held.

A difficult problem in approaching the terms darkness and blackness, then, is how to speak about them without conflating their meanings. Ontologically speaking, the dark atmosphere[23] created in his short stories can be described as the effect of being in a state of absolute darkness, in which not the experience of darkness, but rather the darkness of non-experience, is primary. Against the error of the Gothic tradition, however, which conflates darkness and blackness, Ligotti chooses to deploy the term "blackness" in consciousness of the fundamental difference and distinction between darkness and blackness. That Ligotti knowingly morphs "tsalal" from its etymologically meaning of "to grow dark" to "a perfect blackness" reveals and realizes a definition of blackness as *perfect*—a black, of which François Laruelle writes, that "is without opposite" ("On the Black Universe" 76).

One of Ligotti's own terms may be appropriated to name the language used to describe such an atmospheric space, what he terms the "discourse on blackness." In a later section, we will develop our analysis of Ligottian atmosphere through an invocation of "nouminous life." What remains important at this juncture is to posit that what Ligotti himself terms the "discourse on blackness" utilizes a peculiar logic of negation which is skewed to one side, yielding a modern, if not grotesque, form of apophatic discourse. In order to make this argument, we can look to "The Voice in the Bones," a short story that begins in the nightmarish setting of a Tower that is enigmatically and hermetically set between a higher and lower darkness. Contextually, this short story is enshrouded in an air of mystery: an unnamed narrator tells the story of an unnamed man who is only specified by titles such as "Mr. Fizzle" and "Mr. Thump" by several disembodied voices that inhabit the Tower. The Tower, an intricately designed and abysmal place filled with shadows and echoes, is the dwelling place of the unnamed man. Aside from these general markers, the narrator keeps things relatively unexplained. Ligotti thus casts this story in an air of mystery, vaguely plotting out the context of the unnamed man's stay at the Tower. Utilizing qualifying phrases such as "an interval of oblivion passed, and it was an entirely different room in which he awoke" (*Noctuary* 142), Ligotti's narrator fails to describe the context of time (elapsed and at present) and alludes to the proclivity of what Benjamin Noys calls the "horror temporis"—"what Lovecraft suggests is the detachment of time from any relation to humanity" (281)[24]—to create an ill-explained setting that is as weird as the events taking place within it. At the story's meontological climax, the unnamed man finds several scraps of paper amongst a pile of bones on the ground, the scribbles of which will help him to un-realize his own horrific being within the Tower. As he reads these words to himself, he hears them spoken through a voice in the bones.

With this, Ligotti principally insists on the failure of written words to represent accurately the experience of eternal union beyond oneself, but also shows the critical significance of the presence of writing as morbid or desiccated trace of the unpresent subject. The elliptical phrases the unnamed man finds on the scraps of paper dislodge the narrative logic of the story, creating implicit critiques on the shortcomings of written/oral speech and positive logic, in order to describe mystical union with "eternal blackness." In the following passage, the unnamed narrator describes the abyssal place that long housed the "shattered voice" in the bones by piecing together fragmented modes of speech, a "reverberant discourse [that] had made him its student, imparting theories and practice: *bones pummeled into purity . . . parts turned to brilliant particles . . . the many voices within eternal blackness* (*Noctuary* 147). The reverberant discourse—fragmented, negative, even pedagogical—schools the unnamed man in terms of esoteric content and is evocative of apophasis in terms of narrative

form. This negative discourse, the semantic analog to mystical union with the great blackness, summons him *into* the great blackness—"now he was with them," writes Ligotti (147). Thus, he is not so much third party, a conduit for union between the voice in the bones and the eternal blackness. Rather, he semantically partakes in his own stuttering union with eternal blackness.[25] The fragmented discourse, as a failure of speech, becomes the site of apophatic perversion: despite its effort, the shattered, disembodied voice of the bones can only deliver the pact between bones (the body) and blackness (the eternal) via short utterances, failures of speech that impossibly hope to comprehend their own formulation.

If Ligotti's brand of horror fiction is, as we argue here, a form of linguistic trauma, or, rather, if in this description of mystical union with eternal blackness we find a failure of speech, then what readers find in such discourse is an apophatic a-theology. But to make this claim, we must first arrive at an etymological explanation of what a "negative theology" means. Denys Turner notes,

> If we attend to the Greek etymology of the word theology, then a curious state of linguistic affairs results from its combination with the word apophatic. For theology means "discourse about God" or "divine discourse," so the expression "apophatic theology" ought to mean something like: "that speech about God which is a failure of speech." And, though more than a little paradoxical . . . this definition rather precisely captures the Dionysian understanding of it. (20)

On the contrary, for us, the expression of an apophatic *atheology* would mean something like: "that speech about the absence of God which is a failure of speech." In this way, the Ligottian discourse on blackness seeks to blacken absolutely.

Albeit strange, Ligotti's narrative focus on attaining union with an "eternal blackness" in lieu of *God* adds to the use of apophatic metaphors in the modern short story horror narrative. In other words, Ligotti's "discourse on blackness," as a narrative horror feature attempting to demonstrate that the hiddenness of "macabre unreality" is an illusion,[26] becomes the analog to a weird mysticism of eternal blackness,[27] the practice of a darkness mysticism of pure annihilation. To illuminate the thesis that Ligotti perverts mystical discourse to attain a speculatively medieval aesthetic, the vantage of a key figure in the tradition of medieval darkness mysticism, John of the Cross, comes to our aid. As a writer, Ligotti's choice of the short story narrative mimics John's choice of poetry: as a medium capable to deal with complex philosophical and theological concepts that would otherwise be stifled in any other medium. As we noted earlier in "On Self-Subversion," for Dionysius the Areopagite, darkness is a mysterious beyond, a negative site for a communion where one can "plunge into the darkness, where, as scripture proclaims, there dwells the One who is beyond all things" (*Mystical Theology* 136). Dionysius inaugu-

rated the apophatic discourse on divine darkness which was deployed by medieval mystics for hundreds of years, perhaps most notably by the sixteenth-century Spanish poet and mystic St. John of the Cross. John's poetry, written during a time of spiritual and intellectual growth, is regarded as classic in Spanish literature. As Margaret Kim Peterson notes, John's mystical nature initially drew him to poetry, a medium which he believed capable to express the tumults and ecstasies of his mystical experiences (xii). His mystical poem entitled "The Dark Night" deploys symbolic language, which was typically reserved at this time for devotion literature, in a theological context, espousing the metaphor of the "dark night." John beautifully writes: "There in the lucky dark, / none to observe me, darkness far and wide; / no sign for me to mark, / no other light, no guide / except for my heart—the fire, the fire inside!" (*Poems* 19). Two stanzas later John proclaims that the "dark of night," the quintessential symbol of spiritual negation, is, paradoxically, his very guide. John follows the poem with a lengthy commentary in the form of a prose treatise entitled *The Dark Night of the Soul*, in which the symbol of the dark night is utilized to depict the "discipline of privation or renunciation, from the beginning of spiritual life to its end" (Peterson xiii). This prose treatise is the negative theological corollary to his poetry, the medium of his darkness mysticism.

Earlier in this chapter, we stated that we are able to come to understand Ligottian horror fiction in terms of an authorial (or autobiographical) impetus that acknowledges a constant self-fashioning and artistry. Ligotti thus chooses the short story narrative as his *modus operandi* because it allows him to create a speculative medium in which grotesque images and mysterious plots are conjoined with philosophical commentary, invoking the writerly values of brevity and formal unity. It is via this speculative narrative medium that Ligotti offers readers snapshots into the Real, which for him, as we have argued, is always already unreal. Narrative horror fiction, like darkness mysticism, suggests that experience alone fails to produce a synthesis between thought and thinker. The literary is a juncture that simultaneously synthesizes and annihilates the border between self and world. Through weird reading, narrative horror fiction becomes, much like Ligotti's pessimo-mystical discourse, bewildering: it attempts to *unknow* the division between what can and cannot be thought. In this way, *the form is the function*.

The same can be said of John of the Cross's poetry. John's poetry, of course, was not written in a theological vacuum, as John Frederick Nims statement that "mysticism itself cannot write poetry; it can only stammer about the ineffable" suggests (125). Nims writes that "St. John of the Cross, certainly, was a technician as well as a visionary. When asked by a nun if his poems were the result of inspiration or of his own hard work, he answered, as any good poet would: of both. 'Daughter, some of them God gave me and some I looked for myself'" (125). John utilizes the

poetic nuances of metaphor, tone, symbol, and imagery to intersect the divine and human worlds. His poetry also utilizes the apophatic technique of "knowing through unknowing" initiated by Dionysius the Areopagite and later, notably, the Author of *The Cloud of Unknowing*.[28] In "Deep Rapture," a poem documenting the "ecstasy of profound contemplation," John writes:

> Este saber no sabiendo
> es de tan alto poder
> que los sabios arguyendo
> jamas le pueden uencer
> que lo llega su saber
> a no entender entendiendo
> toda sciencia tracendiendo
> Y es de tan alta excellencia
> aqueste sumo saber
> que no hay facultad, ni sciencia
> que le puedan emprender
> quien se supiere uencer
> con un no saber sabiendo
> yra siempre tracendiendo[29] (*Poems* 26, 28)

John's poetic nuances of metaphor and tone echo an implicit negative logic, and this logic serves as the technique to burst thought's barrier. Utilizing the medium of poetry, John is able to semantically portray how his soul, in a space wherein selfhood has been overcome, reaches divine union which, paradoxically, can only be known through unknowing.

John's apophaticism is a critique of another type of medieval mystical theology that arose in the late Middle Ages, and is characteristic of most modern forms of mysticism,[30] what Denys Turner refers to as "experientialism." Experientialism, in extreme cases, is "the displacement of a sense of the negativity of all religious experience with the pursuit of some goal of achieving *negative experiences*" (259). Turner ultimately agrees with Michel de Certeau that John was historically positioned at a juncture between the late medieval and the early modern, and thus is not fully reliant on "an experientialist mystical epistemology such as is found in John-Joseph Surin (1600-1655)" that would characterize many of the early modern mystics (226). Experientialism "abhors the experiential vacuum of the apophatic, rushing to fill it with the plenum of the psychologistic" (Turner 259). In the case of Jean-Joseph Surin, perhaps most famously known for his decades-long demonic possession, his interior self would episodically enter into states of bliss. To a large degree, John's writings evacuate this kind of interior experience utilizing a non-experientialist method perfected by apophatic mystics that indicates human reason's ignorance of the divine through intonations of incomprehensibility. Turner notes that John's mystical writings

> do in fact contain a psychology of religious experience—often an acute and illuminating one. But his "dark nights of the soul" are not principally metaphors descriptive of them, but embody, on the contrary, a spiritual temperament resistant to the claims of spiritual "experiences." In short, John's "dark nights" are the metaphors not *of* experience, but of a dialectical *critique* of experientialist tendencies. (227)

John's metaphors, then, paradoxically embody the notion of spiritual disembodiment, an anti-experientialist and deeply anti-subjective phenomena. The implicit critique brought about by John's metaphors points to the limits of experientialist tendencies, ones that, while aiming to the fill the subject with a negative *experience*, could be said to posit union with God by way of subjectivity. This, of course, is antithetical to apophatic metaphors of divine darkness in which the bewilderment between I and Thou is central.

Like John of the Cross, Ligotti's metaphors are not entirely psychological metaphors of experience, but more so of a critique of particularly modern experience, namely that experiencing oneself existentially *as a self* is an illusion. Horror tends to subvert and interrogate the foundational binaries of culture and language, problematizing the relations between self and other, animate and inanimate, and being and thinking. This notion is evidenced in "In a Foreign Town, In a Foreign Land," a short story which, in part, communicates the tale of the *uncreation* of Ascrobius, a contemplative freak whose physical maladies are only marginally understood by the town physician, Dr. Klatt. As a metaphysician, however, Dr. Klatt is eventually able to speculate that Ascrobius's contemplative powers allow him to literally *uncreate* himself from existence. As such, the townsfolk witness not the disappearance of a self but the absolute negation of a self on both physical and spiritual planes. What this critique of modern experience allows for is not an anachronistic superimposition of John's metaphor of the spiritual "dark night," but a way of using the theme of purgative contemplation to present a mystical way of viewing modern selfhood as a concept that is intrinsically flawed. Each author posits a type of self-emptying,[31] though each type varies in terms of method and object.

For John of the Cross, purgative contemplation, "which causes in [the] soul the negation of herself and of everything" (*The Dark Night of the Soul* 7), is a kind of self-emptying, an obscure "dark night" in which the soul detaches from all illusions that are not God. It is this metaphysical act of contemplation as an act of freakishness that Ligotti provides readers with a model of the modern self as one traumatized. Ligotti writes that Ascrobius's freakish qualities "emerged from his intensely contemplative nature. 'He had incredible powers available to him,' said the doctor. 'He might even have cured himself of his diseased physical condition; who can say? But all of his powers of contemplation, all of those incessant *meditations* that took place in his high backstreet house, were directed

towards another purpose altogether' (*Teatro Grottesco* 122). Ligotti situates the act of mystical contemplation within the context of the horror of Being, to expunge Ascrobius of the desire *to be* at all, to detach the copula—that Ascrobius *is*—from any coupling with his name:

> Eventually someone did inquire about the contemplative powers and meditations of the recluse, and toward what end they might have been directed. "What Ascrobius sought," the doctor explained, "was not a remedy for his physical disease, not a cure in any usual sense of the word. What he sought was an absolute *annulment*, not only of his disease but of his entire existence. On rare occasions he even spoke to me," the doctor said, "about the *uncreation* of his whole life." (*Teatro Grottesco* 123)

The use of purgative contemplation to *annul* absolutely an entire existence is a kind of mystical self-emptying that, when contextualized within Ligotti's larger narrative project of touching on the ineffable, is a paradox that is expressed poetically through the short story narrative.

On the surface, the shortness of this story bears a resemblance to philosophical commentary, as we mentioned previously. We can also suggest, however, that the shortness of the story bears importance in its relation to mysticism. There is the relation, for instance, to epigrammatic thought (i.e., the narrative-epigram) which is often found in mystical auto-commentary, that is, writing that allows the mystic to at once think about and discourse on their mystical experience. Auto-commentaries of this sort are not only formally short but also call into question other meanings of shortness—of life, of time itself vis-à-vis eternity—that are of significance for mystical horror. Julian of Norwich, for example, writes of the traditional mystical connection between bodily illness and the experience of divine presence. On her sickness, she writes, "I felt as if the upper part of my body were beginning to die. My hands fell down on either side, and I was so weak that my head lolled to one side. The greatest pain that I felt was my shortness of breath and the ebbing of my life" (128). Julian's mystical experience of bodily anguish (i.e., her shortness of breath and of life itself) suggests a connection between imminence and fear, the terror of what is *about to happen* any second now.

"In a Foreign Town, In a Foreign Land" implicitly attributes a connection between mystical horror and shortness, imminence and fear. It epigrammatically and mystically frames Ligotti's philosophical position in *The Conspiracy Against the Human Race*, where he argues for an estimation of life as "something that should not be, which means that what . . . should be is the absence of life, non-being, the emptiness of the *uncreated*" (47).[32] Uncreation, then, becomes a recurring theme in both his fiction and non-fiction work. For Ligotti, philosophical pessimism is the only modern form of knowing that is equally capable and willing to see that life is something that should be *shortened*, or better yet, something that

should be uncreated, and "anyone who speaks up for life as something that irrefutably should be—that we would not be better off unborn, extinct, or forever lazing in nonexistence—is an optimist" (*Conspiracy* 47). If philosophical pessimism is, for Ligotti, a way of knowing, then fiction is, accordingly, his textual medium to convey it. His horror fiction is itself a form of purgative contemplation, one that utilizes a logic of negation—what we termed earlier as "pessimystical discourse"—to situate readers within a non-experience that continually destroys its own substance: readers see the weirdly reflected image beheld in the liminal darkness of non-experience. As such, black discloses, to follow Alain Badiou, "one of its great affirmative functions: marking the location of what exists only by lacking" (65). We are the text's black mirror.

If readers are to believe that being conscious is as unfavorable as Ligotti does, then it would suffice to say that any kind of musing on divine life would be superfluous. And yet, what can we make of the "dark nights of the soul," in which John of the Cross equates the "second night of the soul" as a "perturbation and horror," one "infinitely more grievous than any torment of this life" (*The Dark Night* 121). John offers these words in a sustained commentary on the line, "In darkness and in secret I crept forth" from his poem "The Dark Night" in book two of *The Dark Night of the Soul*. What John so eloquently describes is the secret passage of the soul during the "passive night of the soul," which is characterized by God-given spiritual privation, in contrast to the "active night of the soul" and is self-willed privation. Although John sees this perturbation as a necessary evil, one the soul may inevitably pass through, his language pessimistically posits that the divine horror of the "dark night" is far worse than any torment of human life, which is to say of a life on *this side* of the non-human boundary. With this, we see that the non-experientialism of the apophatic mystic is perhaps more akin to modern pessimism than one might originally think.

John of the Cross's "dark night" is definitely particular to its historical moment: social and political changes resulting from the Black Death of the fourteenth century, his work with St. Theresa of Avila, and his imprisonment all play a part in his spiritual life. John's premodern demarcation between the sensual and the spiritual forestalls the modern fixation on psychology, but by focusing on the dark movement of the spirit, John offers an explanation of how the notion of the horror of the dark night[33] stems from the shadows of one's own spiritual preoccupations, and that thought itself is oftentimes abominable, especially when tormented by the *Spiritus vertiginis*, for instance, an "abominable spirit . . . which darkens [the] senses . . . fill[ing] them with a thousand scruples and perplexities" (46). Such an explanation of how thought can be tormented by a perversely "dizzy spirit" offers a way to attend to the vertiginously claustrophobic experience of reading Ligottian horror fiction, a resolutely

pessimistic form of narrative that blurs the Enlightenment separation between reality and illusion.

A BEAUTIFUL HORROR: "BLACK UNIVERSE"

As we have discovered, the motif of darkness permeates both apophatic mysticism and Ligottian horror fiction, yielding critical-creative commentaries on the vertigo of being. The vertiginously claustrophobic tone of Ligotti's short stories has been identified by James Trafford as a kind of "hallucinogenic horror" "characterized by a claustrophobic discrepancy between realism and oneirism, in which the world is illusional, and the real inconsistent and autonomous" (188–89). "The Prodigy of Dreams" is a short story that recalls the tale of Arthur Emerson, who, from the "various quarters" of an "almost claustrophobic world" attempts to "satisfy an inborn craving to comprehend . . . an astonishing, even shocking existence" (*Noctuary* 55). The world as experienced by Arthur Emerson suggested to him a peculiar level of wonder that remains hidden to most people, "appearances [which] disguised realms of an entirely different nature," Ligotti writes, because in these "divined spheres there existed a kind of confusion—a swirling, fluttering motion that was belied by the relative order of the seen" (55). Although Arthur Emerson is a gifted seer, these divined spheres are ones that can ultimately be said to thrive without-him, in an autonomous reality that can hardly even be comprehended let alone described.

In a hallucinogenic horror tale such as this, Ligotti simultaneously articulates the sentiments of many of the philosophical pessimists of our modern day, a sense that life is of course "MALIGNANTLY USELESS" (*Conspiracy* 76).[34] But his work also suggests that apophatic discourse can be appropriated in order to develop the atmosphere of his short stories. It might be difficult for some readers to understand that Ligotti sees virtually no recourse to quell such logic. Most of the more genuine pessimistic writings of the past two hundred years, especially those of Schopenhauer, Zapffe, Phillipp Mainländer, and David Benatar, that have greatly impacted Ligotti, do impel this sort of pessimism without compromise. Ligotti's horror fiction can be said to historically derive from one particular pessimistic theory, what Philipp Mainländer in *The Philosophy of Redemption* (1876) identifies as an act of Deicide. The implicit notion that lies hidden in the narrative is to show that modern people became derelict from the divine realms through an unspeakable act of divine hubris-cum-pessimism. "Because it seems that existence was a horror to God," writes Ligotti, "His only means to get free of Himself was by a divine form of suicide" (*Conspiracy* 35–36). For Ligotti's characters, being in the post-Deicidic universe is synonymous with immanent detachment from God. This qualifies their dereliction from unreality, which is to say, from the

really real, within the framework of oblivious selves that have always already been emptied. "The human phenomenon is but the sum of densely coiled layers of illusion," writes the narrative voice in the Ligotti's poem "I Have a Special Plan for this World," "each of which winds itself upon the supreme insanity that there are persons of any kind, when all there can be is mindless mirrors laughing and screaming as they parade about in an endless dream" (Qtd. in "Unplug Yourself"). Optimists may find his opining to be discouraging, but this antagonism indicates that the latent terrors of darkness have some basis in the communal experience of life they choose to live among them. It is a signal that the logic of negation sees into an aspect of modern living that other logics cannot see. That the dark night does not subside is indicative of the horror of reality, a failure of the world's truth and the real's consistency.

This negative logic persists throughout *Noctuary*'s third section entitled "Notebook of the Night," provided that this section itself deviates from the first two in the way of form. "Notebook of the Night" is composed of nineteen vignette pieces—short, diary-like entries that are interthematically woven together through abyssal darkness and humanity's alienation from the universe in itself. Emblematically speaking, this formal deviation is a blackening in itself. It productively problematizes a failure in narrative logic of the collection as a whole: through its fragmented meanderings, this section promises to reveal failures of the world's truth—or, put another way, it will reveal that the world-for-us is only ever *relatively* true—and of the real's consistency.

"The beauty of black is the form of vision," writes Nicola Masciandaro, "the incredible delight of being seen by the Invisible, as John the Cross expresses in commentary on this line: 'For though of myself I am dark, he so frequently fixed his eyes on me, after having looked at me the first time, that he was not satisfied until he had espoused me to himself and brought me to the inner chamber of his love'" (8). Framed in this way, what we find in Ligotti's tales is a black universe that is at once mystically beautiful and horrifying: absorption into the beauty of black comes by way of the obliteration of narrative form, when narrative logic does not illuminate the dark but only enters into light's darkness, thought's shadow-upon-return.

Take, for example, "One May Be Dreaming." This short vignette-like piece in "Notebook of the Night" gives readers a snapshot glimpse into the obscure and oneiric state of being of the narrator: "my present state is without reality. . . . I know there is nothing beyond those lights. . . . Should I venture there I would fall straight into an absolute darkness" (162). Bewildered by his own unreality, the narrator remains at the brink of thinking the light's beyond. His Oneness with absolute darkness is limited by the obscure beyondness of the light, one that may or may not be as real as he thinks himself to be. Oneirism is the ontological medium he uses to intuit this limitation. He sits, seen by the invisible unreality,

pondering whether to venture into the absolute darkness, but only capable of narrating his present state as being mediated by his dying dreams. Here, a connection can be made to Edmund Burke's discussion of "obscurity" in *A Philosophical Enquiry into the Origin of Our Ideas of the Sublime and Beautiful* (1757), especially his understanding of dread and night, which he insightfully locates in religion. He asks readers to consider "how greatly night adds to our dread, in all cases of danger, and how much the notions of ghosts and goblins, of which none can form clear ideas, affect minds. . . . The policy has been the same in many cases of religion" (41). Liggoti's universe, it seems, is the dying out of a living contradiction between a darkness mysticism of the world-for-us and the thinking of a world-without-us, in which the Meillaisouxian "great outdoors," as a limit threshold—the great indoors—is experienced as hypnogogic hallucination. If it goes unrecognized, this limit threshold manifests as claustrophobic alienation from absolute unreality.

Recalling the example of "One May Be Dreaming," we are able to recall the characters in the aforementioned short story "The Tsalal." At story's end, they are said to have "had attained the stripped bone of being, the last layer of an existence . . . without nature or essence: the void of the blackness no one had ever seen" (*Noctuary* 109). It follows that this passage on blackness is an attempt to speak about the characters' attaining consciousness of a void "without nature or essence," one that is highly reminiscent of Masicandaro's description of "black universe":

> We bring little lights to black universe and with the shadows cast by our own forms think to have illuminated it. Thought does not illuminate the Real, but projects its own real shadow upon what it cannot see. No light has ever seen black universe because its blackness composes the substantiality of darkness, is grounded in the principle that darkness is not the absence or privation of light, but light's own body, the means of its existence. Light is only in darkness. (7)

Put simply, the narrative logic of "The Tsalal" can bring readers only so close to an illuminated understanding of the "void of the blackness no one would ever see." Ultimately, Ligotti's description endeavors to communicate an experience that is essentially incommunicable. The narrative knowingly fails to illuminate the mystical nature of the void in which these characters are said to attain "the stripped bone of being," but, on the other hand, it does successfully serve as an "experiential feedback" of that which *is* mystical (Turner 245).

As one can see, the perplexity of Ligotti's black universe grows more pronounced when it is aligned with a sense of mystery or illusion. His short piece "The Eternal Mirage" certainly suggests that he grasps clearly the *speculative* essence of black, namely, that is identically out there and inside whoever sees it: "Black is without opposite: even light, which tries to turn it into its opposite, fails in the face of the rigor of its secret," writes

François Laruelle, "Only the secret sees into the secret, like Black in Black" ("On the Black Universe" 106–07). In "The Eternal Mirage," Ligotti metaphorically describes the cartography of a universe where "illusions struggle with illusions," where blackness spreads above and below into "an endless ebony plateau," where "one may see the flickering of . . . luminous motes, quivering bodies held captive in the unbroken web of blackness" (*Noctuary* 195). He writes of this infinite space that "a dimension has died, annihilating depth and leaving behind only a lustrous image which seems to float far and wide upon the infinite surface of a black ocean. And it is said that this ocean is itself merely a starry phantasm glimpsed in certain eyes . . . eyes that are like two stars shining deep in a black mirror" (196). For the wanderers of this place, Ligotti's black universe paradoxically evokes a form of vision, where sight is the site of the mirage itself, a blackening of vision of a "lustrous image" which shines into a black sea of infinity. The mirror image that this blackness provides occurs beyond the depth of human vision, a blackening that points to its own taking place, dually serving as a third thing that reflects its own secret meaning-formation.

In his fiction, Ligotti uses several terms to qualify such blackness. Of note are the adjectives he chooses to conjoin to the nouns—*shining* darkness to *lustrous* blackness—which become the mystical analog to the "luminous darkness" described by Dionysius the Areopagite.[35] The corollary is a form of vision that is brought into its double being, a mutated mirror that corresponds to the formless nigredo of its own image. We can suggest that what Ligotti sees in this mirror is the essential paradigm of weird fiction, "an amazement at the monumentally macabre unreality of life [when awakened] to the weird—just as the man awakens in the perpetual hell of his brief story," he writes, and "reaches out into the unknown thing in the darkness. Now, even without his eyeglasses, he can truly see" (*Noctuary* 14). To see without sight is to cast one's own thought shadow into the black universe. Only the mystic is capable to see the black mirror's reflection.

According to Masciandaro, only the mystic is capable to behold black universe, for the mystic is the one who *is* light's unintelligible nigredo. In his essay "Secret: No Light Has Ever Seen the Black Universe," he writes,

> The mystic is the one who exits the real stupidity of correlational captivation and says openly and with infinite curiosity to the world: What are you doing here? There is nothing to see! No illumination will reveal black universe to you. You yourself alone (in a secret manner of speaking) are the singular unthinkable light that sees black universe, that is, the light beyond light that is nothing other than your own blackening. All you—the philosopher—have done (and covertly do now) is play in the dark. (7)

As it produces a liminal third space wherein the stories' black universe dwells, Ligotti's short narrative form marks a shift in the dialectics of negativity once used by medieval darkness mystics while it retains the enigmatic tenor of their quest.[36] Readers are complicit in the revelation of cosmic nigredo in the way that they become archeologists of black universe, excavating the holy ruins of narrative unintelligibility. Readers engage in what we could call an *apophatic archeology*,[37] which is to say that there is something unknowable about this black universe that no positive narrative logic will illuminate. And by doing apophatic archaeology, Ligotti's readers can begin to answer Masciandaro's call to "exit correlational captivity," to ask themselves once and with awe: What am I doing here?

"NOUMINOUS LIFE"

Ligotti opens *The Conspiracy Against the Human Race: A Contrivance of Horror* (2010), a book billed as a work of non-fiction, by reflecting on the nineteenth-century German philosopher Julius Bahnsen. Ligotti, who finds in Bahnsen "pessimism without compromise" (14), notes that, to Bahnsen, "[cosmic] force and its movement were monstrous in nature, resulting of a universe of indiscriminate butchery and mutual slaughter among its individual parts" (13). On the one hand, to follow Bahnsen, perhaps the best we can do is to confess that the true horror of the cosmos is that, as chaos, it is necessarily disinterested in human thinking. On the other hand, to say that the cosmos does not care if we are thinking it or not, that it does not require us, may be an all-too-convenient position to take. Given that the cosmos produces thinking and yet thinking can also be said to produce the cosmos, the ontological status of human life is rather bound up in a kind of cosmic aporia wherein human beings perpetuate horror by being themselves.

Ligotti's characters exist (from Latin *existere/exsistere* "to step out, stand forth, emerge, appear") in a ruinous state of cosmic puppetry,[38] as is suggested in the short piece "The Unfamiliar," a vignette where an unnamed narrator relays with episodic fervor the fate of a man, perhaps the proprietor of a strange store that houses "trinkets for strange gods, toys for monsters," eerily identified only as "he" (*Noctuary* 168). The man is victimized by "some vast conspiracy that involved the remotest quarters of the cosmos" (168), and mysteriously turns into a monstrous being unfamiliar to itself, the likes of which beckons visiting spectators to visit the dark place where he remains namelessly incarcerated. Here darkness cloaks an occulted world, one full of "hidden portents" that make heads spin "first with vague images and possibilities, then with . . . darkness" (168). This man is not dead and, yet, not *not* dead. Being in this occulted world promotes a form of life in which each character is the stagnant

victim of a traumatic fissure between identity and place, blurring the boundary between self and world, or more accurately, between creaturely "life" and the "not alive." Yet non-life is not merely death; death, it seems, is not the opposite of life but rather the opposite of birth.

In its non-conformism to conventional wisdom the motif of Ligottian liminality produces an "anomic [or] *liminal* terror," generating a sense of "strangeness, uncomfortableness, or uncanniness" (Cardin 88). This triumvirate obscures the boundary between life and the living/non-living almost always producing an atmosphere of liminal terror that adds to a sense of the horror beyond liminal horror, which is to say the thinking of a horror that lies beyond the world-for-us. If horror fiction is a way of thinking the world as unthinkable, then what is capable of being thought is also subject to the paradoxical effects of what is cast by thought's incandescent shadow. It is here that we will commit the deictic sin, and we make the heretical claim that his black universe, rife with ineffability, linguistic trauma, and annihilation, is holy. Ligotti's universe sits in a liminal space between two distinct concepts—the "numinous" and the "noumenon"—what Eugene Thacker has recently termed in *In the Dust of This Planet* as the "nouminous."

The holy and the weird are strange bedfellows. In his essay entitled "Supernatural Horror in Literature," Lovecraft remarks that "the horror tale is as old as human thought and speech themselves . . . crystallized in the most archaic ballads, chronicles, and sacred writings" (427). Historically speaking, the origins of ancient daemons and gods is corollary to the origins of the horror tale, bespeaking a strange affinity between the holy and the weird. In *The Idea of the Holy* (1923), German theologian Rudolf Otto develops his concept of "the numinous," a word taken from the Latin "numen" defined to express the supernatural presence of a divine force. One key element of the numinous that Otto goes to some length to describe is the feeling that arises when one comes in contact with the numinous, what he calls "creature consciousness," the feeling of utter "nothingness before an overpowering, absolute might of some kind" (10). Later in the book, during his analysis of the "mysterium tremendem," Otto suggests that the numinous has a quality of "religious" or "daemonic dread" as "it first begins to stir in the feeling of 'something uncanny,' 'eerie,' or 'weird'" (14). These eerie and uncanny feelings were felt by early human beings as a sense of religious awe and are akin to the uncanny feelings derived from "the weird" itself, especially while reading weird tales. Ligotti himself states that "artistic invocations of horror are most successful when the phenomena they depict call up the uncanny . . . [and are] genuinely threatening from both the outside and from within" (*Conspiracy* 90). In this way, horror becomes a third thing, a site of synthesis between the supernatural and the uncanny that blurs the boundary between what is human and what is the "beyond" or "wholly other" (Otto 29).

The other term Thacker uses to form this conceptual portmanteau is "noumenon." This term was used in ancient Greek philosophy to describe a world outside the mind (the realm of the Platonic Forms, for instance). In the eighteenth century, the German philosopher Immanuel Kant appropriated the term for his own transcendental philosophy, using it as a synonym for the "thing-in-itself," a world of objects that exists outside the realm of human knowledge. According to Kant, thought does not have access to things-in-themselves, only to things as they appear to human beings. The subject-object dualism between the phenomenon (what is observable by human beings) and the noumenon has been a hegemonic paradigm in philosophy ever since. What is important to note here is that the noumenon, in a sphere beyond the limits of human thought, always already evoking a sense of horror in regards the unknown object itself, is aligned with the same sense of daemonic dread Otto defines as at once a source of horror and mystery: "the demonic-divine object may appear to the mind an object of horror and dread, but at the same time it is no less something that allures with a potent charm" (31). It could be said that what is nouminous, then, can be associated with what we might call a nefarious *Siren of the Outside*, the likes of which lures the human mind, trapped on the Inside, into a realm of infinite ineptitude and awe. Keeping this distinction in mind, we can begin to more fully appreciate how Ligotti tries to put this concept of the non-human into language commensurable with the human. In the short story "Mad Night of Atonement," Ligotti describes the prophetic life and public performances given by a mad scientist named Dr. Francis Haxhausen, inventor of the Sacred Ray, a device used to penetrate into divine realms of darkness. At one particular performance, the doctor relays to his audience the esoteric quality of his adventures, describing the ruins of holy places in which there is a "sense of divinity," noting that "we never have such feelings in our cities. . . . This is why so much is atoned for in wintertime, when a numinous death descends on those chosen lands of our globe" (*Noctuary* 119). Dr. Haxhausen's reflection upon the sense of divinity to be found in ruined places allows for us a moment of critical pause. What kind of life exists in a holy place of ruin? Or, to put it another way, what is the relation that exists at the liminal point of encounter between what is holy and what is horrific? To help discern what kinds of boundaries are being crossed, a concept of life is needed that speaks to living contradictions and accounts for the ontological contradictions that Ligottian horror fiction poses to a view of Life.

In "Nine *Disputio* on the Horror of Theology," Thacker proposes that if indeed "horror is a way of thinking the unthinkable, and the limits of our place within that world, then really the *specter* that haunts horror is not death but indeed life" (*In the Dust* 99). According to Thacker, "A nouminous life would have to articulate a conceptual space that is neither that which is lived outside of discourse (the gothic 'numinous'), nor that

which is reasoned within discourse and yet unlived (the Kantian antimonies)" (112). Rather than to favor a binary concept of life, Thacker names the strange affinity between the thinking of the world as unthinkable and the living of a life that is unlivable. Thacker thereby curates a concept of the horror of "a life-after-life," a nouminous life that "elicits a noumenal horror that is the horror of a life that indifferently lives on" (112). Recalling this discussion by Thacker, Ligotti's notion of "beings born undead" comes to mind and is suggestive of a life that indifferently lives on: "We are aberrations—beings born undead, neither one thing or another, or two things at once . . . uncanny things that have nothing to do with the rest of creation, horrors that poison the world by sowing our madness everywhere we go, glutting daylight and darkness with incorporeal obscenities" (*Conspiracy* 222). The short vignette-like pieces we have been analyzing from the final section of *Noctuary*, ones that take place in a universe replete with life that indifferently lives on with beings born undead, exhibit these attributes of the nouminous.

Perhaps the most convincing example is found in "The Mocking Mystery," a short piece in "Notebook of the Night" where readers find a description of a world that has been battered by an atrocious movement of the cosmos, where mystery reigns and all is cast in shadow. This place of ruin, "where ultimate knowledge [has been] denied," is the dwelling place for the necropolis of Ligottian universe, where some devote themselves to worshipping "the ruined state, consecrating earthly objects that in their decrepitude have attained a divine status" (Ligotti, *Noctuary* 189). Because characters are enmeshed in a nouminous life, what readers encounter is not the experience of noumenal horror, but more so the horror of the atmosphere created when such a nouminous life is (un)lived. Such an atmosphere persists in a third space both within the "discourse on blackness" and at the limit-experience of unreality (the un-reasonable, or, that which negates the principle of sufficient reason). This conceptual third space exudes the double atmosphere of darkness and the eclipse of darkness, one composed not of animate elements to aid in the characters' respiration but rather of an inorganic and ethereal sludge fated to suffocate or stifle.

In the examples from "Notebook of the Night," it is clear that Ligotti's "nouminous" always situates itself as that which structures the absence of experience, eliciting the malady of traumatic incommensurability (not the experience of existential thrownness but the experience of its contingency) as it simultaneously is that which negates the possibility of experience, is that-which-cannot-be: this atmosphere is the sublimation into obscurity of any and all subjective perception of exteriority into an elusive, nouminous exosphere. Whereas Lovecraft uses the Outside to circumvent the limit-experience of his characters' thought, Ligotti does the very opposite. Ligotti's characters are trapped on the Inside, forever

wandering and unaffected, ignorant as to their alienation from absolute unreality.

At this juncture, it can be said that what we have been trying to think through is a problematic of literary acuity and philosophic profundity in which Ligotti inaugurates a non-correlational literary form that aims to narratively and speculatively perform the necessity of its conceptual content. In other words, Ligotti's weird mysticism serves as a hermetic vehicle for the enactment of a self-obliterating reading experience,[39] which, in effect, is the latent desire of his horror fiction, the desire to be obliterated by a non-experience which continually destroys its own substance. The hope is that these readings of Ligotti have done this conjunctive profundity justice by casting it in a new light, that is to say, actualizing a shimmering negativity that is not light at all, but a force opposed to the light—a luminous darkness. And so it goes that this problematic invites us, as readers, to both become and be obliterated by the incommensurability of the world-without-us through the commensurability of the short narrative form. Everything that happens as a result of this reading (dis)enactment can also be said to happen for no reason at all. And perhaps that is the way Ligotti would like it to happen.

NOTES

1. By "weird fiction" we explicitly mean the literary genre that appeared in the early twentieth century which joined fiction, myth, and horror with scientific and technological conjecture. This type of writing was inclined to be driven by the proliferation of speculative ideas, rather than plot-driven, though many of the stories share similar literary tropes like supernaturalism, horror, and the return of ancient forms of life.

2. Walter Benjamin offers a definition of the flâneur in which this quintessentially modern practice of strolling spectatorship is accompanied by illusions: "The flâneur plays the role of scout in the marketplace. As such, he is also the explorer of the crowd. Within the man who abandons himself to it, the crowd inspires a sort of drunkenness, one accompanied by very specific illusions: the man flatters himself that, on seeing a passerby swept along by the crowd, he has accurately classified him, seen straight through to the innermost recesses of his soul — all on the basis of his external appearance" (21). The crux of Benjamin's interest in the flâneur is its narrative possibilities, exemplified both by the *Arcades Project* and by Lois Aragon's *Paris Peasent*. Lucian Dregler's metaphysical flâneury, proffered through our metaphor of drunkenness, inverts the illusion toward the outermost recesses of his own horizon. Let us also note that the crux of Benjamin's interest in the flâneur is its narrative possibilities, exemplified both by the *Arcades Project* and by Louis Aragon's *Paris Peasant* (1926).

3. The specific meaning and history of the term "hauntological" in critical discourse is worthy of note here. The term originally stems from Jacques Derrida's 1993 book, *Spectres of Marx*, in which he uses it to describe the question of ghosts, or rather, the "effectivity or presence of a specter" (10). Derrida uses the term to refer to a peculiar quality that is "neither living nor dead, present nor absent: it spectralizes. It does not belong to ontology, to the discourse on the Being of beings, or to the essence of life or death," taking "this category to be irreducible, and first of Two decades later, Mark Fisher, in *Ghosts of My Life: Writings on Depression, Hauntology and Lost Futures*, points to the failure to catch ground beyond its use as a "puncept" or "successor to

previous concepts of Derrida's such as the trace and *différance*, citing "Derrida's circumlocutions" as a "disintensifying influence" (17). Fisher argues that, rather than taking hauntology as an opposition between "some attempt to revive the supernatural" or "just as a figure of speech," it would be more beneficial to "think of hauntology as *the agency of the virtual*, with the spectre understood not as anything supernatural, but as that which acts without (physically) existing" (18).

4. Lovecraft's definition of the weird tale as particularly atmospheric in nature, as Roger Luckhurt's notes, "built on the Old English meaning of *wyrd* as a supernal force or agency that determines events—a distinctly northern sense of malign fates waiting to cross your destiny, like the 'weird sisters' in Shakespeare's *Macbeth*. It only really began to be associated with the uncanny and supernatural in Romantic and Victorian literature."

5. In this innovative study, Brian Willems utilizes an experience he terms the "Zug effect" in order to show how science fiction can paradoxically represent non-correlationist worlds (6). Furthermore, he argues that Meillassoux's tripartite concept of Type 1-3 of worlds is quite useful, but does need some revamping. So he focuses on a wide range of science fiction literature including Neil Gaiman and China Mieville, as well as other speculative realist figures such as Graham Harman and Jane Bennet, in order to proffer an encompassing view of science fiction that ascribes more truth and value to the lives of non-human objects and resists anthropomorphism.

6. In "Introduction: Old and New Weird," Benjamin Noys and Timothy S. Murphy propose and develop a distinction and periodization of the "Old Weird" versus the "New Weird." They write that the "Old Weird can be dated between 1880 and 1940, and the term is explicitly articulated with the founding of the pulp magazine Weird Tales in March 1923. . . . Lovecraft both defined a previous canon of weird fiction, in writers like Arthur Machen, Lord Dunsany, and Algernon Blackwood, and stimulated a number of younger writers to engage with the weird, including Clark Ashton Smith, Robert E. Howard, C. L. Moore, and Robert Bloch" (118).

7. Take, as an account of the dream-like transcendence from life to the Outside, this line from Lovecraft's "The Green Meadow" (1927), originally written in 1918/19 and inspired by a dream had by Winifred V. Jackson: "everything about me, even life and death, was illusory; . . . I had overleaped the bounds of mortality and corporeal entity, becoming a free, detached thing" (*Eldritch Tales* 224). For Ligotti, any subjective experience of the world is always already dream-like and illusory; there is no entrance, no exit, and no transcending this state.

8. In contrast to the Old Weird mentioned previously, Noys and Murphy note that the "New Weird, a term M. John Harrison coined in 2003 (Davies 2010, 6), emerged comparatively recently and was established primarily with the fiction and criticism of Miéville. We can, however, trace the New Weird back to the 1980s fiction of Clive Barker and especially Thomas Ligotti. Ligotti succeeded in avoiding the pastiche and repetition that had tended to dominate post-Lovecraftian weird fiction and formulated a new and desolate conception of a fundamentally chaotic universe. This ability to rework Lovecraft beyond the limits of homage is also observable in Michel Houellebecq, Brian Evenson, and other writers of New Weird. Therefore we could define the New Weird as a period from the 1980s to the present that gained its most explicit articulation in the 2000s" (118–19).

9. John Clute's use of the Swedenborgian term "vastation," an emptying state of spiritual regeneration—as detailed in *The Darkening Garden* (2006)—is also relevant here, considering it is a prior application of religious mystical thought to weird fiction. For Clute, "vastation" is a "consequence of a measurable change in the *relationship* of the sufferer to the world story. It is an emotion linked to the story of the world at those moments when that story threatens to overwhelm us, or when its incoherence or coherence becomes mercilessly visible" (John Clute, "The Darkening Garden: Vastation," *Weird Fiction Review*, November 6, 2012, https://weirdfictionreview.com/2012/11/vastation/).

10. Here the teachings of Italian esotericist Massimo Scaligero are useful to keep in mind, as he situates this notion of human alienation from unreality around the theme of anthroposophic inversion. For Scaligero, if one can get beyond the illusion that the outer world is the real world, then unreality, when taken on its inversion and internalized, becomes the essential power of individuation. He writes that "it is the world that escapes one all the more when one believes one loves or suffers, or craves or hates, because it is in the feeling states and in the instincts that the abstractness of the world, in other words its unreality has become an inner power, a thirst for life reflectively pictured mentally and thought: which is to say, taken on in its inversion."

11. Cf. "The German word *'unheimlich'* is obviously the opposite of *'heimlich'* ['homely'], '*heimisch*' ['native'] the opposite of what is familiar; and we are tempted to conclude that what is 'uncanny' is frightening precisely because it is *not* known and familiar" (Freud 122).

12. This passage suggests a distortion of the Buddhist concept of *Dharmakāya*. One of the three Buddha bodies, dharmakāya proposes that there is a state of immanent immortality beyond all that is and is not, beyond all concepts. For Ligotti, this state would be one of terror.

13. Ben Woodard identifies a clear distinction between the two writers' brands of weird fiction: "Whereas Lovecraft's weirdness draws predominantly from the abyssal depths of the uncharted universe, Ligotti's existential horror focuses on the awful proliferation of meaningless surfaces that is, the banal and every day function of representation" (4).

14. In stark contrast to the narrative conventions of the novel, which traditionally rely on length and totality to describe life, the short, fragmentary form of Ligotti's stories communicates the ultimate condition of ontological dissonance that genre horror sees in the world. This brevity evokes, as we will discuss in the following, a corollary readerly terror that focuses on life's shortness.

15. Speculation like this that hinges upon the alternating dialectic of the real and the unreal is reminiscent of Lovecraft's constant use of the unreliable narrator. In "The Tomb" (1917), Lovecraft famously writes that "men of broader intellect know that there is no sharp distinction betwixt the real and the unreal; that all things appear as they do only by virtue of the delicate individual physical and mental media through which we are made conscious of them; but the prosaic materialism of the majority condemns as madness the flashes of super-sight which penetrate the common veil of obvious empiricism" (93).

16. In the thirteenth-century mystical text *The Journey of the Mind into God*, Saint Bonaventure notes that, "we may behold God in the mirror of visible creation, not only by considering creatures as vestiges of God, but also by seeing Him in them; for He is present in them in His essence, His power, and His presence" (11).

17. Such radical rejections of classical thought may be the result of horror's preoccupation with taboo interstices where cultural and linguistic systems fall apart. For instance, horror critic Stephen Prince, following Edmund Leach, notes a similar collapsing of self and world in body horror films such as David Cronenberg's *The Fly* (1986). He writes that "bodily products are universally tabooed because they are both 'me and not me,' confounding the initial boundary relation of self and world" (122).

18. In this story, we can posit that Ligotti uses art as a "medium of contingency," to follow the phrase used by Robin Mackay.

19. Here we are reminded of Wittgenstein's seventh basic proposition from the *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus*: "Whereof one cannot speak, thereof one must be silent" (108).

20. At present, it might do us well to note that historically there has been a discrepancy between the kind of opaque and inescapable oneirism that Ligotti posits and what we could call a "willed oneirism." The latter is perhaps best exemplified in the Samurai text *Hagakure*: "It is a good viewpoint to see the world as a dream. When you have something like a nightmare, you will wake up and tell yourself that it was only a dream. It is said that the world we live in is not a bit different from this" (82).

21. Lovecraft's early "Dreamlands" stories were also influenced by Dunsanian mysticism, in which dreamlike tales hovering between realism and fantasy were created. Dunsany started publishing his weird tales much earlier than Lovecraft, notably with *The Gods of Pegana* in 1905.

22. In the mid-nineteenth century American literature saw a rise in the male quest story, of which sea narratives like Melville's *Moby Dick* and Poe's *Pym* were notable. The sea, in all of its vastness and space, is not purely a geographical marker for them. Rather it is a medium of the beyond, a space where infinity, internal conflict, and the flux and flow of the unconscious is played out.

23. In his essay "Supernatural Horror in Literature," Lovecraft remarks that when crafting a weird tale "atmosphere is the all-important thing, for the final criterion of authenticity in not the dovetailing of a plot but the creation of a given sensation" (16).

24. Here we might call upon Benjamin Noys' Nathaniel, "What about the shadow out of time? You presume that the shadow comes from outside. You suggest, implicitly, some stable and material outside that forms the flipside of existent reality. I come with the good bad news, the shadow out of time does not exist outside time, it is time. Time itself is the shadowy vortex of a 'matter' that forms nothing and has no need of you, anyone or anything else" (284).

25. In stanza seven of "The Spiritual Canticle," John of the Cross writes of a similar mystical stuttering: "Y todos cuantos vagan / de ti me van mil gracias refiriendo, / y todos más me llagan, / y déjame muriendo / un no sé qué que queda balbuciando" (*The Collected Works*).

26. The godless deformity of this eternal blackness, articulated through a language that has no proper subject or object, "lead[ing] one to suppose that one is given to *understand* something different from what one is given to *see*," impresses upon readers a speculatively medieval aesthetic that is more akin to Hieronymous Bosch's painting *The Garden of Earthly Delights*, "produc[ing] its difference in *making us believe that it contains hidden meaning*" (De Certeau 51). As such, Ligotti's characters wander through a narrative space that is medievally dark.

27. There is also a fundamental relation found here between eternal blackness and the pure annihilation of all human and cosmic life. In *Nihil Unbound* (2007), for instance, Ray Brassier relates the notion of eternal blackness with the extinction of cosmos: "sooner or later both life and mind will have to reckon with the disintegration of the ultimate horizon, when, roughly one trillion, trillion, trillion (10^1728) years from now, the accelerating expansion of the universe will have disintegrated the fabric of matter itself, terminating the possibility of embodiment. Every star in the universe will have burnt out, plunging the cosmos into a state of absolute darkness and leaving behind nothing but spent husks of collapsed matter. All free matter, whether on planetary surfaces or in interstellar space, will have decayed, eradicating any remnants of life based in protons and chemistry, and erasing every vestige of sentience—irrespective of its physical basis. Finally, in a state cosmologists call 'asymptopia,' the stellar corpses littering the empty universe will evaporate into a brief hailstorm of elementary particles. Atoms themselves will cease to exist. Only the implacable gravitational expansion will continue, driven by the currently inexplicable force called 'dark energy,' which will keep pushing the extinguished universe deeper and deeper into an eternal and unfathomable blackness" (228).

28. The acclaimed historian Bernard McGinn notes that "many mystics from Dionysius on have insisted that it is the consciousness of God as negation, which is a form of the absence of God, that is the core of the mystic's journey. The author of *The Cloud of Unknowing* speaks of this with particular power: 'Leave aside this everywhere and this everything, in exchange for this nowhere and this nothing. . . . A man's affection is remarkably changed in the spiritual experience of this nothing when it is achieved nowhere. . . . It seems to him, sometimes, in his labor, that to look upon it is to look into hell'" (xix).

29. This knowing that unknows has mastery so great,
should any sage oppose

he'd blunder in debate,
being no such advocate
as know not knowing there,
burst the mind's barrier.
Of so supreme a kind
this eminence of thought,
as never the mightiest mind
dreamed about or sought.
souls beyond selfhood caught
know, not knowing, there:
burst the mind's barrier. (*Poems* 27, 29)

30. We can easily contrast apophatic mysticism to the modern mysticism of Aleister Crowley, for instance, which relied on ecstatic experiences to distinguish itself as a craft.

31. Rudolf Otto maintains that "one of the chiefest and most general features of mysticism is . . . *self-depreciation* . . . the estimation of the self, of the personal 'I,' as something not perfectly or essentially real, or even as mere nullity, a self-depreciation which comes to demand its own fulfillment in rejecting the delusion of selfhood, and so makes for the annihilation of self. And on the other hand mysticism leads to a valuation of the transcendent object of its reference as that which through plentitude of being stands supreme and absolute, so that the finite self contrasted with it becomes conscious even in its nullity that 'I am naught, Thou art all'" (21).

32. Emphasis in italics is ours.

33. Simone Weil states that "it is he who, through the operations of the dark night, withdraws himself in order not to be loved like the treasure is by the miser" (*Gravity and Grace* 15).

34. Ligotti deploys this term several times in *The Conspiracy Against the Human Race* to qualify his stance on whether life is worth living. Obviously, he does not. In "Suffering II," he puts it as such: "Naturally, the *uselessness* of all that is or could ever be is subject to the same repudiations as the *worthlessness* of all that is or could ever be. For this reason, the adverb 'malignantly' has been annexed to 'useless' to give it a little more semantic stretch and a dose of toxicity" (76).

35. So one way to think Ligottian darkness is to conceptualize it within the framework of what we can call the "Moses paradox," derived from an account of Moses's ascent to Mount Sinai from the vantage point of Dionysius the Areopagite's *Mystical Theology*. Just as Moses "plunges into the truly mysterious darkness of unknowing," characters in Ligottian horror fiction also reside in mysterious darkness but, contrary to Moses's experience of transcendence, vis-à-vis a non-experience with the divine, these characters hold non-experiences with the unreal.

36. In this way, Ligotti can be said to have heeded Matsuo Bashō's maxim: "Do not follow in the footsteps of the old masters. Seek what they sought."

37. This notion can be said to be a sibling term to what Denys Turner in *The Darkness of God* intuitively calls "apophatic anthropology." He notes that Meister Eckhart's metaphors of "'the fortress of the soul,' 'the ground of the soul,' a refuge of the spirit,' 'a silence,' 'a desert' . . . are metaphors of what might be called 'apophatic anthropology,' as if to say there is something unknowable about the self, as much as, in more familiar terms, of an 'apophatic theology,' for which God is unknowable" (140).

38. Cf. "And we may loiter among those in paradise, this is the great news I bring to you tonight. We may take our place among the puppets" (*Noctuary* 122).

39. This enactment is also similarly expressed through the analogy of the texture of the human body. Dylan Trigg insightfully indicates the essential relation between the inhumanity of the body and the non-experience of spiritual depersonalization once expressed in a letter by French poet Stéphane Mallarmé: "I have seen the frost that coats the human body. Its texture is smooth and changes in the light. Over time, the frost develops cracks and falls to the earth, in the process revealing the inhumanity of

the body we grow inadvertently attached to. In a letter, I once read how the body can decompose and yet remain present, leaving the residue of a ghost in its wake: 'I am now depersonalized; I am no longer Mallarmé, but simply a means whereby the spiritual universe can become visible and can develop through what was once me.'" We can appropriate Mallarmé's (non-)experience of the body by way of analogy to this non-experience of reading, in which the depersonalization of the reading experience becomes the shepherding apparatus of the world-without-us.

THREE

Georges Bataille

Opening Up the Infinite

THE *SUMMA ATHEOLOGICA*: REVELATIONS OF A WEIRD MYSTICISM

The latter half of the twentieth century came to know Georges Bataille's heterogeneous thought mainly through the careful scrutiny of leading French intellectuals and theorists in the late 1960s and early 1970s, those gathered in the school of critical theory commonly known as post-structuralism. Philippe Sollers considered Bataille the "godfather" of the *Tel Quel* circle who greatly inspired an ensuing generation of French thinkers including Jacques Derrida, Jacques Lacan, Roland Barthes, and Julia Kristeva (Holsinger 2). Michel Foucault regarded Bataille as one of the leading thinkers of the twentieth century. And yet Denis Hollier writes that "there is something anachronistic in associating Bataille, a writer who died even before people started to talk about structuralism, with post-structuralism" (*Against Architecture* iv). Although the initial association might be anachronistic, the reason for his careful treatment by post-structuralists is clear: Bataille is a writer who writhes against the confines of syntax and language, struggling always to free himself from the limits of discourse. Bataille writes that "th[e] movement of my thought which flees from me—not only can I not avoid it, but there is no moment no secret that doesn't animate me. Thus I speak—everything in me gives itself to others" (*Inner Experience* 128–29). And the fact that he articulates this about his thought and writing, that he articulates himself, gives him a certain translatability and "sell factor" among those who become his explicators. Bataille's thought manifests through the event horizon of an authorial black hole, one relentlessly absorbing and eviscerating the con-

stant desire to write about himself, as he tries to get to (and communicate to others) what happens when one encounters a beyond which is impossibly excessive, sovereign. Offering up the personal records of these encounters through abstruse forms of writing, motifs such as impossibility, eroticism, desire, immensity, and nothingness permeate his work. With all of its poetic thrashings about, the experience of reading one of his texts becomes a disgusting yet beautiful thing. Bataille's texts decapitate us, do violence to us. His texts stage this decapitation as they provide a scaffolding for one's self-execution. But what exactly affords his texts such mystique?

Recognizing his undoubted prescience, Nidesh Lawtoo writes that "Bataille is now mostly remembered as a precursor of the poststructuralist 'death of the subject,' an unrecognized giant who, in an untimely fashion, prepared the ground for the burial of a reassuring notion of the 'subject' that is always centered on itself" (73). Keeping this in mind, one can see why the post-structuralists would have such a vested interest in this modern man who modeled for them forms of writing that, according to Jacques Derrida, '*exceeds* the *logos* of meaning, lordship, presence etc.' precipitating philosophical concepts towards ruin" (qtd. in *Bataille Reader* 4). Yet for us to situate Bataille within a nexus of only post-structural readings would be to relegate the profundity of his thought to just one historical moment. On the one hand, twenty-first-century readers of Bataille are greatly indebted to post-structuralism's deep interest and subsequent recovery of Bataille, a writer who, although highly regarded during his writing life among small radical and literary circles, was not exactly widely read during his lifetime. To an extent, Bataille retains still a significantly marginalized readership within the academy, with much of his following coming from the intellectual and subcultural undergrounds—à la para-academia.[1] On the other hand, then, it seems to be the case that to base our analysis of Bataille's work purely within the scope of "the linguistic turn" in philosophy, we would be committing a sin of omission.

Although Bataille has attracted more attention from those affiliated with the linguistic turn, there are several contemporary scholars who locate Bataille's work within the context of traditional mysticism as well as within the more recent "speculative turn" in philosophy. In his innovative book *The Premodern Condition* (2005), for example, Bruce Holsinger reveals Bataille's intellectual interest with hermeneutic practices and texts of the Middle Ages. Other scholars such as Peter Tracey Connor, Amy Hollywood, and Allan Stoekl each demonstrate how Bataille's infatuation with paradox is in fact linked to a preoccupation with studying medieval and non-Western mysticisms. There is a growing consensus among these scholars on the fundamental importance of his mystical writings, a paradigm in which Bataille's eroticism of thought is contingent on a pursuit of immanence.

This chapter seeks to join with these scholars as well as to conjoin Bataille's work to "the weird." Despite a scholarly desire to positively identify with the hermeneutics of analysis, the interpretive method of this chapter becomes a Bataillean one, a way of thinking and close reading that exists at the limits of criticism. It thus seeks, at a base level, to perform what it describes, to engage with and elevate the importance of a set of central concerns which are also those of Bataille's pursuit: the vertiginous pull of/from/toward the mystical to be neither itself nor nothing else. Bataille's wanderings were not only intellectual but spiritual, a point that has been neglected for some time in prevailing scholarship. Adding to scholarship on Bataille's mystical texts will help to create a bridge between the intellectual and the mystical, reviving discussions about the importance of studying "esoterica" to introduce new methods of critique and modes of thinking.

In doing so, dialogues on the investigation into how notions of medieval mysticism function in modern literature and theory may be more apt to take place. As noted in chapter 1, in Allan Stoekl's *Bataille's Peak*, for example, there is an insightful moment which, relegated to a content note on occult philosopher Giordano Bruno, has not yet been given due consideration. Stoekl, highlighting the tradition of empiricism in fourteenth-century European philosophy, notices an attempt in Duns Scotus and William of Ockham to separate empirical observation from revealed occult wisdom; Giordano Bruno, on the other hand, was unable to separate science from mysticism. For Bruno, science served to synthesize the occult. The same sort of inability to divide the inner and outer worlds is found in modern works by Georges Bataille, as he was unable "to separate entirely materialism from a 'weird mysticism' either" (Stoekl 208). As we will see, the Bataille of the late 1930s and early 1940s turned increasingly to medieval mysticism to buttress his ideas of inner experience and non-knowledge, each of which was enacted through a meandering, fragmented mode of writing[2] we will henceforth classify as "weird."

Attentiveness to the context of traditional mysticism alongside the other critical scholarship on Bataille is not only necessary to an understanding of his cultural and theoretical impact, but also opens up new, more speculative lines of critical discourse. In his book *In the Dust of This Planet*, for instance, Eugene Thacker offers a fascinating and original contribution to the study of Bataille and succeeds in presenting how the ingenuity of Bataille's thought is to be measured not only by its semantic profundity, but also as a pertinent interposition in speculative discourse on the mystical text. For example, he writes that in his enigmatic text entitled "The Congested Planet," Bataille attempts something unheard of in the mystical traditions: "to conceive of a non-human mysticism that would also refuse all forms of anthropomorphic personification" (145). According to Thacker, other works by Bataille, including *The Accursed Share* and *Theory of Religion*, suggest a similar "mysticism of the unhu-

man" (149). Utilizing negation and contradiction, Bataille's mysticism enables him to identify the human as well as non-human aspect of existence, blurring the distinction between human and world, but also between world and world, for "to exist *as* the world, we must cease existing *in* the world" (149).

The term "mystical" holds various meanings. Given connections to Free Spirit heresy and the anti-nomian elements of their work, mystics such as Meister Eckhart or Marguerite Porete, for instance, both of whom wrote within the medieval tradition of the *via negativa*, are perhaps best characterized as unrepentant heretics. This section's heading, "The *Summa Atheologica*: Revelations of a Weird Mysticism," intends to show one of the (albeit confusing) ways in which Bataille conceives of the mystical. Although he intends to describe mystical experience by way of his term "inner experience," he lacks a proper definition, noting: "I envisage less 'confessional experience' . . . than experience in itself, free of ties, be they vague, to any confession whatsoever. This is what justifies the abandonment of the word 'mystical,' to which I could not adhere without confusion" (*Inner Experience* 174). He at once wishes to impart to his readers a series of transcriptions of his mystical experiences, ones no less that were likely spawned from his erudite knowledge on the subject of Christian and non-Western mysticisms, while also distancing himself from those traditions by ultimately abandoning the word "mystical." Bataille thus enacts the simultaneous invocation and erasure of the term "mystical" in order to begin his own doctrine-less doctrine, so to speak, one that will wander boundlessly and aimlessly to and fro. Noting *Guilty*, Amy Hollywood posits that Bataille conceives writing as wandering, for "to write is to go elsewhere. The bird who sings and the man who writes deliver themselves" (*Sensible Ecstasy* 106). Keeping this context in mind, we can argue that Bataille's wavering between mysticism and non-mysticism is, as it turns and bends itself, truly, a *weird* mysticism.

To pursue this line of thinking, we need look no farther than to the term's etymology. As referenced in chapter 1, etymologically speaking, the term "weird" is synonymous with becoming. It is also synonymous with nomadism, wandering, going elsewhere: "the word 'weird' (traditionally related to 'wyrd,' or 'fate') is related to the Old English weorðan ['to become'], rooted in Indo-European *wer- ['to turn, bend']" (Joy 30). As its title suggests, this section aims to reflect upon the ways in which several of Bataille's mystical texts are in fact weird wanderings, turnings, bendings, becomings. In fact, Roger Luckhurst, in "The Weird: A Dis/Orientation," notes that "the waywardness of the weird is also a matter of the slipperiness of form, a refusal to fit narrative or generic expectation" (1050). As such, Bataille's mystical texts are, paradoxically speaking, failures and reclamations of the mystical tradition; all the while the texts *wander*, *turn*, *bend*, becoming something entirely new, even heretical. By creating a modern mysticism that's own auto-abnegating impetus is to

bend itself, the fate of its medieval lineage becomes severed from itself. In this context, then, what we mean by "weird mysticism" is that Bataille deploys mystical writing to wander far beyond discourse (as mystic, to find experience in itself and, as writer, in the sense of a achieving a discourse beyond discourse), but that these modes are also failures, or willed perversions, of traditional mysticism.

At this juncture, then, it is necessary to pinpoint a particular mode of writing that Bataille utilizes (and then abandons) in wartime texts such as *Guilty* or *Inner Experience*, which we will call the "epigrammatic fragment" or "confessional utterance." In her fascinating study of mysticism in twentieth-century thinkers, Amy Hollywood claims that although Bataille is not exactly a mystic in the strict historical sense of the term, one can see, especially in his texts from the late 1930s and 1940s, a deep interest in the writings of Christian and non-Western mysticisms. She identifies Bataille's writing within the context of several medieval women mystics, especially the work of Angela of Foligno and Mechthild of Magdeburg, who wrote in the confessional mode initiated by Augustine, but whose "radical differences between the nature of their experience and that of Augustine lead them to a different set of writing and rhetorical practices" (*Sensible Ecstasy* 101). Bataille's writings during World War II share with texts like Mechthild's *The Flowing Light of the Godhead* a "variety of genres" that are "fragmentary in form" (102). Surviving at the liminal point where states of ecstasy and anguish encounter each other at the limits of the human,[3] Bataille's fragmentary confessions allow a monadic self to wander through bewildering paths and into sovereign inner experience. At the heart of this sovereignty sits the horror of its ineffability, the written remnants of an unspeakable reality capable only of being transcribed by appropriating and then exploiting mystical confessional discourse through fragmentary writing techniques.[4]

Let us take, for example, *Inner Experience*, the first part of his tripartite work the *Summa Atheologica*, in which Bataille writes that "despair, impatience, horror at myself, in time delivered me—even while I was trying sometimes to find once again the bewildering path of ecstasy, sometimes to be done with it, to go resolutely to bed, to sleep" (127). The inner experience Bataille describes is marked by an ontological but also an impossible desire to describe that which is unequivocally ineffable. Not only does this mean mystical ecstasy in itself, but also the fact of losing himself on a wandering path, one he must traverse to get there, becoming bewildered, weird.[5]

Just as in Lovecraftian horror, ineffability is of course one of the longstanding tenets of a mystical experience with the divine, constantly destabilizing the mystic at the level of the Word, of language, distilling the experience itself into a non-experience which cannot be quantified, classified, or spoken of in any kind of formal way. Attending to the issue of ineffability, Leslie Boldt observes that Bataille's texts

> operate within a space which is no longer incomplete vis-à-vis a transcendent unlimited "beyond," but within one which is "made and unmade" by the transgression of its own limits—in particular as sexual experience reveals the absence of God. It is a space which is *interior* and *sovereign*, locked by the Unspeakable which exists at the margins, an impossible abyss glimpsed at the moment of transgression. (ix)

Bataille's transcriptions of his experiences of the abyssal beyond, ones marked by the absence of God,[6] are fundamentally mystical in nature, in that they genuinely attempt to speak about the Unspeakable. In view of this, the thrust of this entire chapter, then, concerns itself with an overarching question: If Bataille transcribes his thought via fragmentary, often epigrammatic, mystical utterances that intend to speak about the Unspeakable, then what exactly does this fragmentary mode of writing do (or fail to do) that other modes cannot?

As noted earlier, Bataille draws upon medieval predecessors in order to contextualize for himself the types of experiences he is having, but "Bataille's insistence on calling himself a mystic was a provocation," writes Surya (302). In dispensing with God, Bataille also abandons the tradition of Christian mysticism in order to free himself from their imaginary trances" (Surya 302), envisioning an "experience in itself, free of ties, be they vague, to any confession whatsoever. This is what justifies the abandonment of the word 'mystical'" (Bataille, *IE* 174). According to Nick Land,

> it is because he is a writer that Bataille disdains to be a mystic. . . . Inner experience translates mysticism into a vagrant vocabulary at the scurf-edge of tradition . . . and thinks interiority not as the secret recess of the self, but as a plane of contact and contagion. The core of inner experience is not personal identity, but naked intensity, denuded even of oneself, and jutting from the refuse of Christian dogmatics as a broken lurch into the unknown. He insists: "Inner experience is ecstasy" whilst "ecstasy is . . . communication, opposing itself to the subsistence onto oneself" (V 24). (122)

Put another way, then, because Bataille is first and foremost a writer, his elliptical writing style can in part be said to be the result of epigrammatic thoughts and impressions, mystical wanderings into "experience in itself." And much like Clarice Lispector, who declares, "As I write I do not know myself, I forget myself. The I who appears . . . is not I" (*A Breath of Life* 11), Bataille is a mystic because he is a writer in an unspeakable sense, because he plunges into the mysticism of writing itself. These fragmented wanderings of mystical language into "the scurf-edge of tradition" mimic the sovereign experience of "naked intensity," evocative of an unspeakable trauma over the ineffability of the beyond, one that, Bataille might argue, a person seeking absolute sovereignty must experience.

In *Guilty*, the persistence of fragmentation in part implies intent on Bataille's behalf to break with conventional narrative, to weirdly "turn" or "bend" how readers view eroticism, death, the void, the divine. He writes,

> The finality of finite beings leaves them at the limit of themselves. And this limit is lacerated. (Hence the lacerating sense of *curiosity*!)
> Only cowardice and exhaustion prevent this.
> Poised on the void, you intuit horror in its depths.
> From every direction, other lacerated beings approach, sick like you from the same horror. They are sick with the same attraction. (142)

In this example, fragmentation is not only a mode, one characterized by chaotic line breaks and short autopoietic sentences, but also a trope, in that the limit-experience itself is defined as lacerating and exhaustive. This play between mode and trope turns ideas that are initially legible into something almost illegible, evocative of a bewildering unspeakability that, although shrewdly and voraciously thought about, is only evinced through intellectual mutterings, elliptical ideas, turns of phrases, etc. As such, Bataille could be said to be attempting to think his way through the horror of the Unthinkable via a mode of negativity, or unthinking, in which only fragmented transcriptions of thought are manifested, the mystical resonances of a non-experience with absolute formlessness.[7]

Put yet another way, the question of Bataille's paradoxical relationship to mysticism thus becomes: How does one speak about the unspeakable without reducing it to a form of knowledge? Or, how does one think about an inner experience that cannot be contained or correlated by the mind? Let us first try to see the question from the side of a positive logic. In this sense, from a certain type of reader's point of view, a reader who perhaps esteems telos over chance, trying to situate the ineffable experience Bataille attempts to describe is symptomatic of a rationalistic or correlational desire to make meaning out of an irreverent chaos. But against this readership (and in good stead), one may view Bataille through a negative logic. His texts are, of course, working very hard not to be pinned down, violating systematic rules across the board. In the sense of a negative logic, Bataille's writing practice, not altogether a traditional mysticism and not entirely a weird fiction, enters into the genre as a bastard. And like all "bastards," he confounds and offends as a simple material presence that proclaims at once a link to the sacred lineage and to desire.

In light of this generic bastardization, one which claims no lineage to God or master, if we were to try a hand at condensing into a sentence Bataille's approach to transcribing thought—marked by heterology, eroticism, excess, non-knowledge, a-theology—we might say that it is to write the self, unfolding ceaselessly and (un)knowingly to its brink: "I

can know that I am a point, a wave lost in other waves," writes Bataille, "laugh at myself, at the comedy of 'originality' that I remain; I at the same time can only say to myself: I am alone, bitter" (*Inner Experience* 129). As such, his writing, in its constant states of paradox and negativity, seems to recapitulate the excess it describes. Showing a strong distaste for the organic, Bataille's writing opts out of wholeness toward a much more radical form of cultural production that utilizes ruptures, breaks, and excesses as a means to simultaneously maintain and perturb itself. "The sovereignty described in *Inner Experience*," writes Leslie Anne Boldt, "is in no way subordinate to or revealed through discourse, but rather arises out of the moment of its rupture" (x). With this, one can see that the ineffable is in fact better approached through radical, fragmentary writing techniques rather than those that cling to orthodoxy. The anarcho-mystical thrust of such writing thus sets the stage for its *weirdness*, its wandering about or becoming-something-other-than-itself. For example, when Bataille writes that "one cannot speak of the knowledge of which God has of himself if not by negations—suffocating negations—images of tongues cut out. Now one abuses oneself in this way, one passes from one level to the other: suffocation, silence are dependent upon experience and not on discourse" (*Inner Experience* 107), he emphasizes, like the confessional mystics before him, the inability of the intellect to know God through positive logic. And yet he also goes on to stress that to extend the limits of infinite knowledge within oneself, one must exploit non-discursive modes of knowledge.

Relying on, bending, and then going beyond models derived from the medieval Christian female mystics, for example, Bataille utilizes a negative mode of communication whereby inner experience becomes a "weird" perversion of mysticism, but one capable of pure communication. In *The Dark Gaze*, Kevin Hart explains that "Bataille insists that mystical ecstasy is a limiting of inner experience: the quest for the unknown is subjugated to what is already known. Even Saint John of the Cross and Saint Theresa of Avila, both of whom valued intellectual visions over the more consoling sensual visions, fall short of inner experience" (30).

As one can see, it is not easy to locate Bataille within a political, theological, or literary framework. But it is possible to trace the trajectory of his shifting interests. After his focus shifted from the theory and practice of building radical communities like Acéphale and the College of Sociology in the late 1930s,[8] Bataille returned to the book as his primary medium during the onslaught of World War II. The book is a paradoxical entity for Bataille and will remain so throughout the course of his life. This notion is evidenced early in the 1940s by his three-part opus consisting of *Inner Experience* (1943), *Guilty* (1944), and *On Nietzsche* (1945). These three texts came to be known under the moniker of the *La Somme athéologique* or *Summa Atheologica*. The *Summa Atheologica* directly parallels and mocks the title of the famous thirteenth-century theological text called *Summa*

Theologica by Thomas Aquinas. Whereas Aquinas's text is a collection of theological wisdoms important to the Catholic Church, Bataille's collection becomes a framework for the production of radical thought on individual sovereignty.

In the *Summa Atheologica*, Bataille's earlier 1930s emphasis on acephalic (meaning "headless") community paradoxically transmutes into the form of the book. "The 'a' added to theology," writes Benjamin Noys, "is an attempt to deprive theology of its 'head' (God) and to lead to a new post-Nietzschean 'headless theology'" (*Georges Bataille* 47). Historically speaking, Bataille's interest in Nietzsche in the early to mid-1940s is very different from its perversion by Nazi Germany. Bataille's reclamation of Nietzsche is well-documented—by both Bataille and his historians—namely because it serves a dual purpose. Not only does it allow him to write from a position of freedom (from fascism) but it also functions as a threshold-passing occasion in the transcription of his thought. Noys writes that,

> *Inner Experience* was impossible without Nietzsche because it was written after the death of God. It was also an opening of a path to *On Nietzsche* through an experience of meditation and mysticism which is separated from God or divine contemplation: "being concerned to communicate an inner experience . . . outside the pale of specific religions" (*IE*, 34). This is an inner experience because it has no reference outside of itself, either to knowledge or to God. (*Georges Bataille* 47)

In this passage, Noys helpfully and appropriately casts Bataille's use of Nietzsche as a bridge to an even higher level of anarcho-mystical thought. According to Bataille, inner experience is sovereignty unbound.

Bataille's leitmotif of sovereignty via non-religious mystical practice is evidenced throughout the entirety of the *Summa Atheologica*. To show how Bataille saturates the collection in weird mystical language, let us again take the example of the collection's second part entitled *Guilty*. *Guilty* is an experimental text that records a series of war-time meditations and illuminations in automatic fashion, ranging from speedy dictations of non-religious mystical experience to dizzying notes on meditative techniques. In *Guilty*, Bataille attempts to comprehend incomprehensible mystical experiences through the medium of textual transcription, jotting fragmentary, often choppy notes on themes such as ecstasy, the death of God, sex, and the beyond. In "The Point of Ecstasy," Bataille writes,

> Method in meditation is analogous to technique in sacrifice. The point of ecstasy is bared if inside myself I shatter individuality that confines me to myself. So too sacredness replaces an animal in the exact moment the priest kills or destroys it.
> Chancing of an image of torture, I can turn away in fright. But if I look I'm *beside myself*. . . . The confining and limiting world of my individual

> being opens up when, horrified, I see torture. A sight of torture opens my individual being violently, lacerates it.
> What doesn't follow is that through laceration I can reach a beyond. (*Guilty* 35)

In this example, horror is experienced as a reaction to an image of torture. Alexander Irwin reminds us that "in his 1961 preface to the re-edition of *Guilty*, Bataille described his mysticism as 'essentially internalized violence'" (151). In sacrificing himself, mysticism opens up his limited individual being by lacerating his ego-laden partitions to the point of ecstasy. This passage is not simply a dramatic gesture. It calls into question the very relation between mystical ecstasy and writing. The overwhelming desire to write about his experiences collapses the division between method and ecstasy, or, to be sure, between form and content. Bataille's fragmentary transcriptions in *Guilty*, a form no less of lacerated thought, is hardly accidental.

Writing, then, becomes the attempt to horrifically push language to its impossible limit, to coerce language to become what it describes. As such, his writing practice embodies, to follow Amy Hollywood, the act of *exscription*, a neologism coined by Jean-Luc Nancy to describe texts that "point outside themselves to an experience that is constituted in the very act of writing" ("Bataille and Mysticism" 84). Bataille's ex-scriptive mode of writing in the *Summa Atheologica* introduces radical methods to think the unthinkable. He can be said to both validate and annihilate his mystic predecessors. For example, in *Inner Experience* he describes "inner experience" as such:

> By "inner experience" I mean what one normally designates by the name of "mystical experience"—the experience of ecstasy, of rapture, or at least of meditated emotion. But I envisage less "confessional experience"—to which one in general refers—than experience in itself, free of ties, be they vague, to any confession whatsoever. This is what justifies the abandonment of the word "mystical," to which I could not adhere without confusion. (174)

The weirdness (i.e., aimlessness, wandering) found in this example is that Bataille thus relies upon, perverts, and then ultimately abandons traditional mystical discourse in order to go beyond (both confessional discourse), to enact an experience in itself, a beyond that blurs the division not only between self and world but between world and world. But weird in this traditional sense also connotes exposure to the fated, which in this case, is a kind of self-exposure to the violence of being oneself. For Bataille, individuation is the ultimate weird. He writes,

> I can't confuse myself with the world, which my value won't change. The world is not me; personally, I am *nothing*. The leaves and flowers of spring, the limitless diversity, the earth at sunset sliding with its plains, mountains, and seas, through the skies. . . . But if the world, in a sense,

> is man (which I am through and through), it is also on the condition of forgetting that it is (what falls is the night of Aminadab). (*Guilty* 94)

In this passage, readers also come face to face with a unique problematic that this auto-annihilating mystical practice poses—the paradox of its *textuality*. This paradox reveals the contingent and irreducibly textual dimension to the *Summa Atheologica*, which problematizes the purely mystical by linking it to writing and (anti-)genre. The valuing of the book's materiality as such, indicating writing's own paradoxical relation to mysticism, allows for the construction of a bridge between the book's textuality and the performance-oriented aspects of mystical practice. Thus, in yet another example from *Guilty*, Bataille argues that "writing is never more than a game played with an ungraspable reality" (*Guilty* 41). Amy Hollywood notes that this form of writing is "the production of a textual experience of desire without limit, without end, without aim" (83). It is precisely because the transcriptions of his thought are so anti-generic and non-systematic that books like *Inner Experience* and *Guilty* can hardly be said to be books at all. They are not formally what one would call journaling and even less so what one thinks of as being a modern novel; the collection can be said to resemble books, but ones exhausted to intense, fragmentary, and at times incomprehensible degrees. For Bataille, fragmentariness showcases the incessant failure of thought, of an impossible ontological desire to think a world without limits. There is an inherent connection here to the fragmentary nature of Lovecraft's "The Call of Cthulhu," which, according to E. F. Bleiler, is a "fragmented essay with narrative inclusions" (478). The fragmentariness in Lovecraft is also connected to thinking a world without limits—in which humankind itself is the horrific expression of failure (i.e., the failure of the cosmos to fully realize itself).

In other words, Bataille's writings are fragmentary in part because his modes of thought are in constant states of flux. One example of this flux is found in the preface to *On Nietzsche*, where Bataille makes this notion clear. "Only my life, only its ludicrous resources, only these made a quest for the grail of chance possible for me," he writes, "Chance, as it turned out, corresponded to Nietzsche's intentions more accurately than power could" (xxv–xxvi). The authorial or autobiographical impetus to writing *On Nietzsche*, the third and final installment of the *Summa Atheologica*, can be said to stem from a desire to enter madness, but the tone in which the text is written reveals a self-reflexive desire to laugh, to show the reader that the very experience of writing the text *is* a Nietzschean one: "But what does this fragmentation mean, or, better, what is its cause, if not a need to *act* that specializes us and limits us to the horizon of a particular activity? . . . Life is whole only when it isn't subordinated to a specific object that exceeds it" (xxvi–xxvii). Fragmentary and divergent as it is, Bataille's writing evokes a form of non-knowledge that encapsulates (and

then rescinds) not artistic expression but rather the rigorous interplay of a mystical failure of language and an impossible ontological desire to think a world without limits.

The non-experiences described in the fragmentary, purposefully disordered, and virtually automatically written meditations in the *Summa Atheologica* are ones that touch, as Benjamin Noys notes,

> on the impossible. For Bataille the impossible is not an object of experience to be meditated on, like a contemplation of the void, but the possibility of the experience as well: "In this sense, the inner experience is throughout an experience of the impossible (the impossible being both that which we experience and that which constitutes the experience)" (*IE*, 26). The impossibility of this experience and the difficulty of describing it without reducing it to a form of knowledge relate it to Nietzsche's transcriptions of his experiences. (*Georges Bataille* 48)

The impossible is double, then, and also deictic. Double because when it is transcribed it serves as the negative index to the experience that it tries to describe; deictic because this negative index points to its own taking place. Thus, the impossible is not a "form of knowledge," but rather the praxis of a weird mysticism vis-à-vis the modality of textuality.

Ceaselessly inaccessible, as it points to its own taking place, Bataille's weird meanderings become hauntological phantoms that at once help to advance the transcription of his thought and yet negate its very graspability. As we will soon see, Bataille's weird mysticism is not only found in the *Summa Atheologica*, the wartime collection of texts that at times resemble quasi-journals, but also in his fiction and poetry. Writing during and after the high modernist era, Bataille's later work, especially his poetry, tends to deviate from high modernist European discourse. While Bataille's writings are decidedly "anti-generic," to borrow again the term from Amy Hollywood, if pressed to do so, we could say that his poetry and fiction echo modernist experiments with representation, notably the fractured narrative. However, aside from this formal feature, Bataille is anathema to high modernist ideals. After the break with André Breton, Bataille's work staunchly repudiates any celebration of the human. Moreover, he does not revel in the commercialization of art or intellect, imitate prose aesthetic styles, or tend to displace ideas or emotions onto simple descriptions of actions or objects. Rather, the concept of expression will ultimately be replaced with that of self-negation.

Bataille enters this book in the liminal space between a necessary fiction and a traditional mysticism. We will further examine Bataille's weird mysticism in the remaining three sections. The first is an analysis of the intersection of Bataille's work and traditional mysticism—an analysis of Bataille's "weird" writing practice, one that evokes terror and horror, in relation to "the night of an absent God" as we consider his experimental work called *The Impossible*. In the next section we will engage with his

mystical poetry to posit that there is a gap in discourse on Bataille's poetry—as a textual object and as *poiesis*—that should be explored more fully, while we consider other issues he raises about the nature of horror through engaging with the genre of poetry that may help us to understand his other works. In the final section we will examine the harrowing, often enigmatic, presence of mystical sorrow in his work. The intent here is to illuminate how the act of writing, the de-actualized heart of Bataille's weird mysticism, as it blurs the distinction between the post-structural emphasis on textual materiality and the performance-oriented caveats of mysticism, becomes an ontological hesitation, a third space equally created and destroyed by Bataille in order to think the abyss that exists beyond the correlation between himself and the world. In so doing, we will highlight the ways in which this anti-genre of writing, when considered alongside his vested desire to achieve the impossible, is actually the human remainder of accessing a non-human reality.

TERROR, HORROR, AND THE ABSENCE OF GOD

Aside from its odd narrative style and fragmented structure, perhaps the most distinctive feature about Georges Bataille's *The Impossible* (1962), an experimental three-part work of prose, poetry, and commentary, is the dizzying experience of reading it. In the book's first section, "A Story of Rats," the narrator obsessively seeks an ecstatic experience that exists just beyond the point of his own self-knowledge. This sacred experience reveals itself in rupture, in the alternating gap between what can be sensed and not-sensed, between God and not-God. In one focal scene toward the end of the story, the narrator recalls a dinner he had the day before with his girlfriend, B., and B.'s father, a monsignor. As he does so, he provides readers with an esoteric commentary on the dinner itself. What one not prone to thinking to the limits of thought might deem an ordinary dinner, the narrator sees as a vertiginous pull toward the abyss, speculating,

> These moments of intoxication when we defy everything, when, the anchor raised, we go merrily towards the abyss, with no more thought for the inevitable fall that for the limits given in the beginning, are the only ones when we are completely free of the ground (of laws). . . .
>
> Nothing exists that doesn't have this *senseless sense*—common to flames, dreams, uncontrollable laughter—in these moments when consumption accelerates, beyond the desire to endure. Even utter senselessness ultimately is always this sense made of the negation of all others. (Isn't this sense basically that of each particular being who, as such, is the *senselessness* of all the others . . . and thought (philosophy) is at the limit of this conflagration, like a candle blown out at the limit of a flame.). (20)

Not only does this drunken dinner serve as a gateway into ecstatic experience, but it also serves as a commentary on the sense-less nature of what happens at the limits of thought (what the narrator calls philosophy), the rapturous, negative moment when thought itself dissolves. Being a cross-genre book that intratextually weaves together these motifs into a fractured narrative and then undercuts its own constituent parts via characters that continually perform their own self-negation, *The Impossible* is a notable example of how Bataille deploys a mode of writing that not only produces a text but also indicates its own taking place. In other words, what he terms "the impossible" is, dialectically, a literary artifact (product) and a mode of writing (producer). It is also, perhaps most importantly, a self-dissolving experience that occurs at the very limits of the human, unveiling to the anguished subject the ecstatic movement of a liberating horror that comes at the moment of ego-death.

This section invites us to think about the heaviness of such a liberating horror. In the preface to the second edition of *The Impossible*, Bataille offers readers a powerful passage which helps to contextualize the authorial impetus to writing "A Story of Rats." He writes that "these evocations have a painful heaviness about them. This heaviness may be tied to the fact that at times horror had a real presence in my life. It may be too that, even when reached in fiction, horror alone still enabled me to escape the empty feeling of untruth" (9). Avid readers of books are sure to appreciate the nature of a preface. Typically, a preface is written by an author in order to introduce the book, to give background information on how the idea of the book was conceived, and, by way of an anecdote or other personal marker, to give thanks to those whom may have helped along the way. Readers familiar with the work of Georges Bataille will recognize the intoxicatingly heavy tone of his brief preface to *The Impossible*, a tone that is characteristic of Bataille's uncompromising, almost impenetrable writing style. Those who are unfamiliar might be taken aback, bewildered as to what place, if any, this peculiar path might lead them. Yet, whether one is familiar with Bataille or not, one precipitating word stands out, a word that may inevitably disturb the reader throughout the remaining pages of the text: horror.

Bataille's heedful use of the word in part reveals to readers an autobiographical impetus to his work. Horror has held a haunting, heavy presence in Bataille's private life.[9] For most people, until its outer arrival is internally proclaimed, a person's experience of horror is not typically characterized by its presence but rather its absence—the terror, if you will, of its *suspension*. In this sense horror is a veritable negativity, a backwards enacting of reality opened up by the sheer obscurity of affective terror. Terror and horror are indeed two separate terms, and yet Bataille will soon choose to place them side by side, complicating the reader's relationship to the terms themselves. Thus, at another moment in *The Impossible*, we read:

> How *sweet* terror is!
> Unimaginable, basically, the lack of suffering and the skin deep-nature of sorrow, the lack of reality, the dream-like consistency of the horrible. Yet I was *in the suspense of death*.
> What do we know by dint of living if the death of the beloved does not usher in horror (emptiness) at the very point where we cannot bear to enter: but then we know what door the key opens. (62–63)

In this passage, we find several key terms—terror, death, sorrow, horror—that will become central to our analysis of Bataille as we move forward. At present, two main questions arise. First, to what extent does the term "terror" inform our reading of Bataillean horror? On the one hand, the narrator says that the suspense of death causes terror to be *sweet*, a tasteful pleasure experienced at life's very limits. On the other hand, we can argue that this terror is part and parcel of a mystical dilemma, a "terror before the absence of God" (Boldt xxvii). As such, terror is the painful metaphysical residue of a self-annihilating experience that expands the horror and emptiness found at the barrier between what is human and divine. And secondly, how is Bataille's relation to the mystical fundamentally "weird"?

Let us start with the second question and move backwards into the first. Although Bataille is not typically a writer who comes to mind when one thinks of genre horror, the connection that he evokes between terror and horror holds a close relation to the long tradition known as "the weird." In chapter 1, we acknowledged the role of terror/horror in premodern mysticism, especially with regard to the thirteenth-century mystic Hadewijch of Antwerp, who wrote that divine Love draws one into a "frightening life" (75). Critical discourse on terror and horror can also be traced back to its Gothic invention, beginning with Ann Radcliffe who, in her 1826 essay entitled "On the Supernatural in Poetry," delineated between the two terms in regard to their affective timbre. "Terror and Horror are so far opposite," writes Radcliffe, "that the first expands the soul, and awakens the faculties to a high degree of life; the other contracts, freezes and nearly annihilates them. . . . And where lies the difference between horror and terror, but in the uncertainty and obscurity that accompany the first, respecting the dreading evil?" (315). By centralizing the focus to the emotional responses experienced by readers rather than just noting stylistic or thematic conventions, Radcliffe marks an important shift in the Gothic genre. The experience of reading Gothic literature thus took on two distinctive traits (which, not uncharacteristic of the early nineteenth century, were also features characteristic of *the soul*). Terror leads to a kind of sublime "obscurity," whereas horror "freezes and nearly annihilates." Critic Stephen Bruhm argues that "terror situates us within the social world, while horror freezes us within the self" (*Gothic Bodies* 37). In chapter 2, we formulated that horror is, following Maurice Merleau-Ponty, not a freezing of the self but more so a "freezing of be-

ing," wherein petrification via the particularity of stone becomes manifest. According to this formulation, horror, then, is not that which freezes the self, but rather is a passageway of human consciousness to its cosmic origin point.

For now, let it suffice to say that Radcliffe's distinction between the two terms set a precedent for understanding a new kind of reading experience which tended to overload readers' affective responses to the text. The Gothic genre, however, does fail to account for several important things. As the Gothic aged and its conventions were appropriated by other genres, notably by the early twentieth-century literary phenomenon of "weird fiction," the distinctions took on slightly different resonances and were embraced to a new end. For example, in *The Roots of Horror in the Fiction of H. P. Lovecraft*, Barton Levi St. Armand revises Radcliffe's distinction to account for the ways in which each term "annihilates" the reader of weird fiction:

> Terror expands the soul outward; it leads us to or engulfs us in the sublime, the immense, the cosmic. We are, as it were, lost in the ocean of fear or plunged directly into it, drowning of our dread. What we lose is the sense of self. That feeling of 'awe' which traditionally accompanies intimations of the sublime, links terror with experiences that are basically religious in nature, like those annihilating confrontations with the numinous that Otto explores in *The Idea of the Holy*, . . . horror is equally annihilating, but from a dramatically different direction. Horror overtakes the soul from the inside; consciousness shrinks or withers form within, and the self is not flung into the exterior ocean of awe but sinks in its own bloodstream, choked by the alien salts of its inescapable prevertebrate heritage. (Qtd. in Messent 15)

St. Armand's description thus refers to several tropes inherent to the long tradition of the weird, including feelings of cosmic dread, the Outside, alienness, and shrinking consciousness. Both Radcliffe and St. Armand's distinctions between the two terms add to our understanding of a very particular kind of reading experience, one that happens in relation to or as an effect of the beyond, wherein fear and immensity converge within the realms of affect and ontology.

Keeping in mind St. Armand's description, George Bataille's weird mysticism, a mode of writing that simultaneously evokes and comments upon a non-experience in which fear and immensity converge, can be explored further; the immensity, after all, is a principle theme in his work. Bataille will take this experience to its extreme point, placing it beyond the scope of any previously conventional reading experience—namely because it calls one *to be* in "an elusive beyond" (*Inner Experience* 11), taking him to "a voyage to the end of the possible in man" (7). On this note, we may now segue into the first question.

By taking this voyage to the end of the possible, relations between terror and horror, fear and immensity, and the elusive beyond each be-

come inextricably tied to and problematized by Bataille's controversial views on God, mysticism, and the self. Readers who, like Bataille, suffer from a *divine impotence* are thus called into a space beyond life wherein death is not anterior or posterior but rather immanent to one's consciousness: "Far beyond the failings of friends or readers I am *close* to," Bataille writes, "I am now seeking friends and readers that a dead man might meet and, in advance, I see them as faithful, innumerable, silent: stars in the sky! My laughter, my madness reveals you and my death will join you" (*Guilty* 53). In this example, Bataille thus positions his work within a community of so-called readers, of sovereign entities *opposed* to the self, in which the sum total of the reading experience is found at the transgression point of life's limits—in death.[10] Thus any reader (or community of readers) of Bataille must allow themselves to open up to and be obliterated by a reading experience that constantly dismantles and un-situates itself, provoking a corollary self-dissolving sovereignty *through* reading. Readers must experience this weirdness for themselves, must enter into the paradoxical abyss of a ruptured language that exists already positioned in the beyond space of death, a space subjected to its own limitless sovereignty. Here, then, the Bataillean experience of terror must be distinguished as an unsuspended emptiness that becomes a horizon for the human being. But to what extent is this unsuspended emptiness itself ungrounded by God's absence and just how is it "mystical"?

The "space of death" called forth by Bataille is not limited to the human being. In fact, it accompanies the divine realm as well. Put simply (but not to oversimplify), we can posit that Bataillean terror is the terror of opening oneself up in the immensity, of going beyond but finding not God but *just oneself*: "In place of God . . . / there is / only / the impossible / and not God" (qtd. in Surya 304). Drawing from Nietzsche's death of God theology, Bataillean mystical self-annihilation precisely produces, following Leslie Anne Boldt, *a terror before the absence of God*. Take, for example, when Bataille writes that "lacking faith in myself I don't believe in God. Faith in God is faith in oneself. God is only a guarantee given to the ego. If we had not offered the ego to the absolute, we would laugh about it" (*Guilty* 39). The paradox Bataille here poses, in which the primacy of the divine is exposed in terms not of its presence but its absence, is characteristic of the traditional use of the *via negativa*, an oftentimes painful mystical path that finds words insufficient to describe God and is marked by willed acts of ego-dissolution in order to merge with the divine. "Any word beyond will fail, just as God himself fails," writes Michel Surya, "What Bataille meant to discover, within himself, was what had hitherto been hidden by God" (302). Deviating somewhat from its classical deployment, however, Bataille locates the *via negativa* in the realm of affective experience. Take, for example, "The King of the Wood," where Bataille writes that "the idea of God, the affections, the sweetness, associated with God is preludes to the absence of God. In the *night* of this ab-

sence, the insipidities and affectations have disappeared, reduced to the inconsistencies of a childhood memory. The horrible grandeur of God heralds the absence in which man is stripped bare" (*Guilty* 104). In this example, we discover that Bataille's unmaking of himself in the night of God's absence is un-bound by a "double movement"[11] at work in Bataille's writing that performs the very terror it conveys. Keeping in mind this example from "The King in the Wood," it becomes clear that his devotion to self-annihilation derives from his experience *in the night* of an absent God.

In chapter 2, we traced out a relationship between the weird and darkness mysticism, necessarily offering a link between the limits of thought and divine darkness. Throughout the Middle Ages, darkness was a necessary and crucial way for describing the ways in which God could be understood. For instance, the Christian mystic Angela of Foligno, one of Bataille's key influences, comments upon being in this darkness, an abyss she wishes *not* to fill with God, writing,

> It is impossible to say anything about the abyss; no word has a sound that can give an idea of it; no thought, no intelligence can venture into it. They stay in their realms, in their inferior realms. Not one word, not one idea is like the God of the abyss. . . . My words give me the feeling of nothingness. What am I saying? My words horrify me. Oh supreme obscurity! My words are curses, my words are blasphemies. Silence! Silence! Silence!" (Qtd. in Surya 309)

Keeping in mind these passionate words by Angela of Foligno, we can see that Bataille's "terror before the absence of God" is circumscribed and informed by what we can call an *apophatic horror*, one in which words horrifically fail to adequately describe, and thought inferiorly fails to venture into, the divine abyss—whereby God himself becomes the darkness. In his indispensable book *Georges Bataille: An Intellectual Biography* (2002), Michel Surya explains that "such are the presuppositions of an experience that knows the night it must travel through; it matters little if the saint insists on believing that God holds sway over this night and that Bataille claims that God is himself this night (or that this night is God), the terror, the dread are the same" (310). Recuperating the limit-experience of the human being by placing it within a mystical night in which the limits of thought are synonymous with terror and dread, Bataille envisions the paradoxical failure of rational thought to convey the radical divinity of the night itself.

Through establishing this relation between the night of the absence of God and two tenets of the weird, terror and horror, we can locate Bataille within a double framework that alternates between a mysticism of the beyond and an apophatic perversion. Taking as its impetus the communication of excessive experiences that are by their very nature incommunicable, in turn exasperating this apophatic horror,[12] Bataille's mystical

texts disclose to readers the macabre presence of what we could call the *weird-for-us*, a double beyond wherein the terror of the affective and the horror of the immensity congregate for us. If horror as such is for-us, it is essentially human, but only in the sense that it is encapsulates that negative moment when the human realizes they cannot comprehend the gaps between oneself and the limits of oneself—leaving one *in darkness*. This notion of being in intellectual darkness is echoed in a now famous quotation by H. P. Lovecraft. In "The Call of Cthulhu," Lovecraft's narrator states that "the most merciful thing in the world, I think, is the inability of the human mind to correlate all its contents. We live on a placid island of ignorance in the midst of black seas of infinity, and it was not meant that we should voyage far" (139). With its indefatigable emphasis on the inability of the mind to correlate its contents, this quotation, like Bataillean apophatic horror, offers an anti-correlationist reference point for speculating on questions concerning the limits of human thought.

Recalling once again the example from "The King of the Wood," we are reminded that it is "the horrible grandeur of God [that] heralds the *absence* in which man is stripped bare" (104), one in which human beings are paradoxically alienated by God's own summit. In other words, Bataillean incomprehension of the Lovecraftian sort is evoked from the play of doubling between the self and the divine. Hence this absence also indicates that *man is himself this absent God*. This negative mirror image, showcasing one's absolute divinity at the limits of oneself, shows not what one is but the horror *that* one is, evocative of an endless abyss that simultaneously exists *as oneself* and *just beyond* the horizon of one's own self-knowledge. This immanent gap is characteristic of a more divine or "sacred" exchange that the human being is capable of but is more often than not horrified by, wholly unable to grasp or experience. In *Theory of Religion* (1973), Bataille writes,

> The animal accepted this immanence that submerged it without apparent protest, whereas man feels a kind of impotent horror in the sense of the sacred. This horror is ambiguous. Undoubtedly, what is sacred attracts and possesses an incomparable value, but at the same time it appears vertiginously dangerous for that clear and profane world where mankind situates its privileged domain. (36)

While other beings such as animals have unconsciously accepted their mode of existence, the human being, who in her ignorance unknowingly dissents against the sacred, has yet to do so. On this point, Leslie Anne Boldt reminds us that

> in the acknowledgement of our suffering and of our limits, in our refusal to flee the anguish inspired by the inevitability of our death, we engage in sacrifice: we sacrifice our will to be everything, we sacrifice the hazy illusions which were middle terms distancing us from the experience of our limits and our eventual loss of self, and we sacrifice

> the belief in a God which, like the other narcotics, was to ensure that our presence be recuperated. Strange hypocrisy! We kill God in our neglect of the sacred, in our devotion to project, yet we sustain our belief in Him in our fear of oblivion. ("Translator's Introduction" xii)

Bataille's work thus seeks a communal re-incarnation of the sacred, taking us into that very oblivion, to replace this privative (or lost) sacredness by resituating the human being within the immanence of sacred, within very context of the death of God. As such, ontological and mystical concerns are paradoxically (un)bolstered by evocations of the impossible, placing the human being at her very limits with the intent of causing a total loss of self, for one cannot reach the non-place[13] of sovereignty without facing the terror before the absence of God.

We can conclude from this call for an absent God that, no matter how well readers succeed in generating meaning from the text, they are in fact incapable of knowing fully the mystical experience that produced the so-called content of the text.[14] Bataillean horror can thus be properly called ineffable, unveiling through the written text a failure on behalf of speech to adequately describe or reckon his mystical experience. It is a horror which tries to express the inexpressibility of a limit-experience in which affect and ontology excessively collide. However, and contradictorily so, this failure is also its true strength, for in losing himself at the limit of himself, Bataille sees *that which was never seen*.

As we have noted, Bataille's weird mysticism evokes perverse actualizations which demonstrate that a denuded view of the self, one freed of ego-laden clichés, needs to be constantly reinvented and practiced. Ordinary language fails when it comes to conveying the limit-experience of the human, so he opts for an ontologically inventive and semantic union with the beyond. Offering up intense melodramas of self only to ultimately reject and annihilate them, Bataille repeatedly invents new methods to discourse about the ineffable, formulating cosmic modes of thought that blur the distinction between self and world, helping us to think *through*, not dwell in, the divisions among affect, intellect, and ontology. In the next section, then, we will identify yet another way in which Bataille draws upon and yet reworks mystical discourse, namely through his highly nuanced and negatively indexed practice of writing poetry.

"YOU ARE THE HORROR OF THE NIGHT": MYSTICAL POETRY

Although many of Bataille's readers may be more familiar with his controversial novels like *The Story of the Eye* (1928) and *Blue of Noon* (1957) or his more theoretical writings like *The Accursed Share* (1949), his poetry serves as a remarkable textual repository[15] for many of his mystical ideas. Poetry is a part of Bataille's *désoeuvre*[16] that deserves our attention be-

cause it is evocative of the negative movement against all other discourse found in his writing and helps us to understand mystical and non-philosophical concepts found in his other works. Although critical interest in his work only flourished toward the end of his life and mainly after his death in 1962, the first collected English translation of Bataille's poetry did not surface until 1998. In *The Collected Poems of Georges Bataille*, readers meet a series of short pieces from Bataille's enormous body of work that, simply put, look like poems. And yet the word "poem," although it is the word that best fits to categorize these pieces, does need to be clarified.

In *Altarity* (1987), Marc C. Taylor identifies Bataille's mystical poetry within the context of *indirect* communication. Taylor writes that

> for Bataille, as for Kierkegaard and Hiedegger, the privileged form of indirect communication is *poiesis*. "The term *poésie*," Bataille avers, "applied to the least degraded and least intellectualized forms of expression of a state of loss, can be considered synonymous with an expenditure. . . . Its meaning is therefore close to that of *sacrifice*." . . . So understood, *poésie* designates a particular literary praxis rather than a specific literary genre. In the *poésie* of his poems and prose, Bataille puts his heterology into practice. (143)

As a literary praxis, poiesis is a form of communication that does not rely on a maker, but, more akin to imagination, involves a *conveyance*. Thus, the incongruence found within the exchange of Bataillean communication can be said to lead readers into a completely new relationship to poetry.

In short, Bataille's poems rupture from the literary into and out of the philosophical, and are at times excessively erotic, scatological, irreligious, and obscene: "Thumb in cunt / Eucharist upon your naked breasts," Bataille writes in his poem entitled "Solitude," "my ass soils the altar cloth" (*Collected Poems* 48). More than this, Bataille's poetry expresses a deeply mystical sensibility[17] buttressed by a deep commitment to kenotic (or self-forgetting) writing techniques as well as the motifs of darkness and nothingness used by medieval darkness mystics. For example, in "Le Vide," the third section of his poem entitled "L'Archangélique," Bataille links together several recurring themes in his poetry—immensity, death, the acephalic, night, the void—that are enigmatically woven into the poem and etch a personal gateway to mystical self-subversion. The original poem's mystical locus appears at the point where the sonic texture of the French form attempts to perform the impossible task of penetrating the very divine darkness it describes before crumbling under the weight of its own impossibility. "Le Vide" ("The Void") is indicative of this relationship between unknowing and the bounds of language (and, accordingly, between translation and the limits of retaining form), whereby even sonic finesse meets its own inevitable subversion. As such, the

speaker of the poem ventures, "then I will have made a void / in your abandoned head" (Spitzer 82),[18] a proclamation that announces the evacuation of not only (presumably) Bataille's, but also his readers', skulls.

In another place in Bataille, a lone poem in *L'expérience intérieure* found amid a series of fragmentary passages on the absence of God, we read, "Spectre en larmes / ô Dieu mort / oeil cave" (132).[19] The scant form of the poem in its original French reveals that there is no conventional structure. Rather, Bataille's poetry often works by setting up series of paratactic relations in which disparate images and fragments are placed side by side. These half-thoughts, ideas that cannot be penned down, present a problem to readers who hope to wander their way through such an abyssal semantic landscape, one very loosely held together through the paratactic syntax. Being the speaker of the poem thus becomes a complicated position for Bataille to occupy and remain critical—or even aware of—because the juxtaposed fragments concoct a poetic language of unsaying that is essentially pointing to its own taking place. These sorts of deictic conjunctions add to the poem's stark weirdness. In this poem, Bataille presents readers with a conundrum as he pursues a dead God and eventually comes undone. Readers get a liminal view of the self as its isolated being unwinds into the boundless sphere of the impossible.

These examples taken from Bataille's poetry are intended to show that his thought is often transcribed and dissolved through spasmodic fits of syntax and epigrams devoid of positive logic. Aside from the critical-creative aspect of this notion, his interest in poetry can also be traced to his personal life. Historically speaking, Bataille's writing life was catalyzed when, during the German occupation of France in 1940, Bataille formed a deep intellectual friendship with Maurice Blanchot. Blanchot's shattering political writings situated him closely within the Bataillean framework of a radical sovereignty free of restrictions. Blanchot was a self-professed non-believer in God, Leslie Hill reminds us, drawn to the writings of mystics because they anticipated the rigors of inner experience (22). When they met, Blanchot had just finished work on his 1941 récit *Thomas the Obscure*, a work that, according to him, gives readers not merely a narration of main character Thomas's experience but the experience itself by way of an écriture that continually draws attention to its materiality.[20] Blanchot's mystical writings, like those of Bataille, tend to obliterate the scission between self and world rather than reinforce it. Obliterating this scission is emblematic of the "limit-experience," when one breaks with oneself to achieve a desire without object, which, in essence, is the true desire of writing.

In terms of a shift in focus, then, from 1941 onward, Bataille's work began to include poetry, a genre he had hitherto dismissed as trivial and much too literary. The basis for his early dismissal of the form stems in part from his break with the Surrealists, many of whom upheld literature

as a quintessential medium for the movement. In 1943 *Inner Experience* was published with the band wrapping the book reading "Beyond Poetry." "By situating his book beyond poetry Bataille was," as Stuart Kendall keenly notes, "indicating that poetry could only be a tool—and one tool among others—in a process in which experience itself was the sole value" (168). Bataille's thought rarely crystallizes through one medium alone. As we have learned previously, he relies on, interlaces, and then obliterates several modes of discourse in order to carry him into the zones of excess he desires. Although Bataille despises genre in general, he blatantly manipulates and reforms it in order to provoke new modes of communication. Above all, he seeks an anarchic sovereignty of/through thought. What, then, does Bataille's mystical poetry do that other genres cannot?

In *Poetry as Survival* (2002), Gregory Orr eloquently argues that poetry is an agent of personal transformation. Orr's study focuses on the personal lyric, primarily transformative personal lyrics that have been written from the vantage point of the individual as opposed to the "sacred" or "social" lyrics which dominated Western poetry until the Romantic period (3). A personal lyric such as D. H. Lawrence's "Song of a Man Who Has Come Through," Orr contends, "dramatize[s] the fear one might feel when faced with the unknown," but also provides "firm advice" about how one "must respond" to it (5). Understanding the issue in this way, Orr endeavors to show that a poetry founded in the private sphere of existence can be a transformative agent in the psychological, spiritual, and/or personal life of an individual. Poetry, as Orr sees it, is not a symptom of, but rather a catalyst to quell, madness. The impact of poetry is clear in this light. The poet struggles to maintain stability in her inner world while the disassociated self begins to reorder itself, fighting through madness to find some semblance of order. "The very fact of the poem's *existence* on the page," writes Orr, "is proof of its efficacy of survival, proof that the poet succeeded in ordering his or her disorder (if only briefly); proof a person could take on the thematic disorder of that particular poem (even the theme of madness) and order it" (83). Put simply, had the poet failed in their attempt to restabilize the self the poem would not exist. Thus, a corollary relation that can be drawn between survival and madness is existence and non-existence. It follows from Orr's argument, then, that poetry is an antidote. Only a mode of writing that puts the writer on the side of existence can lead to transformation and self-awareness, to severance from madness.

Nevertheless, for Georges Bataille, poetry stems from a particularly dizzying movement from what is known into what is unknown. Bataille himself states that "we are only totally laid bare by proceeding without trickery to the unknown. It is the measure of the unknown which lends to the experience of God—or of the poetic—their great authority. But the unknown demands in the end sovereignty without partition" (*Inner Expe-*

rience 5). As in his experimental literary works, several philosophical motifs emerge in his poetic verse. "*The immensity, the impossible, the void, desire, nothingness*"—these are the abstractions through which the poems repeatedly manifest themselves (Spitzer xi). In "The Malady/Greatness of Arthur Rimbaud," Bataille writes that "poetry is the negation of itself: it denies itself as it preserves itself and surpasses itself" (1). Because it contributes to and is derived from an excessive desire, the poet becomes maddened by an inability to contain herself, one marked by a fall into darkness and writing. Here madness and the poetic converge, expressed as the auto-annihilating knowledge of one's self through desire: "what touches on knowledge of one's self is simply desire, evocation; it's the void, the chaos, leftover from poetry" (1). But that is just the point.

Writing is a form that continually alerts us to and negates its form. Because poetry negates itself it fails to synthesize the abyss between madness and non-madness—or, to be clearer, between order and chaos—because it maddeningly collapses the correlative boundary between them. "Madness is masked by the appearance of a will for experience, and this will is disguised by a derangement," writes Bataille, "the inability to survive comes from an excess of desire, which goes in many directions at the same time. The collapse felt during exhaustion keeps the mind from surpassing desire, and exacerbates it" (2).[21] This inability to survive induces a death beyond the natural, utterly dissolving the self at the very limits of the human.

Bataille goes on to say that, like the pioneer Rimbaud,

> the poet is no longer destroyed language reshaping a false world through deconstructed symbols, but is the man, who, weary of the game, wants to make a real conquest from this realm of madness. What collapsed through anticipation, which the *seer* cannot see, is the difference between enduring collapse (madness, or its equivalent, pure negation) and searching for the possible beyond that collapse. These two moments merge into one, as with poetry. (2)

In Bataille's view, then, if any synthesis can be drawn between poetry and madness, it is not the synthesis of survival, but rather the reality of an excessive failure of desire that leads the poet through to a realm beyond its own collapse, an unadulterated madness, that is, poetic bliss.

Apart from the thematic similarities between Orr and Bataille's commentaries on modern poetry, that madness and selfhood are often strange bedfellows, they have an almost opposite viewpoint on its function. For Bataille, the relation between madness and desire is an inescapable one. Contrary to Orr, Bataille sees no possibility for the efficacy of survival or for the positive acquisition of self-knowledge. Bataille states that "Rimbaud's greatness is having led poetry to its own failure. Poetry is not a knowledge of one's self" (2).[22] But if poetry is not knowledge of one's self, then just what is it?

The answer to this question is perhaps echoed via Bataille's interest in medieval mystics such as Pseudo-Dionysius the Areopagite, Meister Eckhart, and Saint John of the Cross. For example, in *Inner Experience* Bataille writes,

> I read in Denys l'Aréopagite: "Those who by an inward cessation of all intellectual functioning enter into an intimate union with ineffable light . . . only speak of God by negation" (*Noms divins*, 1, 5). So it is from the moment that it is experience and not presupposition which reveals (to such an extent that, in the eyes of the latter, light is a "ray of darkness"; he would go so far as to say, in the tradition of Eckhart: "God is Nothingness [néant]"). (4)

We will return to a more detailed discussion of Pseudo-Dionysius and John of the Cross, but for now let it suffice to say that each of these mystics utilized a mode of discourse known as *apophasis*, a Greek word meaning "to speak away." Deploying apophatic logic, what Michael T. Sells has called "the language of unsaying," these mystics *unknow* themselves. Apophatic language is said to be "the semantic analogue to the experience of mystical union" (Sells 9), an anarchic moment which performs union with divine nothingness.

One convincing example of mystical self-subversion performed by Bataille is found in a poem called "God" in which he questions his own identity, denying that he is a person at all. In this poem, Bataille deploys apophatic logic via several semantic acts of self-subversion: the narrator is not an *I*, a subject, but negates the very idea of being himself or anyone else. Rather, he is "*the desert the night the immensity*" (Spitzer 107). He endeavors to semantically articulate the vertiginous non-experience of a union with none other than the immensity itself, a liminal sphere wherein any knowledge of himself as a self is obliterated. Engulfed in eternal emptiness, he plunges into death: "*so I won't know anything / more than these tears*" (107).[23] This poem is unquestionably anti-mimetic, a representational void. As such, what is at stake is the poetic corollary to a *practiced* nothingness wherein fragmented language attempts to perform the nothingness it describes. The notion of a practiced nothingness is perhaps best expressed by the medieval French mystic Marguerite Porete when she writes in *The Mirror of Simple Souls* that "the best I can tell you is that if you understand perfectly your nothingness you will do nothing, and this nothingness will give you everything" (115). Paradoxically, it is because Bataille is a writer that his attempt to "do nothing" becomes a *praxis* of doing (or writing) nothing.

While reading Bataille's mystical poetry, there is a tendency for the reader to lose track of line and stanza. One reason for this type of disassociation is that the speaker of the poem is willfully trying to lose himself. Whereas most modern poetry is usually concerned with evoking or contemplating a subjective "I," Bataille's poems work to obliterate subjectiv-

ity. Another way to think about this practice is to think of it as a literary performance of mystical unknowing. "I oppose to poetry the experience of the possible," writes Bataille. "It is less a matter of contemplation than of rupture. It is however of 'mystical experience' that I speak" (*Inner Experience* 40). Understood in this way, Bataille's poems rupture or disembody themselves through the language of unknowing. "At the limit of knowledge, un-knowing is activated, a process in which subjectivity is torn apart," write Botting and Wilson, "unworked at the core of physical and mental being" (2). Bataille speaks of experiences that exist at the limit of the possible. By blurring the distinction between subject (self) and object (world), and also collapsing the ontological boundaries between the body and the intellect, he indicates an essential component of mysticism itself—that mysticism negates itself as mysticism.

Recalling the example of "God," we can return again to Bataille's reading of Arthur Rimbaud. Bataille's poetry, in contrast to the transformative personal lyrics studied by Gregory Orr, problematizes the notion of poetry as a mode of writing. For the Bataille of the early 1940s, the *sine qua non* of poetry was evidenced in Arthur Rimbaud, a poet who, as Mark Spitzer notes, "had achieved the *possible* (which, of course, is the conquering of *the impossible*)" (*Collected Poems* xiii). The twentieth century had witnessed Rimbaud's influence on modern literature, poetry, and avant-garde movements such as Surrealism. A key aspect of Bataille's interest in Rimbaud's poetry is perhaps found in a well-known letter he wrote to Georges Izambard, Rimbaud's teacher, in May 1871 at the young age of sixteen. In this letter, Rimbaud describes his poetic philosophy, writing that "I'm now making myself as scummy as I can. Why? I want to be a poet, and I'm working at turning myself into a seer. . . . The idea is to reach the unknown by the derangement of all the senses. It involves enormous suffering, but one must be strong and be a born poet. It's really not my fault" (Robb 79–80). Readers familiar with Bataille's *désoeuvre* will note the inherent similarities between them.

Like Rimbaud, Bataille often opts for the filthy and scatological in effort to describe what happens to the human being at the limits of the possible and emphasizes excessive inner vision. In the poem entitled "Night is my Nudity," for example, Bataille articulates his desires for sexual ecstasy by aligning them with polymorphously perverse images, losing himself in the nudity of the night. Deploying a series of uni-directional speech acts, he intends to describe the experience of being engrossed in a divine stupor where he wishes "To vomit living / Oh my failure / Ecstasy which sleepens me" (Spitzer 119).[24] What are readers to make of the scattered, dissociative rhythm of this poem as it interrupts any kind of flow? The line breaks happen in offbeat places, evoking in the speaker a sort of stutter. Consequently, the reader must stumble intellectually while reading to make any sense of the speaker's desire to blur the

distinction between subject and object for a universe filled with dead concepts.

The structural gaps and sonic dissonances employed by Bataille hold a negative pedagogical power, instructing readers to think about non-thinking; he opts for a self-dissolving structure that points to its own incomprehension, all the while dis-engaging the reader. The poem also upholds the death-like plane of immanence that a Bataillean reading experience often evokes. In the night, his nudity, Bataille hurls himself among the dead. His impassioned poetry echoes similar musings in *The Impossible*, where he writes that that "poetry's luster reveals itself outside the moments which it reaches in a deathlike disorder" (161). "But Bataille is tricky," Spitzer writes, for

> in the "Preface" to the second edition of *L'Impossible*, he writes this about achieving *the impossible*: "Indeed I think that in my sense my narratives clearly attain the *impossible*." But then, later on, he seemingly contradicts himself, refusing to let the reader believe he made it as far as he had previously implied, in any sense: "I approach poetry: but only to miss it."
> Thus spoke Bataille. But why? (xiii)

Spitzer thus poses an essential question—why would Bataille knowingly deploy a mode of writing with the intention to get beyond it? This would initially seem to be a counterintuitive move. And yet, when situated within the context of medieval mysticism, perhaps it is not.

Recently there is evidence to suggest that at the heart of this question exists the paradox of Bataille's poetic thought which, beginning from the space of the mystical, seeks the plane of non-existence. Eugene Thacker observes a close relation between Bataille's mystical thought and that of John of the Cross, the sixteenth-century Spanish mystic whom we analyzed in chapter 2. In "The Subharmonic Murmur of Black Tentacular Voids," the prologue to *In the Dust of This Planet*, Thacker explains that a version of John's divine darkness, one that explicitly evokes the "notion of the divine as dark because it represents a limit to thought and experience" (138), can be found in the mystical poetry of Bataille. In a poem such as Bataille's "The Archangelic" what becomes manifest, according to Thacker, is "that which is an absolute limit (for experience, for thought, for the human), which, in its manifesting, is also a vacuousness, a dissipation, a receding into shadows and night" (138). Thus, in another moment in Bataille, we read that "night is itself the youth and drunkenness of thought" (*Guilty* 96). The notion of divine darkness in Bataille's poem "The Archangelic," then, is metaphorical of the darkness of being on *this side* of the unthinkable, the unsayable.

As we noted in the first section of this chapter, "Bataille claims that God is himself this night (or that this night is God), a space in which the terror, the dread are the same" (Surya 310). Yet, before we move on, let us

clarify Bataille's night by discerning the status of the super-essential in his thought, for not only does it represent an unknowable limit to thought and experience but also, in Pseudo-Dionysian fashion, opens to the mystical thrust of inner experience, that of ecstasy. Andrew Hussey writes that "for Dionysius [the intuition of ecstasy] is opening of the negative way which leads to an encounter with the 'super-essential Darkness' which is the face of God. For Bataille, in a parallel manner, the negative way is an ascesis which annihilates discourse and asserts the absence of God as the 'mystical point of experience'" (43). Dionysius's negative way provides Bataille with a method to emphasize the status of super-essential: the night, being an absolute limit (i.e., that which does not answer thought's call) makes negatively certain through its uncertainty that its very unintelligibility be taken in earnest as the impossible reality of beyond-being. The voidic conditions that posit Reality's absolute absence to the one who tries to think it also impossibly reveals, vis-à-vis its uncertainty and unstableness, the super-essential negativity of Reality as sovereignty.

Perhaps, then, the underlying difference between Bataille and Gregory Orr's theories on the function of poetry lies not in the realm of a definitional difference but rather, following Marc C. Taylor, in a difference of literary praxis. "Poetry for Bataille is a continual mode of praxis, a continual play and movement between a suspension of meaning and its oblivion in the void . . . it is an affirmative seeking out of sovereignty. It is a continual 'self subversion' where we seek our own sovereignty" (O'Shea 58). The difference between the two kinds of poetry establishes itself in the midst of a tension that exists between a mystical (evidenced in terms of Bataille's vested interest in voidic oblivion and self-subversion) and a humanist (evidenced in Orr's study of transformative lyric poets) poetry. To clarify this identification, let us take the example of Bataille's critique of poetry found in "The Oresteia," the third and final section of his posthumously published book *The Impossible*. "The Oresteia" is not a linear narrative in any sense. And as the book's third and final part, it can hardly be said to act as a conclusion of any kind. Rather, it is a series of short poems interspersed with a set of fragmentary notes on poetry that could loosely be called commentaries. In "The Oresteia" Bataille writes, "Poetry was simply a detour: through it I escaped the world of discourse, which had become the natural world for me; with poetry I entered a kind of grave where the infinity of the possible was born from the death of the logical world" (*The Impossible* 163).

Revealing an unseen desire of poetry in the form of an occult power—one that conceals the limit-experience *in* the impossible—Bataille's poetry reveals to readers what happens in the liminal space between the known and the unknown, enabling them to attain a level of sovereignty that other reading experiences deny them. "Poetry reveals a power of the unknown," Bataille writes in "To Be Orestes,"[25] "but the unknown is

only an insignificant void if it is not the object of a desire. Poetry is a middle term, it conceals the known within the unknown: it is the unknown painted in blinding colors, in the image of a sun" (*The Impossible* 164). Comprehending the limit-experience that is found in Bataille's mystical poetry is to develop the notion of a poetics of exscription that seeks to magnify the mystical schism between self and world rather than to repair it. A poetics of exscription, it might follow, would be one that theorizes Bataille's poetry through Bataille's poetry, a poetics that, like his praxis of poiesis, points to its own taking place.

In the context of our overarching discussion of weird mysticism, this would be a poetics that both utilizes and posits, via content and evocation, the horror of an experience that "knows the night it must travel through" (Surya 310). In poem ten of the "Archangelical" Bataille writes, "You are the horror of the night / my love for you is like a cry of death" (Spitzer 17). Bataille continues, writing that "my love for you is like delirium" (17), likening the death of thought to a delirious form of love that transpires in the night. If, in this weird, quasi-confessional poem, Bataille yearns for and addresses in the second person someone or some immense no-thing that *is* the night, in doing so, we can argue that Bataille is in fact indicating the horror of experiencing ecstasy in a third space that, overlapping like the center of a Venn diagram, is both human and inhuman (evocative of a divine darkness). As such, this poem holds a crucial relation to Angela of Foligno's experience of divine horror: "Deepening depth, hollowing out nothingness in its abyss, I long, I long, I hunger and thirst. I hunger and thirst for you to sink into the abyss, that you engulf yourselves in the depths of your nothingness and in the heights of divine immensity" (qtd. in Surya 309–10). Here the poetics of exscription seeks to identify through the poem's own non-discourse what happens at the limits of the human in this night and what exists in the fringe space between the poem's simultaneous formulation as both a form and a mode—its mystical content and this content's evocation—one that blurs the correlation between self and world, and between world and world. This fringe space expands infinitely, is the inexhaustible space of inhuman horror, one taking place in the night of the absence of God, an immense and cosmic negativity in which Bataille himself dissolves from without.

THE DARK HALO OF SORROW

Georges Bataille writes that happiness can only be truly known, albeit transfigured, in what he calls "the dark halo of sorrow": "The doubt born of great sorrows cannot help but illuminate whose who enjoy—who can fully know happiness only transfigured, in the dark halo of sorrow" (*The Impossible* 116). Similarly, Giorgio Agamben, renowned thinker of com-

munity, negativity, and politics, offers a theory of the halo which ascribes it as a liminal zone in which "possibility and reality, potentiality and actuality, become indistinguishable" ("Halos" 56,6). The notion of the dark halo is thus aligned with the notion of a very particular kind of sorrow, a solitary nigredo entrusted to mystical individuation. In this concluding section, we will look at Bataille's notion of the dark halo to consider the importance of mystical sorrow on the creation of his weird mysticism and just how this reflection seeks to illustrate and complicate our analyses in the preceding sections. As such, the concept of mystical sorrow will show us striving and yet struggling to theorize the dark halo of sorrow, as it obfuscates and expands the margins of weird mysticism itself. Locating instances of mystical sorrow deployed in his texts, we will attempt to demonstrate how Bataille conceives the individuating dynamics of mystical sorrow and especially how this conception relates to other texts on the subject, including those written by the medieval author of *The Cloud of Unknowing* and nineteenth-century spiritual philosopher Søren Kierkegaard. The mystical text, as such, can be thought by highlighting how literary histories of authorial experimentation act profoundly to transfigure individual consciousness.

In *Literature and Evil* (1957), Bataille notes the essential relation between modern literature and mysticism in his chapter on Emily Brontë. "Literature," writes Bataille, "is not so much cognate with the content of religion as it is with the content of mysticism. Similarly, mysticism is closer to the truth than I can possibly say" (26). Bataille's description of mysticism focuses on solitary mystical states associated with medieval darkness mysticism[26] in which the primacy of the incommunicability of the mystical experience is central. For Bataille, the circumstances under which such solitary mystical states arise are similar to the annihilating experience of reading certain types of literature, especially those in which the reader loses herself in alternating moments of ecstasy and death. In such cases, "the isolated being *loses himself* in something other than himself. What the 'other thing' represents is of no importance. It is still a reality that transcends the common limitations. So unlimited is it that it is not even a thing: it is *nothing*" (26). As the focus of kenotic (self-emptying) experience and as the self-emptied corollary to divine union, solitude holds significance both as a requisite mystical practice and as a state of being. Bataille links the notions of self-annihilation and transcendence to this particular kind of reading experience in order to situate their common trajectories in the unlimited non-place of nothingness. Much like that of the Christian darkness mystic Meister Eckhart, who famously prayed to God to rid himself of (the concept of) God,[27] Bataille recontextualizes the familiar motif within the experience of reading literature. In so doing, Bataille offers a new genealogy that situates modern literature according to its mystical relevance in a weird non-experience of reading that makes it distinct from other literatures.

By suspending desire in isolation and thereby losing oneself in nothingness (which, understood another way, really means to gain *everything*), Bataille's formulation of literature becomes conjoined to the existential basis of a much larger mystical predicament in which he often finds himself. To clarify this point, let us take the example of "Alleluia: The Catechism of Dianus." In this section of *Guilty*, Bataille equates his overpowering experience of sorrow to a majestic horror: "Overwhelmed by frigid melancholy, by life's majestic horrors! Utterly exasperated. Today I find myself on the edge of the abyss. At the limit of the worst situation, of an unbearable happiness. At the summit of a vertiginous height, I sing alleluia: the purest, most painful you will ever hear" (137). In this passage, Bataille links several complex concepts—horror, sorrow, the abyss, the limit-experience—in order to conjure for the reader a transcription of what happens at the liminal zone where happiness and purity, sorrow and pain, indistinguishably constitute the edge of the abyss itself. Here sorrow is frigid, an inversion of movement, a freezing of the blurred division between being and affect that elicits a majestic horror which is also the summit of an unbearable happiness. The negativity he describes marks a point of intersection, or liminal zone, wherein existential sorrow and being in-the-abyss happen in tandem. Just a few lines later, Bataille goes on to write that "the solitude of misfortune is a halo, a veil of tears for you to cover your nakedness" (*Guilty* 137). Expanding the concept of the halo to encompass not only existential facticity, but also describing it as a veil made from sorrow's tears used to cover the nakedness of this facticity, indicates that he sees the halo as a zone or third thing that connects the affectivity of sorrow with ontological nakedness.

A similar connection between melancholy and nakedness has been made by Susan Sontag in "Fragments of an Aesthetic of Melancholy," the introductory essay to *"Veruschka": Trans-figurations*. In the following passage, Sontag elliptically notes the essential relations among melancholy, nakedness, and desire: "The desire to be stripped down, to be naked, to be concealed, to disappear, to be only one's skin, to mortify the skin, to petrify the body, to become fixed, to become dematerialized, a ghost, to become matter only, inorganic matter, to stop, to die" (6). Sontag provokes a merging of desire and self-abnegation within the context of nakedness, which bids a definition of sorrow as a kind of dissolution between the material and inorganic.[28] Recalling the example of "Alleluia: The Catechism of Dianus," Bataille makes a heretical claim that, when stretched to its utmost limit, melancholic solitude becomes sacred,[29] evoking the singing of "alleluia: the purest, most painful you will ever hear" (137). Diverging from Sontag's vantage, then, Bataillean melancholy appears to be the result of a much more mystical predicament.

To illuminate the necessity of the relation between sorrow and mysticism, we can look to Nicola Masicandaro's exceptional work on mystical

sorrow to show that what Bataille ultimately sorrows over is the very fact of his existence. In fact, Bataille's overwhelming melancholy is uncannily similar to the definition of sorrow found in the late medieval mystical text *The Cloud of Unknowing*. Masciandaro writes that "the *Cloud* defines ultimate sorrow as sorrow over the fact of oneself: 'Alle men han mater of sorrow, but most specyaly he felith mater of sorrow that wote and felith that he is. Alle other sorowes be unto this in comparison bot as it were gamen to ernest'" ("Eros as Cosmic Sorrow" 60). According to the author of the *Cloud*'s definition, the condition of ultimate sorrow is thus corollarily located within the blurred division between affect and ontology, within the anguished experience of being oneself. All other forms of sorrow stem from and are minor in comparison to the very fact *that one is*.

Similar claims on the necessity of defining sorrow as the sorrow over the fact of oneself are made by Bataille in his text entitled "Problems of Surrealism." In this essay, which characterizes the experience of being oneself as both "insignificant to the point of horror" and "eternal," in contrast to a positive identification which would uphold being oneself as a beneficent and temporal quality, Bataille conceives ultimate sorrow as the horror that, both insignificant and infinite, is himself, writing,

> this is so tortuous that I am sure people will consider my evidence stupid. To consider oneself an ordinary person . . . in a word, to be aware of the *gutter*, not without the light-heartedness and thoughtlessness of the newcomer, being insignificant to the point of horror, without the benefit of horror, finally knowing oneself as eternal—in the eternity of each instant—without hope, pondering pain and the night of all the dead, becoming the monster of whom monstrosity is familiar, for sweetness and purity fuse with spite—spite with sweetness—this is the fate of the silent being, who adds only his tomb to infinite life, on the immense oblivion of what he already is. *(The Absence of Myth* 98–99)

This conception of himself as simultaneously and anagogically "insignificant to the point of horror, without the benefit of horror, finally knowing oneself as eternal" incites a challenge to the concept of positive identification with selfhood that is also its factical impasse: knowing oneself as "the immense oblivion of what he is" is to enter into an unthinkable darkness that paradoxically illuminates and intensifies the blurred division between affect and ontology, wherein his own being serves as the crypt of infinity.

According to Masciandaro, the complex task of defining sorrow is complicated within the duality of its very structure and experience. "Sorrow is double," writes Masciandaro, so a definition of sorrow must also account in such a way for the "possibility of its opposite" (10). Perhaps the most notable feature of a sorrow like this is the way in which it necessitates an uncompromising series of negativities. In *The Sickness Unto Death* (1849), the Danish philosopher and theologian Søren Kierke-

gaard articulates this necessity, recognizing existential sorrow as a kind of ontological inversion: "Despair itself is a negativity; ignorance of it, a new negativity. However, to reach the truth, one must go through every negativity, for the old legend about breaking a certain magic spell is true: the piece has to be played through backwards or the spell is not broken" (44). Conceived as an experience afforded to an initiate of individuation, then, spiritual despair is marked by an almost exponential negativity that groups it within an unfolding narrative of esoteric truths. This unfolding of sorrows, as it were, happens in reverse, as a kind of playing backwards of being that takes one through every negativity to get to the ultimate Truth.

Utilizing the logic of negativity, Bataille endeavors to communicate this experience of existential sorrow. Because he is overwhelmed by the despair of his own taking place this attempt to communicate his ineffable experience substantiates Bataille's anguish,[30] placing it within series of self-constituting negativities. Despair, therefore, ironically contains the cosmic immensity of nothingness within his very being, locating the affective contingency of sorrow in existential exasperation. Thus, one way for Bataille to try and communicate a vertiginous experience in which affect and ontology converge is through the mode of the fragmented self-subverting narrative, an event of language that at once expels and originates nothingness and being within the narrating subject.

One key example of this self-subverting negativity can be found in the aforementioned experimental work entitled *The Impossible*, wherein Bataille's narrator writes, "Oh, *senseless* sorrow, without regret, without reflection! Here I am, burning with the desire to burn from such agonizing, splintered flames. Between death and physical pain—and pleasure, deeper than death and pain—I drag myself along in a melancholy night, at the edge of sleep" (34). According to Masciandaro, "Sorrow's ambivalent power is all about blurring the boundaries between being and affect . . . its belonging to a mysterious dimension of extreme desire where how one feels and what one is intersect in the will's utmost self-constituting and self-dissolving negativity" (10). This speculative medievalist definition of sorrow gives a more comprehensive understanding of existential sorrow in the context of Bataille's penetrating and auto-exasperating vision into the essential problem of his own being. Darkness, sorrow, impossibility, the mystical unknowing of self—these are Bataille's subjects, ones that, at the level of obscurity, engender a (non-)form of epigrammatic thought. Typically, modern people tend to find "sorrow's cause by defining its lost reality," attempting to integrate it into the nebulous field of existence, "but the reverse, in fact, has taken place," suggests Harvie Ferguson, because for modern people "melancholy alone has 'depth,' and it is its 'presence' which lends expression . . . to the disease of existence" (qtd. in Masciandaro, "The Sorrow of Being" 28). In contrast to this point,

mystical sorrow is the type of sorrow that breaks a lot of so-called modern rules of affectivity.

One way to account for the ambivalent power of sorrow in Bataille is to show how sorrow and horror function together in a liminal space that muddles the dichotomy between human affect and ontology into a dizzying experience largely characterized by such auto-bewildering ambiguity. One interesting example comes in the form of the "dark halo of sorrow," a point of convergence between horror and sorrow. In *The Impossible*, Bataille writes,

> The doubt born of great sorrows cannot help but illuminate those who enjoy—who can fully know happiness only transfigured, in the dark halo of sorrow. So that reason cannot resolve the ambiguity: extreme happiness is possible only at the moment I doubt it will last; it changes on the contrary into heaviness, from the moment I'm certain of it. Thus we can live sensibly only in a state of ambiguity. There is never a clear-cut difference, for that matter, between sorrow and joy: the awareness of sorrow on the prowl is always present, and even in horror the awareness of possible joy is not entirely suppressed: it is this awareness that adds dizzily to the pain, but by the same token it is what enables one to endure torments. (116)

For Bataille, sorrow becomes a liminal space in which several complex categories of individual consciousness are obliterated. Literalizing the content of his phrases, the monsignor's non-discourse becomes suffused with the same ambiguity as his temporal state of being. In other words, editorializing and qualifying phrases at once point to the horror of ambiguity and ambiguize the horror he has over his sorrow. This is the weird disparity between the existential intensity of self-knowledge—realizing *that one is* and being saddened by it—versus the ambiguity of affective language, that the very obscurity of negative affect necessitates and engenders an indeterminate and abstruse use of language. There is also an extraordinary profundity to the monsignor's lamentations, marking the level of insight he actually has into his impoverished existence even in a state characterized by confusion and torment. Noting with a qualifying phrase that "the awareness of sorrow on the prowl is always present," he ambiguously shifts between ideas and concepts, knitting them together through percolating layers of discourse that, to follow Masicandaro, blur the boundaries between being and affect. Moreover, we find an ambivalent locality (his affect) and universality (the awareness of his horror) to the monsignor's description of sorrow, as he relates it to a "dark halo." Exactly what role, then, does the halo play in this context?

Traced throughout the corpus of occult literature, the halo shapes and constitutes several key aspects of esoteric initiation. In his highly regarded work entitled *Initiation into Hermetics* (1956), Franz Bardon, deemed as one of the greatest adepts of the twentieth century, locates the

halo in/as the emanation of a person's soul or aura. "Pictures of high initiates and saints," writes Bardon, "are always depicted with a halo, which is identical to the aura" (46). Bardon thus identifies the halo within the context of individuation, a series of mystical initiations undergone only by initiates, mystics, and saints. According to Giorgio Agamben, halos are also indicative of the Absolute's slight displacement from the world as we know it. Said another way, recalling the thirteenth-century theologian Duns Scotus, Agamben posits that the halo is "the individuation of a beatitude, the becoming singular of that which is perfect," and, taking the notion even farther, for "[Saint] Thomas the singularity here is not a final determination of being, but an unraveling or an indetermination of its limits: a paradoxical *individuation by indetermination*" (*The Coming Community* 54). Framed in this manner, Bataille insightfully situates sorrow at the most extreme and singular point of its very taking place—at the limit threshold of happiness.

For Bataille, sorrow is singularly indeterminate, is in the zone of the *really real*, deviating from happiness only in terms of a small displacement at the limit of its experience. As such, sorrow is *absolute*, and, irreducible in its splendor, is sung with an alleluia.[31] Such delight is exactingly professed by Saint Theresa of Avila when she writes that "during this agony, the soul is inundated with inexpressible delights." Thus solitude's misfortune, described by Bataille as "a halo, a veil of tears for you to cover your nakedness," is only that, as a mystical aegis, it is not for all but rather few, reserved only for those whose melancholy is overwhelming and individuating. Thus, only the weird mystic is capable to cry these paradisic tears and to don the metonymic halo of individuation. The halo that covers nakedness locates itself within the liminal space of naked-being. And the being who, cloaked in tears, suffers the overwhelming melancholy of herself also feels the "imperceptible trembling of the finite," as Agamben might have it, "that makes its limits indeterminate and allows it to blend, to make itself whatever, is the tiny displacement that every thing must accomplish in the messianic world" (55). In this way, the halo becomes an anagogic instrument, one that can be seen only by the few others who dwell in that indeterminate zone within which the divine and the finite are blended.

In another example, Bataille likens the confusing predicament of himself to being in a sad crevasse. In *Guilty*, Bataille writes, "In the bottom of an abyss oppressed with haze—myself in this pit confusing myself with the horror of things, humble and sad crevasse cracking the planet, my presence here is like a cry, without hope, the cry of a blind beast calling a beloved . . . shattered by desire for the ungraspable." In this passage, Bataille states that the pit of the abyss serves as the oppressive haze in which the boundary between him and the horror of things is obscured. Here his own being presupposes its desire to be grasped, culminating in a double erasure of self and planet—vis-à-vis the sorrow of his own

being. Indeed, the autobiographical or authorial impetus to this passage at first glance resembles that of the anonymous Author of *The Cloud of Unknowing*, who writes, "For whi He may wel be loved, but not thought. By love may He be getyn and holden; bot by thought neither . . . and fonde for to peers that derkness aboven thee. And smyte apon that thicke cloude of unknowing with a scharp darte of longing love, and go not thens for thing that befalleth" (36), as it fits within a central paradox. Just as the author of the *Cloud* cannot access God through thought, Bataille is unable to think the object of desire: a world-without-world. Bataille's abyssic haze is similar to such a cloud of unknowing. But Bataille's non-experience of an "abyssic haze" is strikingly different from the cloud that lovingly blurs the correlation between divine union and human understanding for the author of the *Cloud*. It is necessarily the case that each writer becomes enshrouded in the divine darkness of the inhuman and ungraspable gap between the unknown and the knowable. But whereas the *Cloud* author beats "apon that thicke cloude of unknowing with a scharp darte of longing love," Bataille, in sadness, is shattered by "desire for the ungraspable." The difference between the two forms of unknowing shows that it is nevertheless possible to move from a loving, moving sense of unthinkability—a state indicative to achieving divine union—to a horrific and shattering one.

Similarly, twentieth-century Romanian philosopher E. M. Cioran understands the notion of the unthinkable according to the limits of darkness and via the idea of a "thirst for a black halo": "And we . . . instruments of a strange execution, fascinated by the illusion of reaching the limits of the darkness, the frontiers of our nocturnal fate. Fear of the void transformed into a kind of voluptuous joy. . . . Infinity in reverse, god that begins beneath our heals, ecstasy before the crevices of being, and thirst for a black halo, the Void is an inverted dream in which we are engulfed" (*Decay* 52). In is not our intention here to conflate the notions of darkness and blackness, as each holds a phenomenal relation to one another and yet are different. However, the intuitive relation between darkness and blackness is of note, for in Cioran the "thirst for a black halo" is contingent on "the illusion of reaching the limits of darkness." Thus, the dark halo can ultimately be thought of, following the precept of darkness as a divine abyss, as an interminable zone of unthinkability. For Bataille, the horror of this unthinkability is not primarily what saddens him. Rather, it is to know that his own being serves him indexically as an abyssic pit that simultaneously points to and acts as his sadness. In this interminable zone of unthinkability being and affect are forever confused, serving as the torrential emphasis of his self-confusion but also as an impetus to mystical self-subversion.

Our aim in this section has been to examine how changes in the affective-ontological structure of the self (as a construct and hinge of power relations) has been produced and corollarily annihilated through the ex-

perience of mystical sorrow exemplified by Bataille, a writer who imagines his own negative relationship to such a structure as crucial to his own exhilarating non-experience of individuation. For Bataille, self-identification with sorrow becomes an act of self-emptying, a playing backwards of himself that functions to actualize the cosmic wounds of life and thereby gain union with nothingness. Bataille's notion of the dark halo allows us to situate the concept of weird mysticism within the variability of mystical sorrow, and also to problematize it, allowing readers to see that weird mysticism, bending beyond the limits of the unthinkable, is also created from the unthinkable, in the very act of writing itself.

NOTES

1. From the Greek para, "beside, near, from, against, contrary to," the term "para-academia" in this sense refers to the recent rise in blogs, theory-fiction, commentary, and open-access publishing that runs "alongside" or goes "beyond" traditional academic forms and practices. Para-academics tend to feel at home when creating discourses that deviate from or threaten academic norms, often finding repose in obscure mediums and modes of writing. Black metal theory, for example, is a form of para-academia that formally blurs the boundaries between heavy metal music and theoretical discourse.

2. In "The Weird: A Dis/Orientation," Roger Luckhurst states that "another way to understand this veering of the weird is to think about it as a mode that offers a formal rendition of *perversity*" (1051). The notion of the weird as a harbinger and/or as a rendition of "the perverse" will make itself known on multiple occasions in this book.

3. We can add here the limits of the "humanistic" as well, which was one of the cruces of his disdain for Breton's Surrealist tendency and his interest in experimental sociology and anthropology.

4. Along with bewilderment, the ineffable is one of the defining characteristics of apophatic language. Ineffability evokes the subsequent *trauma* done to speech by the divine. Bataille's notion of the impossible thus subverts mystical discourse: it transmutes the trauma/failure of speech into a mode that paradoxically does what it describes.

5. This mode of confessional writing is bewildering indeed and, in a sense, unanchors itself from the text, often resulting in a stupefying play of language which has no recourse to its readers' intentions or of potentially extracting something formal from it.

6. Cf. Michel Surya on Georges Bataille: "It is not only the absence of God that tortures, but the Impossibility into which desire falls once God has gone" (302–03).

7. And here we have a connection to post-structuralism. Language is precisely that which is unthinkable yet thinks.

8. Michèle H. Richman, in her study of the College of Sociology, states that "in its Bataillian version, modification of the individual's inner economy within collective forms of expenditure leads to intensified communication also qualified as sacred" (14). These concentrated forms of communal experience served a dual purpose for Bataille. First, the sacred dispelled the focus on the individual reveries of surrealism, and secondly, it served as a corollary to his early writing life in *Documents* and the *Encyclopaedia Acephalica*, where constant expansions of key terms—heterology, baseness, excess, eroticism—were not only theorized but practiced.

9. In fact, it calls to mind an anecdote used by Thomas Ligotti when he defines "macabre unreality," a term we deployed in chapter 2. In it, he likens the quintessen-

tial horror tale to that of the man who, lying in bed, reaches out his hand to place his glasses on the end table, only for the glasses to be taken by a set of hands he didn't know were there. For our purposes here, we can say that the horror experienced by this man is double: not only finding out that this figure is in the room, but also realizing how long it has been there—perhaps all along (the longevity of his life).

10. Here we can recall a passage in "The Call of Cthulhu" when the infamous *Necronomicon* is quoted: "That is not dead which can eternal lie, / And with strange aeons even death may die." As Roger Luckhurst notes, the weird is full of "fake books, fake libraries and fake traditions," that is, of *pseudobiblia* like the *Necronomicon*, an imaginary book which now does exist as a book, and has done so since at least 1969" ("The Weird" 1048).

11. The play of doubling becomes an essential feature of Bataille's heterogeneous thought, as is stems from ruptures within his logic of negativity. Noting a key passage from *Inner Experience*, Fred Botting and Scott Wilson write that "the dynamic momentum of negativity is neither contained in a productive system of thought nor expanded in exhaustion. It remains at play in a 'double movement' of action and questioning or contestation, in which the one is endlessly opposed to the other in a continual 'rupturing and disequilibrium of the system'" ("Introduction," *The Bataille Reader* 15).

12. In *Literature and Evil* (1957), Bataille notes his affinity for the work of nineteenth-century French poet Charles Baudelaire. Bataille equates Baudelaire's poetic genius with the uncompromisingly unique experience of horror and ecstasy, two concepts that form the basis for much of Bataille's own work: "As a child I [Baudelaire] felt in my heart two contradictory feelings, the horror of life and the ecstasy of life" (46).

13. As Amy Hollywood makes clear, Bataille calls this nonplace "the impossible" (80).

14. On this point, is can be noted that the significance of the text is in its very textuality, its paradoxically expressive inertness. The materiality of the inscripted word on the page is something Bataille found horrifying, too. After all, it is the whiteness derived from rot or the signification derived from the annulment of whiteness.

15. The term "repository" is used with slight hesitation here knowing well, following Denis Hollier in *Against Architecture*, that Bataille was aggressive toward architectural metaphors because of their "anthropomorphism" and that the human form is "embedded in architecture" (xi–xii). However, we can position our use of the word repository within what we will call an *archi-texture*, which clarifies more fully both the (inter- and intra-)textual and essentially textural (or compositional) qualities of Bataille's writing.

16. It is a *désoeuvre*, note Fred Botting and Scott Wilson, "in the sense that its negativity is unemployed, in the service of nothing and no one" ("Introduction," *Bataille Reader* 4).

17. Cf. "Poetry is sacred in so far as it is *nothing*. The truth of modern poetry is to have deprived poetry of *substance*" (*The Absence of Myth* 100).

18. The original French reads: "alors j'aurai fait le vide / dans ta tête abandonee" (*L'Archangélique* 91).

19. Cf. "Ghost in tears / O dead God / hollow eye" (*Inner Experience* 103).

20. Hector Kollias maintains that Blanchot's use of literary language gives us "what Blanchot calls 'the existence before the day,' the existence of things before they became things, of a world before it was constituted into a world, dust which permeates without being visible and color that is not illumination" (qtd. in Hill 127). Thomas's world is pre-dialectical, a world before the world takes place.

21. The translators of this short piece on Rimbaud, Mark Spitzer and Emmanuelle Pourroy, emphasize that it was found in Bataille's notes. What he refers to in the quotation, then, is the last section of his book *The Impossible* called "The Oresteia."

22. Cf. Bataille writes: "Poetry is not a knowledge of oneself, and even less the experience of a remote possible (of that which, before, was not) but rather the simple evocation through words of inaccessible possibilities" (*Bataille Reader* 111).

23. This latter half of the poem is also evocative of a mystical sorrow that we explored much more deeply in the earlier section where we recalled a quintessential characteristic of the medieval mystical text *The Cloud of Unknowing* in which the ultimate sorrow is a sorrow over the fact of one's very existence.

24. The original French of "La nuit est ma nudité" reads: "mon envie de vomir en vie / ô ma faillite / extase qui me dort" (*L'Archangélique* 115).

25. According to Greek mythology, Orestes took to murdering his mother. This story of madness was one that Bataille knew well, and it had also been rewritten by his then rival Jean-Paul Sartre. Stuart Kendall notes that "Bataille explained in a letter to Jean Lescure, 'Poetry contents itself with evoking Orestes, one must be Orestes . . . become the man who questions nature, the pure questioning of everything as a completion of man'" (169). The poems and commentaries in *The Oresteia* are insightful if not obscure examples of Bataille's dual critique and reappropriation of poetry at that time.

26. One example is when the narrator of Bataille's "A Story of Rats" enters into darkness, saying "I entered into this darkness where, ever since, I plunge deeper every hour and lose myself a little more" (44). This quotation can be thought to echo Saint Bonaventure's call in the thirteenth-century mystical text entitled *The Journey of the Mind to God*, to "let us then die, and enter into this darkness" (39).

27. Cf. "Thus we say that man must be so poor that he is not and has no place wherein God could act. Where man still preserves some place in himself, he preserves distinction. This is why I pray to God to rid me of God, for my essential being is above God insofar as we comprehend God as the principle of creatures" (214).

28. It also is worth remarking that in Sontag's case, as Leland Poague notes, melancholy can be contextualized within a "specifically feminine form of modernism" (xlii). In the afterword, we will make the claim that weird mysticism seems to be situated within a particular type of modernity, one that is fairly masculine and Eurocentric. Further study of the genre would perhaps take care to extend its scope to include other forms, including more feminine ones.

29. In "Problems of Surrealism," he also states that "there can be *nothing* sacred. The sacred cannot be a *thing*. The instant alone is sacred, which is *nothing* (is not a *thing*)" (99).

30. Cf. Bataille in *On Nietzsche*: "Anguish in me contests the possible. To an obscure desire it opposes an impossible obscurity."

31. At another point in *The Impossible*, we read, "a while ago I wept—or, dry-eyed, accepted the disgust; now day is breaking and the feeling of possible sorrow exhilarates me: life stretches within me like a song modulated from the throat of a soprano" (18).

FOUR

E. M. Cioran

The Horror of Being Oneself

"A MAN FROM NOWHERE": OR, THE STRAY

In France, Romanian-born philosopher E. M. Cioran spent his twilight years living in a student garret and struggling with Alzheimer's disease. By most accounts, he was a frail but shrewd old man, a curmudgeon who grew physically tired fairly quickly. He also grew quickly tired, metaphysically speaking, of talking about, well, just about anything at all. As Ilinca Zarifopol-Johnston frames it, "Whether insomniac, suicidal, or in varying stages of nervous exhaustion, [Cioran] always wrote with the greatest *intensity*, always, from the first, 'on the heights of despair'" (124). In part, highlighting this passage aims to show how Zarifopol-Johnston, Cioran's biographer, emphasizes this intensity's importance on his work. It causes him great personal duress, but also indicates self-endurance: "What do you do from morning to night? / I endure myself" (Cioran, *Trouble* 36). There are two poles to this kind of self-endurance: an existential pole comprising one's suffering of being and a mindful pole that attempts to hold one back from distraction and escapism. On the one hand, self-endurance makes incredible demands on oneself: "We moderns have discovered hell inside ourselves and that is our good fortune" (*Tears and Saints* 52).[1] On the other hand, self-endurance is a spiritual exercise, the act of pure observation of oneself without identifying with or dramatizing such hellish demands. Writing with the "greatest *intensity*" becomes an authentic mystical capacity to hover between passion and dispassion, to engage and disengage. The extent to which Cioran's work is circumscribed and informed by this polarity of self-endurance can be said to be the result of his affective experience of the world, that of

heightened despair, and his mindful interrogation of the ontological condition of the universe—its worthlessness. Practically all of Cioran's writings hover around a nihilistic epicenter of apocalyptic decay, as he prophetically points readers toward the existential and historical demise that surrounds them—if they could only see it for themselves.

Considering the corpus of his work, which, in staccato-like fashion, posits deliriously mordant aphoristic fragments on subjects ranging from mysticism, nothingness, suffering, despair, paradox, aesthetics, and spiritual ordeal, this chapter will undertake a speculative analysis of E. M. Cioran's thought that will hinge and unhinge itself based upon three underlying propositions that permeate this chapter. First, there is no E. M. Cioran (in the sense of a writer who sees self-identification in positive terms). Second, Cioran is a liminal figure: his philosophy is based in and on, but is not of, this world.[2] Another way of saying this is that, in his work, what is being posed is a philosophy of having too much of *this* world in a manner that is not *for* it, and as such is un-human. Third, his thought is incomplete (but not pejoratively so) because it consists of fragments. As we continue, we will thus seek to posit and conduct a schematic analysis of Cioran's work in relation to these propositions, as they serve to reverberate and heighten his special blend of weird mysticism.

And so, we will begin this chapter, knowing that Cioran speculatively opens the rational to the unreasonable. Nevertheless, an extremely important question arises in our midst: noting his characterization as already stated, why on earth would anyone want to read the old pessimist Cioran? In exploring the ways in which Cioran deploys the fragment, we will aim to show how pessimism, which, as Eugene Thacker suggests, "is the lowest form of philosophy, frequently disparaged and dismissed, merely the symptom of a bad attitude" ("Cosmic Pessimism" 66), holds a close relation to the notion of "failed mysticism" and that, against its relegation to the margins of philosophy and despite its futility, what the scholarly world actually needs—and secretly, even if unknowingly, begs for—is more pessimism.

It is difficult to explain the intense and acerbic nature of his pessimism, especially given the complicated character of his personal, political, and intellectual lives. In fact, we will leave the vast intricacies of that ardent task to his past and future biographers, as that continues to remain a project in and of itself. In his book *Pessimism* (2006), Joshua Foa Dienstag constellates Cioran, along with Albert Camus and Miguel de Unamuno, under the heading of "existential pessimism." According to Dienstag, existential pessimists "reconstitute the issues that preoccupied the earlier pessimists (the burden of temporality, the dearth of happiness, the futility of striving, boredom, and many others) by focusing on the life conditions of the modern individual" (119). Keeping the profundity of Cioran's work in mind, we can begin by speaking with care about two particular points regarding Cioran's life without reducing them to the

realms of cliché or the commonplace—for Cioran was neither. First, Cioran's life, tied to the geographic and hence deeply political climates of his time, and which undoubtedly went on to influence his political, personal, and intellectual lives, can be divided into two sections: his time in Romania, from his birth in 1911 until he exiled himself in 1937, and in France, from 1937 up to his death in 1995. Second, and stemming from the first geographic distinction, Cioran's writing can be divided into three main periods. As Marta Petreu notes in *An Infamous Past* (2005), the first was a deeply philosophical period in which Cioran was influenced by Arthur Schopenhauer's metaphysics; the second, from roughly 1933 to 1941, was Cioran's "political period"; and the third period is characterized by highly stylized writing in which he astounds readers with statements resembling those of the early Greek sophists, particularly Gorgias and Protagoras (254–55).

In order to make sense of Cioran's complex writing life, it is necessary to build upon these insightful remarks made by Petreu.[3] Cioran's early writings are Schopenhauerian in nature (they are characteristic of a metaphysical rather than an existential pessimism) and are cast with the shadow of Romania's past, and the Iron Guard, looming behind him. Norman Manea notes that after the completion of *The Transformation of Romania* (1936), Cioran, writing against an extremist Romanian right-wing, "claimed for *himself* the right to be unique, above the mob" (xi). Notably, *Tears and Saints* (1937) was self-published shortly thereafter within the same year. Whereas the mystical rhetoric in *The Transformation of Romania* served a deeply political function, *Tears and Saints* worked explicitly as a commentarial discourse on mysticism. Written so closely together, and with their political and mystical leanings, the pair of books accentuate the tension between this-worldly and other-worldly in his work. Certainly, the two books are connected in a desire for spiritual revolution, a discourse of the far right that is typically ignored or downplayed by its opponents. Manea continues: "As a master of paradox and therefore an 'anti' thinker, a fighter against canons and standards, common sense and common taste, Cioran always followed his stubborn 'anti'-ness as an imperative, even when it was not of real spiritual relevance but frivolous self-indulgence" (xi–xii). Over the course of his life, Cioran will continue to vacillate between the depths of spiritual ordeal and the fettering debacle of selfhood: "On the frontiers of the self: 'What I have suffered, what I am suffering, no one will ever know, not even I'" (*All Gall* 103). It is important to note that Romania serves as a geographical and temporal ruin for Cioran, the disastrous receptacle of political upheaval; but it is also *ruinous*, ensconcing this dire past, a path from nothing that deviated to nowhere, deep within his memory.

Along with other Romanian intellectuals including Mircea Eliade and Julius Evola, at this time Cioran was involved in a broader narrative which viewed Romania as a kind of spiritual/intellectual crucible. Exca-

vating the ruins of the past, then, is an underlying impetus to his work done in Romania. But his excavation will bear little in the way of finding new remains in France. His first French book, *A Short History of Decay* (1949), was to be a work of sustained poetic aphorisms that survive within the tradition of the "nihilism of the great sophists" (Petreu 234).[4] In it, the leitmotif of ruination finds cognizant expression. In "The Mockery of a 'New Life,'" for instance, Cioran writes,

> It is because all men who cast a glance over their past ruins imagine—in order to avoid the ruins to come—that it is in their power to recommence something radically new. They make themselves a solemn promise, waiting for a miracle which would extricate them from the average abyss into which fate has plunged them. But nothing happens . . . I have known no new life which was not illusory and compromised at its roots. (*Decay* 68)

To comment upon the misguided logic of all men who believe it is in their power to recreate themselves is suggestive of a contained critique of the failure of the human will to impose any teleological command onto one's life. In other words, Cioran casts into suspicion the metaphysical notion that creating a new life free of egoism and illusion *without* fated exposure to one's own abyss is possible at all. The skepticism of change represented in this example recognizes a level of psychological inauthenticity within a person who believes themselves capable of leaving behind their own fateful abyss and insists that the underlying conditions that would enable one to start anew are in fact null and void.

In contrast to cultivating a life formed from a radical newness, Cioran opted to accept his fate, to continue his unique and obsessive skepticism in a manner that accentuated, rather than quelled, the personal torments of alienation, and yet allowed him, like a good clown-cum-pessimist, to abandon himself of taking it all so seriously. Living in exile enabled him to distance himself from the perpetuity of his radical Romanian youth, thus rendering him able to construct a Cioran freed of political affiliation yet overtly lacking in any desire for further spiritual development. This renunciation of the spiritual, however, will ironically become for him a sort of perverse site of spiritual ordeal. In *The Trouble with Being Born* (1973), for example, Cioran writes, "For a long time—always, in fact—I have known that life here on earth is not what I needed and that I wasn't able to deal with it; for this reason and for this reason alone, I have acquired a touch of spiritual pride, so that my existence seems to me the degradation and erosion of a psalm" (15). At present we must be careful in attributing to Cioran's complex identity structure any warrant on his behalf to identify with himself as a self whatsoever.

In order to illustrate this point, let us take, for example, the words spoken by Cioran's "Anti-Prophet," an anti-hero that surfaces in his book *A Short History of Decay*. Cioran writes, "Once I had a 'self'; now I am no

more than an object . . . I gorge myself on all the drugs of solitude; those of the world were too weak for me to forget it" (7). If to posit such an Anti-Prophet is also to deploy a rhetorical strategy of mystical writing that radically heaves the "self" into annihilation, prioritizing solitude in lieu of differentiating himself[5] in a world or a community of others, then he also sounds strangely like Meister Eckhart, who says, "I will tell you what I think of people: I try to forget myself and everyone." In fact, following the first proposition—there is no E. M. Cioran who self-identifies—the thrust of Cioran's own existence, like that of the Anti-Prophet, tends to gravitate toward absolute non-identification with himself as himself or anyone else, which echoes the Pseudo-Dionysian mystical understanding of being "neither oneself nor someone else" ("Mystical Theology" 137).

Keeping in mind that Cioran, a particularly non-religious thinker who would have abhorred the title of being a "mystic," adopts the mystical precept of non-identification with oneself or others, he becomes of increasing interest to us here. It also marks an important shift in the way Cioran began to view himself as a writer and philosopher. Ilinca Zarifopol-Johnston writes, "By 1949, when the French book he started composing in 1947 appears, as *Précis de decomposition*, he has cast off both his Romanian language and identity, and yielded to a long-cherished obsession: not to be a Frenchman, but to be a man from nowhere" (134). His obsession with non-identification allows him to existentially create a version of himself that is both everywhere and nowhere, molding, to follow Petreu, into a "wandering sophist,"[6] an itinerant stray with no map, nothing to lose or to gain.

In one way, Cioran's writerly conjunction of mystical brevity and self-naughting wanderlust mirrors Angelus Silesius's *Cherubinic Wanderer*, the seventeenth-century collection of over sixteen hundred short poems composed of Alexandrine couplets: "I am a blessed thing, could I a nothing be, / Stranger to all that is, for nobody to see" (41). Though unlike Silesius's rhyming couplets, Cioran's fragmentary style gestures toward the dissonance of being. And as he strays, in paradoxical fashion, he stays put. Or, more accurately, he *floats* nowhere within an anti-natalist psycho-spatial bubble, warding off his own birth.

In chapter 1, we discovered that the word "weird" is etymologically related to "wyrd"—meaning what happens or becomes. Like Georges Bataille, Cioran is weird in this sense because he has been self-exposed to the horror of being himself; he must become what he essentially *is*. "Weird" is also synonymous with wandering and nomadism. He is nomadic, an outsider in the sense in which Bataille puts it as seeing the essence of self as foreign: "In the abandon in which I am lost . . . the essence of myself arises from this—that nothing will be able to replace it: the feeling of my fundamental improbability situates me in a world where I remain as though foreign to it, absolutely foreign" (*Inner Experi-*

ence 69).[7] Following this logic of negation, the notion of "being a man from nowhere" comes into new light. It is the point at which, against Dienstag's diagnosis of Cioran as primarily an "existential pessimist," we can call him, more acutely, to follow Thacker's formulation, a "cosmic pessimist." Doubly weird, the fate of his own individuation has stopped this nomad in his tracks. Though not entirely a bad thing to be lost, for there is nowhere to go in the Cioranian universe, and yet not necessarily free, or trying to flee, for the weight of the wandering causes him despair, a question is to be raised about the *ontological position* of this weird mystic. If Cioran is a cosmic pessimist who comes from nowhere, is not going anywhere, and has expunged his past, then, ontologically speaking, exactly how and where does Cioran exist? And is this space *human* at all?

With this question, we have just sketched an outline for the second proposition referred to earlier, that the liminal ontological position from which Cioran writes is not of this world. Hence Cioran's writing self may actually exist in a space of horror that is essentially *un*-human, which is another way of saying, fully human, in the sense of someone who keeps his eyes open in astonishment to the fact that he, anything, is happening in the first place. Camelia Elias suggests that the density of Cioran's writing marks the "experience of a continuous space . . . punctured by interruptions that mark some degree of skepticism and uncertainty as to one's state of mind—am I sad or am I not?—the role of the subjunctive is nonetheless to reestablish a relation to the continuous dimension" (58). The dimension to which Elias refers is essentially horrible. Hence, to further clarify how Cioran's ontological positioning as a writer can be based in and on, but not of this world, we need to show that this position is essentially derived from and contingent on the space of horror. To illuminate this point, let us take, for example, when he writes in *All Gall is Divided* (1952), "Except for the dilation of self, that fruit of total paralysis, what remedy for crises of annihilation, asphyxiation in the void, the horror of being no more than a soul in a gob of spirit" (23). This "horror of being no more than a soul in a gob of spirit," then, is the secret pessimal recognition of being a canceled-out self in between existence and non-existence. As such, his epigrams become auto-commentaries which allow him to experience the divine horror of this essentially voidic space while simultaneously thinking and writing about it.

Put another way, this mystical experience of not-being-anywhere, where one finds oneself not-oneself in the no-where of non-existence, is the negative mode of being *everything*. In "Advantages of Exile," Cioran writes that "it is not easy to be *nowhere*, when no external condition obliges you to do so. Even the mystic attains his *askesis* only at the cost of monstrous efforts. To extricate yourself to the world—what a labor of abolition!" (*Temptation* 76). The mystical insight of this apophatic formulation is beautifully laid forth in *The Cloud of Unknowing*, in which the author writes, "Leave aside this everywhere and this everything, in ex-

change for this nowhere and this nothing" (252). Horror essentially and counter-intuitively enables Cioran to mystically dwell in the non-sense, in the nowhere/nothing which is really everywhere/everything, to remain still in the space where one does not yet exist.

This formulation echoes, quite uncannily so,[8] Julia Kristeva's discussion of horror in relation to abjection. In *Powers of Horror* (1982), Kristeva presents readers with a critical treatise on the "abject," a term used to describe the space of horror, of "radical exclusion," drawing us "towards the place where meaning collapses" (2). She writes,

> A massive and sudden emergence of uncanniness, which, familiar as it might have been in an opaque and forgotten life, now harries me as radically separate, loathsome. Not me. Not that. But not nothing, either. A "something" that I do not recognize as a thing. A weight of meaninglessness, about which there is nothing insignificant, and which crushes me. On the edge of non-existence and hallucination, of a reality that, if I acknowledge it, annihilates me. There, abject and abjection are my safeguards. (2)

If we are to accept that the ontological positioning of Cioran's verse, to follow Kristeva's discussion of abjection, flows from the edge of non-existence, then we can go one step further to identify not who—for he has denied himself a self—but *how* Cioran "is" (which is really another way of saying what he is *not*): a me-ontological nomad who, via an inhuman mysticism, wanders beyond being. Thus, the liminal space of Cioranian horror can be defined not only by what is, but also by what is not, which is another way of saying that it concerns itself with a small branch of philosophy called meontology, the study of non-being.[9]

Abjection, thus construed, is this haunto-physiological site which, corporeally situated between bios and life, factically opens a wormhole to the Outside. That is to say, the abjection actualized via the facticity of the body thus renders the Outside insidiously inside, an Inside-out where in the fallen deject, weirdly enough, becomes bodhisattva personified, a holy figure or saint. As such, following Quentin Meillassoux, facticity is the path to the absolute.[10] Facticity is fundamentally connected to disgust, to negative affect (disgust, of course, is located in your own body). For Cioran, the "you" is the reader. The fable, so to speak, is always about the reader, about *you*. Mystical texts often address *you*, and if not, then the reader ought to question who, exactly, is being addressed. The issue of address (of literary form) is always already lurking inside the text, opening to the reader.

The in-humanness of horror becomes a trope in Cioran's fragmented work, in which the horror of being oneself in this world becomes deictic fodder, the material to propel a self-abnegating mode of writing against the *bearing out* of that to which it refers. In one example, Cioran posits a paradigm for what Eugene Thacker calls the "world-without-us," as he

imagines a world after humanity has vanquished, a world, no doubt, inhabited only by no-things like himself. In a chapter of *Anathemas and Admirations* (1986) entitled "On the Verge of Existence," Cioran writes, "'The end of humanity will come when everyone is like me,' I declared one day in a fit I have no right to identify" (20). It is in the sense that Cioran is at once existentially a writer, and yet one who opts for a liminal plane at the edge between existence and non-existence, of a self that is not yet self and of a world that is not world, that he is bound up in his own Cioranian paradox of double refusal.

On the one side of this double refusal, he is E. M. Cioran, a man, "an unknown author . . . from the margins of Europe," a self-exiled philosopher who literally changes his pen name on the "eve of his French debut" from Emil to E. M.—mimicking E. M. Forster, who was at the time only moderately famous (*Searching for Cioran* 8). Zarifopol-Johnston writes that "Cioran does not belong to the 'once-born,' . . . He belongs to the 'sick souls' or divided selves,' that is, those who strive for a 'second birth' . . . [the] young Cioran was engulfed in a cycle of identity crises (existential, religious, political) leading to exile and eventual triumph" (8). Given Cioran's greater focus on birth in his work, wherein he professes a stark anti-natalist attitude believing it would be better to have never been born, this second birth is contingent on getting back to "a time when time did not yet exist" (*Trouble* 17). Cioran will go on to morph his "creative capacities . . . into a born-again writer" (Zarifopol-Johnston 9), attempting to find his way back to this time before time through a highly practical, albeit neurotic, mode of mystical writing.

On the other side of this double refusal, he is a *deject*—a ghostly placeholder of the abject; the stray anti-locus of the negative. In *Powers of Horror*, Julia Kristeva signals "an exile who asks, 'where?'" writing about a stray, "The one for whom the abject exists is the a deject who places (himself), *separates* (himself), situates (himself), and therefore strays instead of getting his bearings, desiring, belonging, or refusing" (8). The parenthetical relegation of the pronoun "himself" in this quotation indicates a demotion of the deject's subjectivity to a place neither outside nor to the hither side of being, but rather to a third space that conflates and usurps its own autonomy. In this passage, the pronoun "himself" is a mere anti-moniker, one not joined to another object, but to its own divisibility, hence, the phantom signature of an ontological nomad. She continues,

> Instead of sounding himself as to his "being," he does so concerning his place: "*Where* am I?" instead of "*Who* am I?" For the space that encloses the deject, the excluded, is never *one*, not *homogenous*, nor *totalizable*, but essentially divisible, foldable, and catastrophic. A deviser of territories, languages, works, the *deject* never stops demarcating his universe whose fluid confines—for they are constituted of a non-object, the abject—constantly question his solidarity and impel him to start

> afresh. A tireless builder, the deject is in short a *stray*. He is on a journey, during the night, the end of which keeps receding. . . . And the more he strays, the more he is saved. (8)

In the night of his dejection, "those nights when you convince yourself that everyone has evacuated the universe, even the dead, and that you are the last living being here, the last ghost" (*Anathemas* 119), Cioran strays, and yet, goes anywhere.[11] To illustrate this point, let us take, for example, these remarks in *Anathemas and Admirations* wherein the delineation of straying versus staying put is at once indistinguishable and absolute. "Fragments, fugitive thoughts, you say," writes Cioran, "Can you call them *fugitive* when you are dealing with obsessions—with thoughts whose precise quality is not to *flee*?" (*Anathemas* 11). With this, it becomes evident that perhaps the true textual utility of the Cioranian fragment is that it inscribes a way to weed out thought that germinates and then sprouts through the cracks of thought and expression, a technique in which epigrammatic fissures allow room to perfect the double erasure of self/world and world/world. This double erasure is how the cosmic pessimist saves himself against a world in which he does not wish to exist, by becoming an epigrammatic wanderer, a no one veering[12] ever so often into the ghostly desert of subtractive thought.

Philosophers and literary critics have largely attributed to Cioran's writing a variety of significances, presenting more or less unfailingly depictions of his work as gnomic and speculative.[13] Susan Sontag, for example, in her introduction to Cioran's *The Temptation to Exist*, calls him a "poet-philosopher,"[14] although Cioran, in his indefatigable pessimism, would have perhaps resisted such idealism. She states that he "writes about impossible states of being, about unthinkable thoughts. That's his material for speculation" (14). Perhaps, then, the lure of Cioran's writing lies in the fact that his auto-abnegating sensibilities, ones that deepen his disgust for the world and disclose to him the irreparable conditions of facticity, seem so sincere:

> *I am absolutely persuaded that I am nothing in this universe; yet I feel that mine is the only real existence.* If I had to choose between the world and me, I would reject the world, its lights and laws, unafraid to glide alone in absolute nothingness. Although life for me is torture, I cannot renounce it, because I do not believe in the absolute values in whose name I would sacrifice myself. If I were totally sincere, I would say that I do not know why I live and why I do not stop living. The answer probably lies in the irrational character of life which maintains itself without reason. (*On the Heights of Despair* 33)

Insofar as self-abnegation can hold a quality of sincerity—vis-à-vis not wanting anything from anyone, even oneself—Cioran holds it. He detests not only the world, but also himself, or at least that inner ego-laden phantasm that goes so far to call itself a self, professing, with exacting

insight and clarity, the banes of world, individual, Other. He attempts, despite himself, to think the unthinkable.[15]

Given the focus of this book, in the following sections particular interest will continue to be given to Cioran's assessment of mysticism, given that he is at once critical and laudatory of mystics; to how mysticism's failure is appropriated to serve his epigrammatic discourse of pessimism; and to how this subsequent discourse is then linked with the larger notion of cosmicity. The three writers highlighted in this book each hold a deep interest in mystical discourse and in many cases deliver writing that highlights and enacts a gap between self and world, but, at times, abhor the impetus to mystical work and in fact are quite critical of the mystics. Cioran is perhaps the exemplar of this kind of work, as he paradoxically creates a negative ontology that is at once non-philosophical and anti-mystical but also deeply enmeshed in spiritual ordeal and a specific set of writing practices. Locating the interplay among horror, mysticism, and philosophy specifies that, as readers and critics, we can participate as receptors in the genre-bending techniques these authors utilize in their work, even if we are at times alienated from them because of it. Such participation deepens the potential for synthesis of human thought with that of an inhuman absolute, which reinvents weird mysticism as a mode of thought and, by the opposite side of the same token, renders thought itself as a kind of weird mysticism.

SONGS OF SICKNESS: "CULTIVATING THE FRAGMENT"

In "The Gnomic Philosopher," an essay in *The Temptations of Emile Cioran* (1997), Michael Finkenthal writes that Cioran

> has invented his own form of paradox, which entices us with melancholy and pessimism. It is based on the following construct: The subjective positive is based on an objective (or factual) negative. This is similar to, I have in my pocket this wonderful thing which will kill me. The conclusion of the Cioranian paradox is that we are condemned without any recourse. (152)

In lieu of Jean-Paul Sartre's famous phrase, "Man is condemned to be free," Cioran sees not freedom, but rather existence itself, as the ultimate condemnation: "Man is free, save for his depths," writes Cioran, "On the surface, he does as he likes; down there, will is a meaningless syllable" (*Anathemas and Admirations* 4). As such, Cioran, as he invokes pessimism's "unwillingness to move beyond the 'worst'" (Thacker, "Cosmic Pessimism" 69), views existence itself as sickness or dis-ease. So imbedded in Cioran's work is this pessimo-existential paradox[16] that it circumscribes and informs his use of the fragment as a mode of writing, which brings us to the third proposition mentioned previously: Cioran's thought is incomplete, but not pejoratively so, because it is fragmentary,

not systematic. And although Cioran's modern work stylistically resemble aphorisms, it might be useful to clarify the link and subtle difference between the fragment and the aphorism and then show how the Cioranian fragment is linked to the notions of sickness and disease,[17] for as Cioran notes in *A Short History of Decay*, "disease is an activity, the most intense a man can indulge in" (11).

The genre of the aphorism has a long history. In the German tradition, the aphorism was famously deployed by the eighteenth-century Enlightenment thinker Georg Christoph Lichtenberg, a figure who inspired Friedrich Nietzsche, whose aphorisms, in turn, are still widely read to this day. There are also the nineteenth-century French aphorists, including Friedrich Schlegel and Novalis, each of whom held importance in the development of Nietzsche's use of the aphorism (Faber xxvii), who helped give credence to the genre. The so-called credential work of the aphorism can be put rather bluntly. Dienstag writes, "The seemingly fragmentary form of the collection of aphorisms communicates, ahead of the content, the condition of disorder that pessimism as a whole describes in the world" (228). The question of style, therefore, is tied to the enactment of descriptions that are modeled after the perspective they hope to convey. "As a result," Dienstag continues, "rather than emphasizing community and identity, as a dialogue does, aphoristic wisdom tends to separate its reader from his or her self and from the group of which he or she is a part" (229). This is a specific, vivid description of writing practice indeed, one that also entails a role for the reader.

For Nietzsche, the use of aphorisms enables both self-contradiction and an active, assembly role for the reader, and is often ordered toward unity or summit-thought via his peak-to-peak formulation. The text itself contains its negation, both formally and performatively. In Cioran's case, however, the modernist stylistic use of aphoristic verse is essentially self-abnegating from the standpoints of social world, readership, and authorship. In this way, Cioran's style is better expressed by the word "fragment." To enter Cioran's writing, Camelia Elias notes, "First one has to pass through the back door, which is the fragment. Cioran writes it on the invitation to his critic whose challenge consists of grappling with the difference between Cioran's self and Cioran's fragment. And there is no difference" (*The Fragment* 146). In this way, Cioran's fragment holds a close relation to what Simon Critchley calls "unworked romanticism," a process instantiated by the Jena romantics at the turn of the nineteenth-century in which one responds to the "predicament of post-Kantian philosophy . . . by cultivating the fragment, that is, a self-undoing theoretical practice" (xxi). For Cioran, the fragment serves, what we might call, an abortive function. First, to follow Critchley, it is a theoretical practice that undoes the self, instantiating that the brevity of the fragment be utilized as a negative form of elucidation. As such, the fragment textually mirrors Cioran's anti-natalist call that it is better never to have been born. Not

having lived, fragments are forever—we may go so far to say, eternal. Second, the Cioranian fragment reverse engineers the function of systematic logic. It rhetorically transforms systematic assessments of the world into an unworked romanticism that aborts rationalism in favor of a pessimistic logic of negativity.

The ultimate (f)utility of the Cioranian fragment in this case, then, is that it reveals the defunct nature of using human reason as a platform to propel and/or perceive thought. "However intimate we may be with the operations of the mind," he writes, "we cannot *think* more than two or three minutes a day;—unless, by taste or profession, we practice, for hours on end, brutalizing words in order to extract ideas from them. The *intellectual* represents the major disgrace, the culminating failure of Homo sapiens" (*All Gall* 84). Cioran thus stands on the other side of philosophical systems[18] which prioritize meaning garnered from rational means and thinks they ought to be aborted.[19] In contrast to positivistic aphorisms that lead to cumulative, climactic, or congratulatory sentiments, the Cioranian fragment is an abortion of reason, in that it leads readers into a realm of paradox, as it peers into essential problem of existence as Cioran sees it: being is its own double, continuing its sickness by its own sickened continuance.

To further understand how the Cioranian fragment is deployed, we can analyze it with reference to this Cioranian paradox of sickness. In *The Theology of Illness* (2002), Jean-Claude Larchet remarks, "To be philosophical about . . . sickness and suffering means above all for a person to consider what they reveal to him [sic] about his condition" (58). Larchet continues,

> By confining the soul within the limits of the body, sickness and suffering destroy any illusions of fullness and self-sufficiency a person may have previously had, illusions fueled by a state of health he took for granted. They teach a person the extent of their poverty, even their ontological nakedness. . . . The person can no longer consider himself as absolute, since his fundamental pride is broken. (59)

Though Cioran's notion of sickness goes against the pedagogical logic of spiritual ascension via the impoverishment of illness that Larchet will go on to emphasize in his book, the general sense of sickness as maladaptation to existence exhibited in the quotation is Cioranian in the sense that it reveals one's ontological nakedness and corollary dereliction from the absolute. In this way, sickness is a site of non-spiritual ordeal that can paradoxically lead readers, by realizing that by thinking they are a "someone" is the seed of their own pain, into a pessimal mode of higher awareness that is actually and counter-intuitively beneficent.

In short, Cioran's fragmentary writing is a performative experiment. The productive element of pessimism lies precisely in what it does *not* show and do. His fragments are shaped through the literalization of ni-

hilistic impressions, the content of which are surveyed in the text itself which sustains its own thetic and readerly negation. Hence, the malady that will not heal is formally structured into the fragment. Readers of Cioran are confronted with themselves as the symptomatic existential expression of a malady that will not heal, which is another way of saying that the facticity of sickness is the paradigm of existence. In order to eschew such sickness, the answer is simple: one simply need not exist. In *A Short History of Decay*, for example, Cioran writes,

> How long must I have been telling myself: I loathe this life idolize. The nullity of our deleriums makes us all so many gods subject to an insipid fatality. Why rebel any longer against the symmetry of this world where chaos itself can only be a *system* of disorders? Our fate being to rot with the continents and the stars, we drag on, like resigned sick men, and to the end of time, the curiosity of a denouement that is foreseen, frightful and vain. (181)

This cryptic passage reveals what is not so simple, however, and that is our true plight, through which we play out our lives lived in systematic disorder. Rather than to rebel against this disordered system, one would do better to accept one's fate, "to rot" with the cosmos and continue to "drag on, like resigned sick men." This is an intense thought, but one which Cioran thoroughly defends. Zilla Gabrielle Cahn writes that "we must defend ourselves against our healers . . . even if we die for it . . . [and] preserve our sickness and our sins,' because for Cioran, who never tired of repeating it, lucidity came only in sickness" (374). "He wished to counter the human 'temptation to exist,' the ever-present and irrepressible life-urge which makes us dupes to an indifferent universe," Cahn continues, because for Cioran, "it is not human despair that is in danger, but human optimism" (374). In this way, we will argue, Cioran deploys the pessimal notion of lucidity sickness to reveal the ways in which optimism has worked to heighten human naiveté rather than to dispel it.

On this central point, Cioran's stance can be contrasted to that of Friedrich Nietzsche, the indomitable pessimist, who, on the notion of sickness, deviates quite a bit, viewing it not as an immanent ontological aberration, but rather as an emancipatory spur. Both philosophers see sickness as a requisite part of existence, yet whereas Cioran views it within an unrelenting pessimism, Nietzsche affords it an opportunity for personal growth. In the Preface to *Human, All-Too-Human*, Nietzsche writes, "And, speaking seriously, [sickness] is a radical *cure* for all pessimism (the well-known disease of old idealists and falsehood mongers) to become ill after the manner of these free spirits, to remain ill a good while, and then grow well (I mean 'better') for a still longer period" (11). Here Nietzsche begins to outline a rather curious element of his thought, that of the "free spirit," an ideal individual who steps out of sickness and "draws near to life . . . grateful to his wandering, his austerity and self-

estrangement, his far-sightedness" (10–11). Free spirits, of whom perhaps Nietzsche himself is the exemplar, have been unshackled from their sickness, wandering into new zones of possibility. In fact, Nietzsche held the free spirit to be a predecessor to the ideal philosophers of the future. J. M. Kennedy remarks,

> It must be clearly understood . . . that Nietzsche's disease must not be looked upon in the same way as that of an ordinary man. People are inclined to regard a sick man as rancorous; but any one who fights with and conquers his disease, and even exploits it, as Nietzsche did, benefits thereby to an extraordinary degree. In the first place, he has passed through several stages of human psychology with which a healthy man is entirely unacquainted. . . . Secondly, in his moments of freedom from pain and gloom his thoughts will be all the more brilliant. (4)

Kennedy's remarks on Nietzsche's illness illustrate for readers an essential point of departure for Cioran from Nietzschean pessimism. On the one hand, Cioran could be said to definitely exploit his bouts with mental and physical sickness, both serving as a double motif which intermittently punctuate his body of work. On the other hand, however, and against the Nietzschean attribution of sickness as a kind of emancipatory or individuating circumstance, Cioran sees absolutely no possibility for a free spirit or for other ideals including the *Übermensch* (Overman).

Being a philosopher of the future who holds no interest in finding a way out of the predicament of "life as suffering," Cioran inverts the Nietzschean ideal of the free spirit—"what joy even in the weariness, in the old illness," Nietzsche writes, "in the relapses of the convalescent" (11)—into a vision of staying put, a philosophy of going nowhere: "Paradise was unendurable," writes Cioran. "otherwise the first man would have adapted to it; this world is no less so. . . . What to do? Where to go? Do nothing and go nowhere, easy enough" (*Trouble* 13). Although Cioran wanders the path as a dejected stray, he never finds—nor does his wish to—his way back. The sickness of which Cioran speaks cannot be overcome. Self-estrangement wins out. To those, then, who prioritize existence as life-giving and hold optimism to be a form of health, Cioran's defense of sickness, which affords that life's meaninglessness holds its true meaning—"The pessimist has to invent new reasons to exist every day: he is a victim of the meaning of life" (Cioran, *All Gall* 12)—becomes quite unsettling. Let us take, for example, when Cioran writes that "[w]ithout illness there is no absolute knowledge. Illness is a primary cause of history; sin, only a secondary one. Consciousness is a symptom of estrangement from life caused by illness. Everything that is not nature was revealed to the first sick man when he looked up at the sky for the first time" (*Tears and Saints* 95). Accounting for the effects of a lived contradiction, that consciousness is a "symptom of estrangement from life," Cioran's work helps readers understand how lucidity about exis-

tence's profundity[20] might be gained from sickness and how this condemnation shapes the possibility for the conditions to achieve a kind of negative aletheia, a disclosure of the illusions by which we unknowingly live.

OF FAILED MYSTICISM: A THREEFOLD ONTOLOGY OF DEATH

Now that we have sketched the Cioranian paradox of lucidity sickness, which is nonetheless a defense of pessimo-existential sickness in order to reveal humankind's misgivings, we can turn once again to the question of mysticism in Cioran and how his views on mysticism's failure help to shape his pessimistic oeuvre. In the introduction to this chapter, we discussed Cioran's fixation on situating his self-identity within the Pseudo-Dionysian mode of annihilative mystical non-identification. One way to understand this paradoxical relationship is to view his identification with non-identification in such a way that his aphoristic style becomes a representational method to model the experience of existential futility. For example, Cioran writes,

> There exists an undeniable pleasure in knowing that everything you do has no real basis, that whether or not you commit an action is a matter of indifference. The fact nonetheless remains that our in our daily gestures we compromise with Vacuity—that is, we turn and turn about, and occasionally, at the same time, we take the world as real and unreal. We mingle pure truths and sordid truths and this amalgam, the thinker's disgrace, is the living man's revenge. (*Anathemas* 79–80)

In this passage, Cioran invokes a form of mingling with vacuity, occasionally gaining a sense of the world outside ourselves as being either real or unreal.[21] Cosmic pessimism's power, if it can be said to have one, hinges upon this sense of vacuity, which, said another way, is that vacuity becomes *instructive* via the pessimal mode of detachment: "When you imagine you have reached a certain degree of detachment," Cioran writes, "you regard as histrionic all zealots, including the founders of religions. But doesn't detachment, to have a histrionics of its own? If actions are mummery, the very refusal of action is one as well. Yet a noble mummery" (116). This detachment, pessimism's "noble mummery," also indicates a relation to twentieth-century mystic Simone Weil's notion of detachment. Weil writes, "The reality of the world is the result of our attachment. It is the reality of the self which we transfer into things. It has nothing to do with independent reality. That is only perceptible through total detachment. . . . Attachment is a manufacturer of illusions and whoever wants reality ought to be detached" (*Gravity and Grace* 14). Against the logic of Christian mystical detachment exhibited by Weil, but for a logic of pessimistic detachment in which one refuses all action, we find in Cioran a double refusal of the worst, one which negates, to

follow Thacker, the for-us (human action) and the in-itself (Weil's independent reality). This is the sense in which Cioranian pessimism is really a failed mysticism.

In another example, Cioran becomes what he describes, as he invokes a poetics of deixis that points back to himself as a failed mystic. In *The Temptation to Exist*, he writes,

> Upon myself I am only too aware of the stigmata of my time: I cannot leave God in peace; along with the snobs, I entertain myself by repeating that He is dead, as if that had any meaning. . . . When Nothingness invades me and, according to an Oriental [sic] formula, I attain the "vacuity of the void," it so happens that, crushed by an extremity, I fall back on God, if only out of a desire to trample my doubts underfoot, to contradict myself and, multiplying my *frissons*, to seek in Him a stimulant. The experience of the Void is the unbeliever's mystic temptation, his possibility for prayer, his moment of plenitude. At our limits, a God appears, or something that serves his turn. (120–21)

Again "vacuity" comes into play, this time as kind of voidic attainment. The Cioranian paradox of this passage is that it is marked by the interplay of existential crisis and spiritual ordeal. Cioran reflects that his non-engagements with the void lead him to his own "mystic temptation." In other words, he treads that same mystical territory of bewildered unknowing, even while atheistically distancing himself from it.

Trained in the pessimistic tradition, Cioran studied the great German pessimists Arthur Schopenhauer, Friedrich Nietzsche, and Oswald Spengler. Whereas Schopenhauer's pessimism held an affinity for Eastern mysticism and Nietzsche's pessimism had moments of mystical clarity, Cioran, as we noted, sees mysticism as a failure, but one that, as it strips away the mystics' material attachments, is capable of deepening their oneness with the absolute. He remains interested in the practical nature of mysticism. According to Meher Baba,

> Spiritual experience involves more than can be grasped by mere intellect. This is often emphasized by calling it a mystical experience. Mysticism is often regarded as something anti-intellectual, obscure or confused, or impractical and unconnected with experience. In fact, true mysticism is none of these. There is nothing irrational in true mysticism when it is, as it should be, a vision of Reality. It is a form of perception that is absolutely unclouded, and it is so practical that it can be lived every moment and expressed in everyday duties. Its connection with experience is so deep that, in one sense, it is the final understanding of experience. (*Discourses* 5–6)

Cioran's work seems to hover on the edge between neurotic reaction and authentic spiritual experience.[22] His early anti-mystical writings are borne of a Schopenhauerian metaphysical pessimism that seeks its own annihilation, neurotically attributing pointlessness to the world and dis-

closing a consequential melancholy[23] over existence. However, he also utilizes, in part, a highly practical double mysticism of self-endurance/erasure. As such, he is able to critique traditional mysticism from a vantage that is at once susceptible and unthreatened by contradiction.

His piercing study of the mystics in *Tears and Saints* (1937), for example, is "a critique of [the mystic's] will to power which reaps nothing but empty and cruel suffering" (Zarifopol-Johnston xiii). The mystic's attempt to ascend into God-consciousness establishes the prototype for a will to power in which suffering is perpetuated for a greater good, a movement that is at odds with Cioran's understanding of suffering. Zarifopol-Johnston writes that "*Tears and Saints* represents in some ways Cioran's philosophical struggle with himself, a text full of contradictions and ambiguities" (127). She continues, "As a discourse on mysticism, it is neither mystical discourse nor objective, impersonal philosophical discourse. Generically, it resembles Nietzsche's hybrid philosophical commentaries" (132). By providing a non-mystical and non-philosophical discourse on mysticism, Cioran begs a fundamental question on the nature of the absolute. His skeptical commentaries render him neither on the side of mysticism nor philosophy, but rather suggest that while mystical discourse attains to undermine temporality and individuation in order to merge with the absolute it holds a heuristic utility that philosophy does not. In short, philosophy holds an impoverished view of mysticism.

Cioran's contradictory writings both reveal and magnify existence's futility, indexing a mode of discourse that, resembling a dissociative series of meditations on such futility, informs and is informed by his pessimism. The indexical nature of his writing thus presents readers with a series of negations, textual detachments that index various forms of existence, call them into question, and then consequently negate them. In other words, to extol existence as the very worst is also to index it via its very negativity. This strategy is akin to an ontological argument for futility via futility, whereby readers are provided with epigrammatic analyses of being's worstness via the very renunciations of being these analyses seek to reject. In this way, Cioran's writings exile him from both philosophy and mysticism. At this point, then, it may be helpful to raise a further question about Cioran's textual strategy: If everything is eventually negated via its own futility, then why write at all?

In "Foreshortened Confession," a short autobiographical essay written toward the end of his career, Cioran comes close to providing his readers with a theory of writing. In an intense fit of extimacy, he notes, "I write in order not to take action, to avoid a crisis. Expression is relief, the indirect revenge of one who cannot endure shame and who rebels in words against his kind, against himself" (*Anathemas* 248). As such, his writings are performative, in the sense that they describe existence and then call that existence into a conceptual annihilation. They comprehend what Thomas Ligotti calls existence's "malignant uselessness" and then

consign this existence into annihilation. But there is an inherent paradox to this performance itself, for comprehending existence necessarily means recognizing its ultimate futility and, more so, even futility's futility. Thus, if existence is malignantly useless, then this very performativity is futile, the negation itself is also quite malignantly useless. This is the Cioranian paradox inherent to reading Cioran's writings. Absolutely nothing in itself has any point at all. If this is indeed the case, then what function does writing play for Cioran? Could it be considered a kind of perlocutionary statement, an act of writerly persuasion in the absence of any perceivable practical purpose?

Another look at Cioran's views of writing might be helpful to illustrate the relationship between futility and writing. Cioran admits that "writing is a provocation, a fortunately false view of reality that sets us above what is and what seems to be," and, even more than this, to write is "to rival God, even to exceed Him by the mere virtue of language: such is the feat of the writer, an ambiguous specimen, torn and infatuated, who, having forsaken his natural condition, has given himself up to a splendid vertigo" (*Anathemas* 249). There is no cure for existence at large, but there is a cure for the disease of being oneself, one which requires a kind of total writerly nigredo: "Without the faculty of blackening pages, I wonder what I would have become. To write is to get free of one's remorse and one's rancors, to vomit up one's secrets. The writer is an unbalanced being who uses words to cure himself" (249). The cure, then, is to intensify this blackening so much that one loses oneself via the maddened vertigo of its production. Writing means to rebel against the wisdom of the saint via the vertigo of the madman, to blacken one's being via writing. Cioran's theory of writing is the ultimate failed mysticism,[24] for it negates itself as writing, just as mysticism negates itself as mysticism, and subsequently calls philosophy into its own kind of mystical annihilation.

In "Dealing with the Mystics," a short essay in *The Temptation to Exist* (1956), Cioran writes,

> Contrary to [the] abstract, false void of the philosophers, the mystics' nothingness glistens with plenitude: delight out of this world, discharge of duration, a luminous annihilation beyond the limits of thought. . . . Here the mind is suspended, reflection abolished and, with it, the logic of disarray. If we could, after the example of the mystics, pass beyond the evidence, beyond the impasse which proceeds from it, if we could become that dazzled, divine errantry, if we could, like them, reascend to the *true* nothingness! (155)

In this passage, Cioran problematizes philosophy's relation to itself via an invocation of the mystic's notion of nothingness. In so doing, he illustrates pessimism's departure from mainstream philosophy and pessimism's corollary ability to show philosophy its own shortcomings. He

also outlines several important tenets that are germane to the relation between pessimism and mysticism.

By attesting to the fact that philosophy fails in its attempts to access Void, he identifies a principal issue in the history of Western philosophy since the time of Immanuel Kant. Kant's philosophy posits a subject-object model of knowledge that refutes the potential for knowing a noumenal realm beyond human access. According to Kant, it is not the human mind that conforms to objects, but rather objects that conform to the human mind. While this Kantian explanation is on one level precise, it stresses the primacy of human beings to think only the correlation between subject and object and as such relegates access to the absolute to something outside of human thought. Cioran suggests that mysticism offers an important counter-narrative to this emphasis on subject/object correlation, or what Quentin Meillassoux calls "correlationism,"[25] by seeing the predicament of the mystics as an experimental tool by which to rethink how to access the absolute, as well as opening up a rupture to show a gap in philosophical discourse on the nature of non-human reality. What can initially be seen as his criticism of the mystics also paradoxically becomes a validation of them, one that secretly illustrates the primacy of their ability to think beyond the correlation between self and world but also blurs the division between world and world. However, Cioran remains skeptical of mysticism; whether the mystic, despite time and the individuation of herself, succeeds in accessing the absolute is a question implicit to Cioran's discussion of the figure of the failed mystic.

"The failed mystic," Cioran writes, "is the one who cannot cast off all temporal ties. Caught between mysticism and history, he wanders forever in the no-man's-land connecting this world to the other" (*Tears* 67). As we discovered in the introduction to this chapter, Cioran is a stray, a wanderer who goes nowhere but is in fact everywhere. This passage, in which the failed mystic "wanders forever in no-man's land," bears a striking resemblance to the authorial conundrum in which Cioran finds himself: *he* is the failed mystic. Zarifopol-Johnston writes,

> Centered on this figure of the failed mystic, Cioran's discourse on mysticism is a self-consciously blasphemous parody of mystical discourse. The voice of the faithless mystic introduces a new perspective into the traditional genre of the saints' lives, that of despair, and thus gives a new accent to the mystical experience, deliberately and perversely distorting its meanings. For example, "paradise from the viewpoint of despair" becomes "the graveyard of happiness." (133)

She continues that he views suffering as fundamentally tragic and "aimless, since it does not hold out the promise of redemption inherent in Christian notions of suffering, which are carried to extremes in mysticism. Suffering, behind which Cioran detected a will to power, is ineffectual; it achieved nothing except more senseless and cruel suffering" (133).

The will to power in Christian mysticism's notion of suffering to which Zarifopol-Johnston refers to is extreme because it accentuates an ascetic category that non-saints will never know. However, according to Cioran's failed mystic, this ascetic suffering is also essentially useless; it reaps not an effectuated Oneness with the absolute but rather just more exhaustive suffering and sorrow.

In order to analyze this passage further, we can take as a counter-example work done by the anonymous author of the *Theologia Germanica*. This book, a medieval mystical treatise composed in Frankfurt, Germany, grants that "[g]rief and sorrow over sin should and must remain in a divinized person until he leaves his body in death, even if he were to live until the latter day, or forever" (110). The author continues,

> This [Christ's] hidden sorrow over man's sinful condition is an attribute of God's that He has chosen and that He is pleased to see in man. But it is God's attribute above all. Sorrow over sin does not finally belong to man; man is not himself capable of it. Wherever God can bring it about in us, it is the most pleasing and the most appropriate but at the same time the most bitter and heavy undertaking on which we can enter. (110)

Written in the late fourteenth-century during a time of papal power struggle, the author, being a member of the "Friends of God," was participating in mystical restoration. The author is committed to the elimination of ecclesial restrictions and advocates a form of anagogic self-knowing, wherein one actualizes the presence of Christ in the here and now. This passage articulates the necessity of existential sorrow in a person's relationship to God, which rests on the same kind of presence that caused Christ's hidden sorrow. There are plenty of Christian references that are constrained to the historicity of book itself, but nonetheless, the *Theologia Germanica* helps us to recognize the depth of the Cioranian problem of existence.

Writing in a time after the "death of God"—"If I believed in God, my fatuousness would be limitless; I would walk naked in the streets" (*All Gall* 91)—Cioran deploys the inversion of the divine paradox of sorrow articulated above. Whereas the anonymous author of the *Theologia Germanica* emphasizes the primacy of sorrow as a divine gift of sorts, Cioran sees it as a prevailing existential malady. "If we squeezed a madman's brain," writes Cioran, "the liquid that emerged would seem like honey compared to the gall secreted by certain melancholics" (*All Gall* 80). In this passage, Cioran manages to measure the gap in intensity between the madman and the melancholic in terms of an analogy of viscosity between honey and gall. The knowledge acquired by the madman is sweet compared to that of the bile-like knowledge of the melancholic. This fragment could be said to be an inverted analogue to Nietzsche's aphorism in *Human, All Too Human* entitled "Onwards," where he writes,

> When your sight has become good enough to see the bottom in the dark well of your being and knowing, you may also see in its mirror the distant constellations of future cultures. Do you think this kind of life with this kind of goal is too arduous, too bereft of all comforts? Then you have not yet learned that no honey is sweeter than that of knowledge, and that the hanging clouds of sadness must serve you as your udder, from which you will squeeze the milk to refresh yourself. (175)

The Cartesian emphasis on "no honey is sweeter than that of knowledge" serves Nietzsche's free spirit, the philosopher who sees the truths in a culture defunct of meaning, in a way that transmutes sadness into a kind of antidote (Faber xxxiii). Cioran's post-Nietzschean pessimism, however, is grounded in his fidelity to the notion that existence is a bile enterprise replete with no possibility for repair, offering a "no saying to the worst, and a further no-saying to the possibility of any other world, in here or out there" (Thacker, "Cosmic Pessimism" 68).

For readers, this implicit paradox of the worst holds as its negative index the possibility for a sorrow experienced in an ultimately pessimal mode of self-knowledge in which even death itself, in other words, death as an escape from life, is a disappointment. Death's disappointment is its non-possibility for escape, but due to death's de-actualization as nothingness it necessitates itself as everything. To think of death, then, is to cultivate a sorrow reared for a mystical meditation on death. Again, as with Georges Bataille in chapter 3, Marguerite Porete's words from *The Mirror of Simple Souls*, that "the best I can tell you is that if you understand perfectly your nothingness you will do nothing, and this nothingness will give you everything" (115), are especially useful. Her formulation of nothingness as everything is indicated in Cioran's own formulation on death: "Life is nothing; death, everything. Yet there *is* nothing which is death, independent of life. It is precisely this absence of autonomous, distinct reality which makes death universal; it has no realm of its own, it is omnipresent, like everything which lacks identity, limit, and bearing: an indecent infinitude" (*Trouble* 152). According to this formulation, it would appear that death is not a culminating experience at the end of one's life. Yet neither can it simply be said that it is a realm of nonbeing or non-existence, for it "has no realm of its own," but rather, like one who has nothing and is given everything, becomes a kind of "indecent infinitude." If the essence of death expresses a kind of metaphysical defeat, in which one must negate oneself in order to be given infinitude, then can one negate one's life pessimally through their failures? Does the essence of death precede one's own life?

In order to see how Cioran understands death, it may be useful to have a definition of "life." In *A Short History of Decay*, Cioran describes a kind of "life" that is as lifeless as it is pointless. He writes,

> What we call *our* life, in relation to "life," is an incessant creation of vogues with the help of an artificially manipulated speech; it is a proliferation of futilities, without which we should have to expire in a yawn that would engulf history and matter alike. . . .
>
> It is only too legitimate to imagine the moment when life will no longer be the fashion, when it will fall into desuetude like the moon or tuberculosis after the abuses of romanticism: life will then crown the anachronism of the denuded symbols and the unmasked diseases; it will once again become *itself*: an ill without prestige, a fatality without luster . . . the mind itself will give way; it is only an excuse in the void, as life is only a prejudice. (90)

In order to overcome a life like this, one would have to achieve the impossible. As Nick Land states, "Death is the reality of the impossible, making fictions of us all, and it is only in fiction that we separate ourselves from it" (171). Thus, to throw off the fiction of existence—"Everything that *is* engenders, sooner or later, nightmares. Let us try, therefore, to invent something better than being" (Cioran, *Trouble* 114)—is to become death, to be given the reality of the impossible. If existence is indeed itself a fiction, which, in this context, also means a kind of lie one tells oneself in order not to rot, the question then becomes: What would an ontology of life via Cioranian paradox of existence as sorrowful sickness, a non-life that exists at the limit of its own end, which is also to say, a life that takes place always already in the immanent horror[26] of death, actually entail?

"By dwelling on the infinity of death," writes Cioran, "thought manages to *use it up*, to inspire disgust for it in us, disgust, that *negative* superfluity which spares nothing and which, before compromising and diminishing the prestige of death, shows us the inanity of life" (*Decay* 12). What he offers here is not a critique or assessment of death, but rather something more along the lines of a commentarial counter-narrative that speaks from the opposite side of the reader's infinite grave of meaning, the impossible space of a possibility for death's voice. Characterized by the impossible structure of a limit-experience, Cioran's fragments on death reflect the ability of the fragment to reveal what the hidden circumstances dissonantly induced by death's very incomprehensibility. In other words, Cioran's cosmic pessimism senses the phenomenal relation between death and being by linguistically traversing the cracks of the fragments rather than understanding it as a whole or totality. He continues:

> The man who has not given himself up to the pleasures of anguish, who has not savored in his mind the dangers of his own extinction nor relished such cruel and sweet annihilations, will never be cured of the obsession with death: he will be tormented by it, for he will have resisted it; while the man who, habituated to a discipline of horror, and meditating on his own carrion, has deliberately reduced himself to

> ashes—that man will look toward death's *past*, and he himself will be *merely a resurrected being who can no longer live*. His "method" will have cured him of both life and death. (12)

One must totally give themselves up to the decadence of anguish if they wish to be cured of their fixation on death. Yet, even more fully, if one can achieve the method of death by meditating on oneself as *already dead*, then one will have cured oneself of *both* life and death. The Cioranian paradox found in this passage thus posits a speculative threefold ontology of life connecting existential anguish, extinction, and the anteriority of death via resurrection. This mode of writing serves as the glome, or higher dimensional analogue, of the commentarial three-sphere woven into the threefold ontology.

We have done our best in an earlier section of this chapter to outline several tenets of Cioran's views of existential anguish. Concerning the second element of this threefold ontology of life, Ray Brassier's work, which primacies the relations among extinction, purposelessness and pessimism, is instructive. The following quotation could be said to be a secret speculative commentary on the paradox Cioran lays bare above. Brassier writes,

> Extinction is real yet not empirical, since it is not in the order of experience . . . it is precisely the extinction of meaning that clears the way for the intelligibility of extinction. Senselessness and purposelessness are not merely privative; they represent a gain in intelligibility. The cancellation of sense, purpose, and possibility marks the point at which the "horror" concomitant with the impossibility of either being or not-being becomes intelligible. Thus, if everything is dead already, this is not only because extinction disables these possibilities which were taken to be constitutive of life and existence, but also because the will to know is driven by the traumatic reality of extinction, and strives to become equal to the trauma of in-itself whose trace it bears. (238–39)

Brassier's paradoxical remarks illuminate the negative capacity of thinking about extinction which Cioran opens up in *A Short History of Decay*. In other words, the performative function of negativity aligns with what the writing is doing as writing. In order to speculatively think a world that is intelligible, one must first one must first negativize it, that is make it unintelligible through the indexicality of horror. The immanent, essentially de-constitutive element of extinction always already precedes life.

Concerning the third and final element of this threefold ontology of life, Cioran's epigram foreshadows an inverted model of futural resurrection found in Quentin Meillassoux's recent remarks on "immanent immortality" in *The Divine Inexistence*, wherein the shock at one's own existence "ceases to be anguish or a contemplation turned back on itself" (193). Meillassoux continues,

> The philosophical astonishment that we feel before an existence depraved of any "why" ceases to be identified with the shrill and desperate consciousness of a godless human condition that leads us to no specific *act* other than perhaps suicide. Instead, it henceforth becomes the source of both our most extreme and immanent hope. The shock felt before what has already in fact arisen becomes by the same stroke the comprehension of that which can *really* be a world delivered to itself. Only those who know how to live this astonishment also know how to hope. For only those who comprehend the utterly staggering character of their own existence know that even resurrection would be less astonishing. (193)

The two hold an almost similar view on existence itself: the fact of one's existence in a world without a "why" is a source of philosophical astonishment. Yet Meillaissoux's post-Cioranian philosophy deviates from the concept of anguish at one's existence, positing a possible—which, really is to say, impossible—life lived in the astonishment of itself. Meillassoux's ethical imperative leaves open the space for a coming futural God who does not yet exist, yet might one day exist. But whereas Meillassoux would offer that one's learning how to live in this astonishment is the source for an ethics of hope, Cioran would negate any possibility for an existence lived in hope. If Cioran's work can be said to posit anything even resembling an ethics, it is truly a negative ethics of the crevasse: a politics *of* the crevice *through* the crevice, one which lowlights a heretical discourse of "cosmic catachresis." If it is an ethics, then, it is a writing, and nothing more.

"COSMIC CATACHRESIS"

"The feeling of being ten thousand years behind, or ahead, of the others, of belonging to the beginnings or to the end of humanity," writes E. M. Cioran (30), quickly followed by: "Negation never proceeds from reasoning but from something much more obscure and old. Arguments come afterward, to justify and sustain it. Every no arises out of the blood" (30–31).[27] The central, paradoxical invocation and criticism of mysticism in Cioran's work opens up and invites several questions as to the nature of cosmicity and its relation to human existence. In the two previous aphorisms, taken in sequential order from his book *The Trouble with Being Born* (1973), Cioran describes an invaluable paradox on (being a) human being. The *ideal* human being, in his view, is one who is a negation of oneself, an antediluvian human being who remains bewildered by their very being. Nietzsche understands the necessity of such antediluvian thinking when he writes, "Oh, those humans of old! They knew how to dream and didn't have to go to sleep first!" Such an understanding points to the antediluvian human being as the human being *par excellence*; that

is, one who is *already awake*. However, Cioranian pessimism inverts this essential awakedness into a "double refusal" or kind of "sleep," a "no-saying to the for-us and the in-itself" (Thacker, "Cosmic Pessimism" 68).

Through instantiations of vivisected thought, Cioranian pessimism begs a crucial question: Why is life so terrifying? To which Cioran might reply: because individual fear is bound up in a "cosmogonic discomfort" wherein the notion of where one comes from collides with the bewildering fact that one *is* at all: "Every individual discomfort leads back, ultimately, to a cosmogonic discomfort, each of our sensations expiating that crime of the primordial sensation, by which Being crept out of somewhere" (*Trouble* 16). Cosmic pessimism's essential and bulldozic mode of extolling the worst, the epigram, reveals part by part the vivisected remains of the anatomy of thought at its fringes. These vivisected thoughts, pinned down by the pen, are, as Camelia Elias notes, "words that take infinite flight in our gut. . . . If he were still alive, Cioran would call this point in the anatomical space cosmic catachresis" (58).

In his boiled-down language and staccato-like preciseness, characterized by the poetic and piercing insights of pessimism's unequivocal worldview of the worst, Cioran's work traces the vanquished movement of thought at its fringes. Cioran uses the aphorism[28] to both invoke and exceed thought itself. The short form's brevity thus imbues epigrammatic thought with a kind of cosmic delirium, indicating the perspicacity and inventiveness of the Cioranian paradox as a paradigm of thought that links the tropes of existential crisis and spiritual ordeal to cosmic origin through pessimal metaphors drawn from the language of skepticism: "I am invited to a colloquium abroad, there being a need, apparently, for my vacillations. The skeptic-on-duty of a decaying world" (*Anathemas* 14). As Michael Finkenthal explains, "Skepticism is in a way paralyzing. One ends in doubting one's own doubts" (150). Cioran's writing enacts a mode of pessimistic skepticism in which self-scrutiny becomes a circumspect, ex post facto vehicle for positing the conditions, traps, and pitfalls of human existence. In fact, Cioran approaches even the self-reception of his own writing work through a lens of sardonic self-scrutiny: "Each time I find myself assigning some importance to things, I incriminate my mind, I challenge it and suspect it of some weakness, of some depravity. I try to wrest myself from everything, to raise myself by uprooting myself; in order to become futile, we must sever our roots, must become metaphysically *alien*" (*Temptation* 119).[29] This formulation of becoming "metaphysically *alien*" to oneself and the world is one way in which the cosmic pessimist defends herself against existence.

In *Tears and Saints*, for example, Cioran writes, "The creation of man was a cosmic cataclysm, and its aftershocks have become God's nightmares. Man is a paradox of nature, equally removed from it and from God. The order of things in heaven and on earth has changed ever since the creation of consciousness. With it, God appeared in his true light as

one more nothingness" (70). According to the notion of cosmic catachresis, it follows that all personal wounds would thus stem first and foremost from a cosmic wound, that of individuation, which severs the human from the infinity and ubiquity of the cosmos and yet is this very wound that allows access to them. "Suffering opens our eyes, helps us to see what we would not have seen otherwise," writes Cioran, "Hence it is useful only to knowledge and, except for that, serves only to poison existence" (*Trouble* 176). Moreover, he writes in *Tears and Saints* that philosophy fails to provide us with answers, and that "compared to philosophy, saintliness is an *exact science*. It gives us precise answers to questions that philosophers do not even dare consider," but sanctity, whose "method is suffering and its goal is God" is revelatory (47).

According to this notion of sanctity as an "exact science" whose method is suffering, it follows that one is capable to regain cosmic knowledge only through the auto-annihilating and invariably pure gesture of one's own human suffering, the conduit or wellspring of cosmic mourning. "When one is devoured by such an appetite for suffering that to satisfy it would take thousands of existences," he writes, "we realize out of what hell must have arisen the notion of transmigration" (*All Gall* 91). In this example, Cioran is on the side of an *absolute* suffering[30] rather than a tolerable suffering; for it opens up those crevasses and cracks even further to de-create the gestalt, for one to question one's existential foreground, or, the inexplicability of one's existence, against one's cosmic background, that one yanked oneself from the cosmos itself. In a double negation of self and world, and of world and world, which is to say, to follow Thacker, a negation of the for-us and the in-itself, Cioran offers a critique of consciousness from the perspective of "individual and cosmic loneliness":

> One can experience loneliness in two ways: by feeling lonely in the world or by feeling the loneliness of the world. Individual loneliness is a personal drama. . . . An outcast in the world, indifferent to its being dazzling or dismal, self-consumed with triumphs and failures, engrossed in inner drama—such is the fate of the solitary. The feeling of cosmic loneliness, on the other hand, stems not so much from man's subjective agony as from an awareness of the world's isolation of objective nothingness. It is as if all the splendors of this world were to vanish at once, leaving behind the dull monotony of a cemetery. *(On the Heights of Despair* 50)

At the limit of this extreme view is formed an uncompromising realization of one's own negativity, for it discloses that one's individual discomfort is contingent on a cosmic discomfort in which the world itself is alienated from world and is in fact limitless.

We can call this strange awareness, to follow Elias, a cosmically catachrestic one, which is appropriate considering that the word "catachre-

sis" stems from the Greek *katakhresthai* "to misuse," from *kata-* "down" (here with a sense of "perversion") + *khresthai* "to use" (*Online Etymology Dictionary*). The cosmically catachrestic movement in the epigram moves not towards authorial creation but against it, de-creating the autobiographical impetus to self-revelatory[31] writing by severing the autonomy of its own activity. For Cioran, writing happens in the interstice of doing nothing, and to do nothing is to say "no," to refuse the "temptation to exist" at all costs: "Since day after day I have lived in the company of Suicide, it would be unjust and ungrateful on my part to denigrate it," writes Cioran, "What could be healthier, what could be more natural? What is neither healthy nor natural is the frantic appetite to exist—a grave flaw, a flaw par excellence, my flaw" (*Anathemas* 89). Existence, the ultimate flaw, the impetus towards penning the reflections seen from a hidden mirror of what is there (out in the world): "Who, in pitch-darkness, looking into a mirror, has not seen projected there the crimes which await him?" (*All Gall* 136). This sort of anti-writing exasperates the scission between thinking what *is* and what *is reflected* to the point where it liminally collapses upon itself, fusing with what *is not*. This interplay between what is, what is reflected, and what is not sets up a series of pivotal questions on the origin of thought: Is thought produced by the cosmos or by the human, or vice versa, or both? Cioran writes,

> Endlessly to refer to a world where nothing yet stooped to occurrence, where you anticipated consciousness without desiring it, where, wallowing in the virtual, you rejoiced in the null plenitude of a self anterior to selfhood. . .
>
> *Not to have been born*, merely musing on that—what happiness, what freedom, what space! (*Trouble* 22)

In this dimensional space of nothingness, Cioran's writings begin to look like the fated etchings of an a-cosmic other: the words uttered by a cosmic doppelganger who usurps the illegitimate pangs of authorial creation through a skepticism of being, paradoxically placing the mode of authorial production, writing, in the hands not of a human creator but precisely within the psycho-spiritual shadow of a pre-dialectical, *un*-human being, one that has vanished before it was even given life, birthed: "No fate to which I could have adjusted myself. I was made to exist before my birth and after my death," writes Cioran, "not during my very existence" (*Anathemas* 119).

Zarifopol-Johnson writes that in Cioran's later work "the wound is . . . hidden from view under writing which has sublimated the martyred author's ideal. The bandage—writing—is the wound's only trace, and the sufferer, now a master of style, is in control of his agony" (15).

Writing, then, is the phantom penmanship of a cosmically catachrestic hand. "If we could only reach back before the concept," writes Cioran, "could write on a level with the senses, record the infinitesimal variations

of what we touch, do what a reptile would do if it were to set about writing!" (*Trouble* 29). Cioran's work sits on the age-old throne of a dead king: although this king is long since disembodied, there is still a veritable power to be found in the throne (if one could just give up the desire for it). Clearly, any hope for humanity has long since died, and yet, as we claimed earlier, we find in Cioran's cosmic pessimism a hidden meditation on the nature of his own marginal ontological *position*, that of an antediluvian human being who writes from an a-cosmic third space, the space of horror.

We see these themes also played out in the literary genre of cosmic horror, especially with regard to the work of H. P. Lovecraft. In a letter to Farnsworth Wright dated July 5, 1927, Lovecraft writes,

> Now all my tales are based on the fundamental premise that common human laws and interests and emotions have no validity or significance in the vast cosmos-at-large. To me there is nothing but puerility in a tale in which the human form—and the local human passions and conditions and standards—are depicted as native to other worlds or other universes . . . when we cross the line to the boundless and hideous unknown—the shadow-haunted *Outside*—we must remember to leave our humanity and terrestrialism at the threshold. (Qtd. in Joshi 1999, xvi)

The insights into "cosmicism"[32] laid out here by Lovecraft serve to further his pessimistic philosophy of the insignificance of humankind. The sweeping implications of Cioran's use of this motif is found in his later period, particularly in *All Gall is Divided* and *The Trouble with Being Born*. These speculative investigations into the peril of human existence in terms of the cosmic origin of thought indicate central overlapping wisdoms that occur in the genre of cosmic horror but do so in an inverse way.

As such, Cioran's cosmically catachrestic fragments mirror non-philosophically the literary tidings of Lovecraftian cosmic horror in two ways: as both a symptom and an antidote. On the one hand, Cioran's writing holds a relation to Lovecraft's awkward style which includes, as Roger Luckhurst notes, in "The Color Out of Space," for instance, the "breaking open of language . . . a logical consequence of trying to describe an absolute otherness, a color for which no human language exists, thus prompting another convulsion of adjectives to catch the impossible" (*The Classic Horror Stories* xx). On this inventive and persistent misuse of language in Lovecraft's fictions, Luckhurst continues, describing it as a rhetorical device "known as *catachresis*, the deliberate abuse of language . . . that continually stumbles against the trauma of the unrepresentable Thing, the shards of the sublime falling back into the debris of his busted sentences" (xx). On the other hand, according to Gary J. Shipley, cosmic pessimism is "the antidote to Lovecraftian/Thackerian cosmic horror: in

the case of the pessimist the horror of unthinkability is transformed into a salve, a place of solace for thinking that cannot escape itself" (par. 17). Through pessimism's essential mode of staying put, and by refusing participation in the exercise of futility that is the world, cosmic pessimism thus mitigates the horror of unthinkability. It also ushers in a counter-intuitive form of pessimistic repose, the ability to *forget* the futile nature of a world that was not asked for: "Our cosmic terror springs," writes Cioran in *Tears and Saints*, "from the memory of the endless night against which God fought his first battle. He partly won, for he made night and day alternate. Man tried to establish the reign of day by conquering the night altogether; he was successful only in imagination. We sleep not to rest but to forget the night we should have defeated" (108). Cioran's work seeks to induce in its readers a kind of indifferent sleep in which one forgets the world. This induction of sleep is counter-intuitively non-productive and thus compels a kind of mystical forgetfulness in which one disremembers the flawed human struggle to know; hence the cosmic pessimist *does* actually rest—rests in the indifferent sleep of non-knowing.

Utilizing this double motif of indifferent sleep and forgetfulness, the relation of Cioran's work to the genre of cosmic horror also divulges Cioran's simultaneous fidelity to and displeasure with philosophy,[33] for Cioran utilizes the motif of cosmic terror against philosophy by advancing upon it from a place that is critical of philosophy, from a negative form of hope: "I too have a hope: a hope for absolute forgetfulness. But is it hope or despair? Is it not the negation of all future hopes? I want not to know, not to know even that I do not know. . . . How much longer all this thinking and philosophizing?" (*Decay* 51). Moreover, Cioran insists that the totality of what can be known is inverted by the existential impossibility of actually knowing it, a vision-in-black, if you will, caused by a particular kind of intellectual nigredo compelled vis-à-vis the void. In *The Trouble with Being Born*, Cioran writes,

> If we see things black, it is because we weigh them in the dark, because thoughts are generally the fruit of sleeplessness, consequently of darkness. They cannot adapt to life because they have not been thought with a view to life. The notion of the consequences they might involve doesn't even occur to the mind. We are beyond all human calculation, beyond any notion of salvation or perdition, of being or non-being, we are in a particular silence, a superior modality of the void. (116)

According to this logic of negativity, thought is, as Cioran puts it, the very "fruit of sleeplessness," and for one to silence thought one must induce forgetfulness, or un-knowing, through indifferent sleep.

Without this pessimo-mystical sleep, a human being remains at odds with oneself. Since the darkness of the cosmos holds one away from thought, a human being is split by her own incomprehension of herself in

relation to the cosmos. And yet it is also the cosmos that *produces* thought, is the origin of thought. In this way, the human being could be viewed as a wound in the cosmos, wherein impossibility comes to know itself only through madness.[34] By thinking, the cosmic wound remains festering. But his strange style begins to dismantle the horror of the cosmos, insisting on a subtractive form of radical knowledge un-production that simultaneously dismantles as it produces itself. This mode of epigrammatic non-thinking via indifferent sleep reflects a strategy for non-philosophical thinking that accounts for an ineffable paradox found in Cioran's cosmic pessimism, which, in this case, is a failed mysticism that employs its own rhetorical shortcomings as its manner of actualization.

Thacker maintains that cosmic pessimism is "a pessimism that is neither subjective nor objective, neither for-us nor in-itself, and instead a pessimism of the world-without-us, a pessimism that is first and last about *cosmos*" ("Cosmic Pessimism" 68). This formulation is evocative of an inquiry into the cosmic nature of human horror and bewilderment that can be inventively applied to Cioran's views on mysticism, cosmos, and consciousness. "Mysticism revolves around the passion for ecstasy and a horror of the void," Cioran writes, "One cannot know one without the other. . . . Consciousness dilates beyond the limits of the cosmos" (*Tears and Saints* 64). This quotation helps us to situate the notion of cosmos within the context of consciousness by recognizing how its interchange registers a dual dissonance/synthesis between self and world, world and cosmos.

One's own consciousness, shrouded in cosmic oblivion, is the dark, uncanny element that haunts this interchange—consciousness is itself cosmic. There is also what lurks beyond it, which is really to say *within it*: "An anxiety born out of nothing suddenly grows in us and confirms our homelessness. It is not 'pyschological' anxiety, it has something to do with what we call our soul. In it is reflected the torment of individuation, the ancient struggle between chaos and form. I can never forget those moments when matter defined God" (*Tears and Saints* 100). There is an anxious fear that lurks behind the veil of consciousness, the fear that being oneself is contingent on a much more horrifying cosmic fear, that one's being is essentially and interminably uncanny, rendering a kind of cosmic homelessness enacted via the torment of individuation. It is not what lurks beyond the reflection, but the reflection itself that causes these anxieties "born out of nothing." In view of this negative logic, most human beings are fearful to discover what lurks beyond their own reflection, for this reflection itself, the reflection of one who has being, is so incomprehensible to them in the first place—hence not "psychological" anxiety, but the anxiety of nothing, torments them. This reflection of one's anxiety via "the torment of individuation" not only symbolizes but *is* one's oneness with obscurity, that is, one is one's own non-oneness with obscurity itself. In keeping with this radical aloneness, this notion of

one's own being as acosmic non-oneness with oneself echoes the famous Plotinian formulation, *phuge monon pros monon* (*Enneads* 6.9.11), usually translated as "the flight of the alone to the Alone."[35]

If there is a lesson at all to be learned from this doctrine of cosmic catachresis, it is to erase the "fiction of being" that we constantly entrust to ourselves, as we dishonestly perpetuate our insideous complicity with our own births. Being's fiction is that it masquerades as non-fiction, that it is the only "reality" that "exists." But Cioran knows better. He implores our awakening to it as well. In order to do so, he instantiates in his readers the requisite seed of inversion to develop a kind of annihilatively critical and critically annihilative reading of the text, but also a reading of the very fictive nature of being itself, in order to become the pessimo-mystical sleuths we were always meant to be. This way of reading, which is a type of occult sleuthing, a kind of "true detection,"[36] sets the stage to dismantle the very stage upon which this fiction takes place, as it reverses the hermeneutic circle, instantiating what could be called the liminal reading method of *crypto-meontology*, the hidden study of non-being.

ZEN PESSIMISM: ON NON-BEING

Shock to the System

Unlike systematic philosophers, many of whom spend large swaths of time grappling with the fastidious organization of their ideas, pessimist philosopher E. M. Cioran gained a reputation for dismantling the so-called systematic utility of philosophy in favor of a fragmented, disintegrative one.[37] As Eugene Thacker suggests in an interview entitled "The Sight of a Mangled Corpse," paying consideration to Cioran necessitates a corollary counter-analysis of philosophy itself. Thus, he indicates that

> there is something in Cioran's work that mitigates against philosophy in the key of philosophy. That is a good definition of "pessimism" to me—the philosophy of the futility of philosophy. Cioran takes up this thread from other thinkers to be sure—Nietzsche, Schopenhauer, Lichtenberg, Leopardi, Pascal, the French moralists. His writing itself works against the presuppositions of grand, systematic philosophy, composed as it is of fragments, aphorisms, stray thoughts. It is refreshing to read his work today, especially against the mania for systematicity in philosophy textbooks or the so-called speculative realist treatises. (386)

Thacker's analysis continues, pointing out that there is "subtractive rigour to this kind of pessimism, what Nietzsche called the rigour of the 'unfinished thought.' Cioran appeals to the secret voice inside all our heads when we read philosophy, or science, or psychology, or self-help: 'Really? You really think we can just figure it all out?'"(386).

Because, as Thacker shows, Cioran is heavily invested in unveiling philosophy's futility[38] in a subtractive mode that, even in its anti-ness still closely resembles philosophy, it may be useful to posit, but in a way that discloses the paradoxical nature of this pessimism, yet another term for what specifically Cioran is doing in his writing. But before we do, let us suggest that one way to theorize Cioranian pessimism, which, at its limit, is really a weird mysticism that negates its own beyond, might be to highlight it within the context of its leitmotif—that of futility—and to point to *its* essential practicality as a transposal of philosophic utility. To do this, we need to begin with the question of ontology. Ontology, the branch of metaphysics that concerns itself with the nature of existence, asks the question of how something can be said to exist. Rather than speaking about Cioranian pessimism on the basis of some totalizing philosophical system,[39] we might do better to see it as laying out a position for a negative ontology, or, more accurately, a meontology (an ontology of what is not) that can teach readers something central and non-exchangeable about existence as it is commonly viewed or agreed upon.

While many may read Cioran's philosophical work as gloomy and incomplete, we should note that these are in fact important features in his work: they are the textual remnants of a rigorous—albeit subtractive—process of un-making oneself and the world via a practical mysticism of intense, pessimistic mindfulness which, as we will later suggest, paradoxically results in a sort of Zen-like no-mind. In opposition to identifying with oneself *as oneself*, his aphorisms and fragments position readers in a marginal space between being and non-being. It is not that Cioranian pessimism changes the condition in which one could be said to exist, for that condition is one of futility, but that it burrows an inhabitable gap between existing and non-existing, and pointing us to it, a liminal mode that claims no throne to a transcendent reality, might enable one to think in a way that is more clearly and immanently pessimal.

Field Notes from Nowhere

For a pessimist, fragmentary writing often serves as ongoing marginalia on the book of systematicity. Cioran's philosophical position, as it views systematic philosophy as a kind of futility warehouse, is composed of fragmentary thoughts that break up not only the language of systematicity but also sever the positivistic conditions for a mode of existing that directs itself and/or validates the "subject" to which it refers on *this side* of being. "As long as you live on this side of the terrible," writes Cioran, "you will find words to express it; once you know it from the inside, you will no longer find a single one" (*Trouble* 53). Yet what would knowing something "from inside" the *other side* of being, which is really to say, unknowing something, look like?

Focusing on themes such as nothingness,[40] despair, suffering, and personal crisis, Cioran's work presents a series of meontological dictums that allow readers to come into mindful awareness of their complicity with the horrors of existence. Let us take, for instance, an aphorism in which Cioran presents this paradox by way of a philosopher who hopes to gain a kind of satisfaction from his ontological forays. Cioran writes, "'Being never disappoints,' declares a philosopher. Then what does? Certainly not nonbeing, by definition incapable of disappointing. This advantage, so irritating to our philosopher, must have led him to promulgate so flagrant a countertruth" (*Anathemas* 113). According to this inventive formulation, any perceived positive conditions for existence are actually ontological misgivings that survive under an ideological rubric of optimistic validation: being does not disappoint. The kōan-like thrust of this aphorism, however, is most powerful in what it does not show. On the other side of the ontological veil of this positivistic philosopher lies "so flagrant a countertruth" that it precedes his statement entirely. In fact, it precedes even the conditions to proffer an ontology. For only in nonbeing is one capable of never being disappointed, if not simply because there is no *is* there—no circumstance nor possibility to exist at all. This notion is perhaps the closest Cioran will come to a "first philosophy" in the Cartesian sense of the term of knowing something in full sureness after casting all into doubt.

Utilizing a negative and equally skeptical logic that subtracts its way from a whole in order to proffer an imperative for non-being, Cioran posits a non-philosophical tenet that primacies non-being as the only truth to be desired: "I have never taken myself for a *being*. A non-citizen, a marginal type, a nothing who exists only by the excess, by the superabundance of his nothingness" (*Trouble* 176). Given that meontology typically utilizes discourse about both being and non-being, Cioran's marginal status as a chameleon-like figure that moves back and forth between being and non-being simultaneously relays to readers what does not happen, that is to say, negatively indexes what happens *nowhere*.

Pessimism's connection to mystical discourses of non-being is well-noted in one of Cioran's pessimist predecessors, Arthur Schopenhauer, who held a personal and philosophic affinity for Eastern mysticism and was strongly influenced by Hindu and Buddhist religious thought. Though, as Peter Abelson points out, "compared to his worldview, which is very severe, Buddhism seems almost cheerful" (255), Schopenhauer agreed that Buddhism's First Noble Truth, *dukkha*—a Pali word commonly translated as "suffering"—was the basis of human existence. In *The World as Will and Representation* (1819), Schopenhauer analyzes several principles of esoteric origin. His description of the ethics of willessness, for instance, is worth quoting at length:

> If [the] veil of Maya, the *principium individuationis*, if lifted from the eyes of a man to such an extent that he no longer makes the egotistical distinction between himself and the person of others, but takes as much interest in the sufferings of other individuals as his own, and thus is not only benevolent and charitable in the highest degree, but even ready to sacrifice his own individuality whenever several others can be saved thereby, then it follows automatically that such a man, recognizing in all beings, his own true and innermost self, must also regard the endless sufferings of all that lives as his own, and thus take upon himself the pain of the whole world. No suffering is any longer strange or foreign to him. All the miseries of others, which he sees and is so seldom able to alleviate, all the miseries of which he has indirect knowledge, and even those he recognizes merely as possible, affect his mind just as do his own. . . . Wherever he looks, he sees suffering humanity and the suffering animal world, and a world that passes away. (378–79)

The purpose of highlighting this quotation is not to subsume Cioran under the rubric of personal liberation that Schopenhauer outlines, but rather to address the fact that Cioran disconnectedly fits into this paradigm just like the fragmented verses he pens fit into his implicit critique of systematic philosophy. In other words, Cioran is and is not this liberated person, does and does not these things. His own contradictory individuation is evocative of what might fragmentarily occur in the ontological gaps and affective crevices of such an individual's life.[41]

What, then, ought the pessimist to do about the problem of communal suffering, the double suffering, no less, that stems both from the horror of one's individuation and, for those who lack self-knowledge, from the inability to recognize such horror? The obvious answer is that the pessimist will do nothing: "What to do? Where to go? Do nothing and go nowhere, easy enough" (Cioran, *Trouble* 13). But what does this mean? How might this negative praxis turn back to the theory of knowledge? If we are to take Cioran's vision of existence, a universe with no way out, seriously, then we must deign to understand the complexity of the ethical paradox this negative vision brings to light. First, we must learn to dwell in the horror of being ourselves. If to exist is truly the ultimate condemnation, if our own births sever us from the abyssic canal of non-being, then we must find a way to exist not. If we follow this through, "being negatively" (23), as Clarice Lispector's G. H. once called it, becomes the way to live rightly, which is also to say justly. This is the hidden mystical life of the marginal figure, the interdimensional chameleon that passes between being and non-being because they know by un-knowing, because they owe themselves nothing other than to know that they know not. In this sense, we might wish, first, to implore a kind of "pessimist activism,"[42] one compelled by an inverted and introverted courage—not hope—to be emptied out, to stay and break bread with one's nothingness.

This would be an assortment of individuals who know they are doomed but have learned to dwell in their own horror so that, one day, they might be able to unlearn it, in order to, as Nicola Masciandaro puts it, "think *through* cosmic pessimism, as opposed to dwelling in it" ("Paradisical Pessimism" 188).

Keeping Schopenhauer's description of the *principium individuationis* and its corollary renunciation in mind, one can see that Cioran hovers somewhere in the middle of the two as a marginal figure. On the one hand, in Cioran's fragmentary work readers find the laborious musings of a man so deeply tied to and cognizant of humanity's suffering that it brings him to a place of innermost, even automatic, recognition of pain and suffering. In this case, Cioran, who, we could argue, has adopted an identity politics of non-identification and has to a degree successfully renounced himself as a self and the world as world, has somewhat parted with the *principium individuationis*. Cioran sees personal and communal suffering everywhere he looks and, as is indicated by the overarching theme of suffering found in his work, he does, as Schopenhauer puts it, "take upon himself the pain of the whole world." On the other hand, however, he stops short of becoming the kind of bodhisattva figure Schopenhauer described earlier that attempts to lead others out of the veil of Maya, or the illusory causes of humanity's suffering, and into liberation. Cioran is a failed mystic and an even better pessimist in the sense that he would not hold this attainment true or available for anybody, which is in part analogous to and bolsters his critique of the "failed mystic" in *Tears and Saints* (i.e., "a critique of [the mystic's] will to power which reaps nothing but empty and cruel suffering") (Zarifopol-Johnston, xiii). He sacrifices his individuality, but not *for* anyone, and in that way he exemplifies the latter half of Schopenhauer's description which focuses on the hardship of the individual who cannot fend off her desires via a "final resignation" in order to free themselves from the "the allurements of hope" and the false pleasures of the world (379). On the one who is lured back into such egoism, Schopenhauer continues, "At times, in the hard experience of our own sufferings or in the vividly recognized sufferings of others, knowledge of the vanity and bitterness of life comes close to us who are still enveloped in the veil of Maya" (379).

Cioran is sure to resist the allurements of hope. Yet, in quite another way, he remains courageous in sense that his work does indeed uncover what lies underneath Maya's veil. Through an intense mode of unknowing, a kind of practical mysticism of pessimistic awareness, he points out the elaborate and illusive fallacies through which human beings live out their lives. In this way, then, Cioran hovers between the two concepts of willlessness and egoism, which, in his typical contradictory fashion, is not surprising. And yet, there is another, a third, view that can be taken, that is aligned at the point at which authorship and reader reception comes into play. For just because Cioran does not intend his work to be a

catalyst to any kind of change whatsoever, that does not necessarily mean that a reader might not find any. In fact, the change that happens is not even one that is related to the product of changing the plight of the world, but rather a change in the process of observing the world.

Toward a Zen Pessimism

Another way to show how Cioran deals with the subject of non-being is to view inexistence as a particular state of mind.[43] To do so, we can analyze passages in his work which specifically relate to Buddhism, a religion which prioritizes the concept of nothingness or, more accurately, emptiness (*sunyata*), as deeply significant on the path to realization. In the remaining space, an in-depth study of Buddhism's wellspring of beliefs and traditions cannot be undertaken, but we can begin to trace out Cioran's curious treatment of Buddhism. Given that he appears at once critical and laudatory of Buddhist doctrine, this living contradiction may bring us closer to understanding how merging Eastern mysticism with philosophical pessimism presents challenges to philosophical authority, but also utilizes the limits of philosophical thinking in order to possibly think *through* such limits. For example, Cioran writes,

> "Meditate but one hour upon the self's nonexistence and you will feel yourself to be another man," said a priest of the Japanese Kusha sect to a Western visitor.
> Without having frequented the Buddhist monasteries, how many times have I not lingered over the world's unreality, and hence my own? I have not become another man for that, no, but there certainly has remained with me the feeling that my identity is entirely illusory, and that by losing it I have lost nothing, except something, except *everything*. (*Trouble* 19)

Drawing on Buddhist custom, Cioran discloses a sort of pessimist appreciation for living in a state of non-attachment. To lose living under the false illusions of one's identity is to gain *everything* by returning to one's original state, what Zen masters call Original Mind. In unorthodox fashion, Cioran's curious treatment of Buddhism constitutes a strange portmanteau discourse, or inverted spiritual practice, something we might call a *Zen pessimism*.

Zen, a form of Mahayana Buddhism which began in sixth-century China and later spread throughout the West in a modern context by D. T. Suzuki, especially primacies this relation. Insofar as Cioran is doing a kind of non-philosophy,[44] that is, subtracting from Western systematic thought rather than adding to it, this mode bears a resemblance to Buddhist philosophy, "which takes up philosophy," writes William Barrett, "only as a device to save the philosopher from his conceptual prison; its philosophy is, as it were, a non-philosophy, a philosophy to undo philosophy" (xvi). Zen, then, is not a philosophy. And neither is it "mysticism

as the West understands mysticism" (xvii). Zen writings or sayings aim not to philosophize and are conveyed through strange mystical utterances, negations which give way to non-sensical affirmations. For those who come into the Zen state of mind, these non-sensical affirmations have pointed to the deeper reality of existence. "In the end all language is pointing: we use language to point beyond language, beyond concepts to the concrete," writes Barrett (xv). In contrast, Cioran points backwardly beyond language, reverse engineering it into an existential mantra for ego death: "*Sarvam anityam*: All is transitory (Buddha). A formula one should repeat at every hour of the day, at the—admirable—risk of dying of it" (*Anathemas* 19).

If the failed mystic of *Tears and Saints* is, for Cioran, the figure of futility *par excellence*, then this Zen pessimism, an epigrammatic auto-subtractivism in which futility points to itself via being oneself, becomes essentially *recuperative*. This pessimist recuperation is paradoxical, given that Cioran goes to great lengths to emphasize absolute futility, but it is by this futility that readers may be able to recuperate nothingness. There is something in futility worth thinking about more fully, and that something, being nothing, recuperates—à la futility qua futility. So the question arises: why have these texts not yet been sucked into the black hole of their own making? It is because they first require readers to pass through the event horizon in order to actualize their nothingness.

In other words, Zen pessimism recuperates failure not in order to redeem the world, but rather to point out more and more of its infinite failures. Cioran writes,

> "All is suffering"—modernized, the Buddhist expression runs: "All is nightmare."
> Thereby, nirvana, whose mission now is to end a much more widespread torment, is no longer a recourse reserved to the few but becomes as universal as nightmare itself. (Cioran, *Trouble* 14)

Whereas Zen Buddhist *satori*, the nirvanic experience of inner peace, emphasizes the awakened mind as its source, Cioran paradoxically insists (via an oneiric logic of suffering) that only by nightmare comes one's true awakening. To see the world as nightmare, to hear it playing as the nocturne of pessimism, is not to know the modern world philosophically, but rather to know it *practically*.[45]

At present, let us emphasize that Cioran does not specifically advocate Zen Buddhist practice, but rather uses Buddhist doctrine to problematize his readers' relationship to his non-philosophy's underlying tenets. Suzuki states, for example, that "contradiction, negation, or paradoxical statement is the inevitable result of the Zen way of looking at life" (120). Zen is a "living fact," an intuitive means of apprehending truth, and not something to be penned down. On the one hand, Suzuki's notion of paradox is homologous to Cioran's aphoristic language of paradox. On

the other hand, one finds in Cioran a poetic inversion of Zen, that is, a non-philosophy, but one profusely committed to writing. Consequently, it exacerbates Zen's limit-conditions to the point of failure. That is to say, his appropriation of Buddhist thought is itself a failure. But failure is "always essential," writes Cioran, because it "reveals us to ourselves, permits us to see ourselves as God sees us" (*Trouble* 17). For a Zen pessimist, the world does not change, only their perception of it does. It follows that this shift in perception enables one to attain a level of pessimistic lucidity, a state which neither withdraws from, nor adds to, the world's troubles. "One can be proud of what one has done," writes Cioran, "but one should be much prouder of what one has not done. Such pride has yet to be invented" (*Anathemas* 81).

Appeals to non-action raise an important question regarding Cioran's work and its relationship to ethics. In Buddhism, one cannot extricate the epistemological from the ethical, for the ethical is the a priori moment. Buddha stepped onto the path the moment he recognized that others suffer and that their suffering is the suffering of self. Earlier we pointed out that, for Cioran, only in non-being is one capable of not being disappointed. This notion echoes the very crux of Buddhism's commitment to compassion.[46] It is precisely in that moment of realization of non-existence that one recognizes the absolute commitment to others. Here Cioran presents readers with an ethical conundrum. He fails to allot an ethical imperative for compassion and thus fails to assess the ethical implications of this thought. Hence, his invocation of Buddhism is indeed a failure, at least an ethical failure. But being that Cioran's appeal to non-action serves as a practical vehicle to auto-negation, returning the practitioner to their rightful inexistence, then his work does provide a fascinating pivot point for the critical reception of his work to cross back into the realm of ethics.

The Way of Worst

If there is a lesson of unlearning to be gleaned from Cioran, it is to erase the "fiction of being" that people, dishonestly perpetuating an insidious complicity with their own births, constantly entrust to themselves. Being's fiction is that it masquerades as non-fiction, that it is the only "reality" that "exists." One must first awaken to the nightmare in order for the nightmare to provide one's awakening. The awakening might be sudden, as in the Rinzai account of satori, or it may come over the duration of time, mirroring the Soto school. Or perhaps one ought "to go still further than Buddha, to raise oneself above nirvana, to learn to do without it, . . . to be stopped by nothing, not even by the notion of deliverance, regarding it as a mere way-station, an embarrassment, an eclipse" (*Trouble* 207). Such an awakening is therefore a kind of sleeping,[47] a nirvanic reversal of nirvana wherein the pessimist refuses self

and world, but also refuses what is beyond self and world. No matter how it comes, his work plants the nightmarish seed of readerly awakening necessary to properly decipher the fictive nature of being. This way of reading, which is a type of pessimist sleuthing or true detection,[48] makes preparation to dismantle the very stage upon which this fiction takes place, reversing the hermeneutic circle into a self-eating or Ouroboric one.

Ultimately, Cioran often avoids going into the realm of ethics. His is an ethics of no one. But this ethics of no one conceals an ethics of the Other. It models the kind of horror-dwelling it takes to create the conditions of possibility in which other individuals, perhaps his readers, *can* enter into the realm of ethics.[49] For to dwell in horror necessarily means coming to realize, as if out of nowhere, that being oneself is the root cause of horror in the world. Hence, the critical reception of his work can point to an ethical encounter, even though he may have found one futile. Put yet another way, the lack of ethics in Cioran can be negatively indexed as a pessimal ethical move on his part, which lays the ground (*pessum* "downward, to the ground," from PIE *ped-yos*)[50] for a form of pessimo-mystical social anarchism, a world of no ones who commune by their nothingness.

His readers thus find themselves complicit in an adroit Cioranian paradox: that this practice of auto-negation, selflessness via pessimism, might bear out in a relinquishment of suffering. The question returns: why read the old curmudgeon Cioran? The courage of the pessimist is to intuitively recognize that there is no hope and to know that the only kind of world to be desired is one inhabited by those who exist by the abundance of their nothingness. Zen pessimism speculatively opens itself to a readership that can dwell in that space on and as its own, a readership, that is to say, of no-mind. In no-mind one is said to know without knowing, act without acting, and do without doing.[51] Put simply, for the Zen pessimist to do nothing means to do without doing, by intensely observing without identifying with oneself as the observer and recognizing, in that moment, the presence of infinite others factically suffering with you and because of you. These are readers who, in the commons of nowhere, move in a state of pessimist *mushin* (No-Mind), and who, in the ultimate form of compassion for one another, ask nothing of each other.[52] To practice asking nothing of anyone is also to suffer *through* the horror of oneself, the "living fact" of worst.

Zen pessimism shows the way to self-erasure by showing us nothing; it's only maxim, no maxim. To illustrate this point, we can take, for example, a short essay entitled "The Odyssey of Rancor," when Cioran writes that

> [O]ur kingdom is that of the "I," and through the "I" there is no salvation. To exist is to condescend to sensation, hence to self-affirma-

> tion. . . . The more we try to wrest ourselves from our ego, the deeper we sink into it. Try as we will to explode it, just when we suppose we have succeeded, there it is, apparently more self-assured than ever; whatever we do to destroy it merely augments its strength and solidarity, as such is its vigor and its perversity that it flourishes still more in affliction than in joy. . . . No man stirs without allying himself to the multiple, to appearances, to the "I." To act is to forfeit the absolute. (*History and Utopia* 62–63)

The logic of non-action found in this passage is axiomatic: there is no one to be; there never was anything to do; there is no way in because there is no way out. In other words, pessimist non-action resurrects the potential for ontological insurrection: to accept the inexistent call to be no one, what Zen refers to as the selfless self, is simply to return one to the full awareness of their nothingness. Pessimism of this sort claims no mastery over anything; it is non-mastered through its nirvanic reversal of nirvana, the renunciation of enlightenment: "'Children admit no limits to anything' they always want to see beyond, to see what there is afterward. But there is no afterward. Nirvana is a limit, the limit. It is liberation, supreme impasse" (*Trouble* 175). This pessimistic kōan, a playful but concentrated gesture of language, gives pause: to desire a way out is a limit. Cioran does not offer an escape. Rather, he offers us nothing.

Cioran's writings supply readers with the negative of writing, the dissemination of the extimacy of his soul. In *On the Heights of Despair*, Cioran writes, "My soul is chaos, how can it be at all? There is everything in me: search and you will find out . . . in me anything is possible, for I am he who at the supreme moment, in front of absolute nothingness, will laugh" (86). This is the mantra of the pessimist, the one who, despite the ineffable magnitude of suffering in the world, stays put, to see it and feel it with an intensity that others do not yet possess, so that they might one day laugh, to suffer absolutely but not to balk, for in this laughter there is absolutely nothing over which to suffer. Speaking impossibly, from there, which is really nowhere, everything is possible, impossibly speaking, even nothing. Stay put and let Zen pessimism fail you into inexistence. Worst is not a way out. It is the Way.

NOTES

1. Cf. "The 'region' of eternity is that of *intensity*, which surpasses the measures of quantity that we employ in time and space. 'Eternity' is not a duration of infinite length; it is the 'intensity of quality' which, if compared with time and thus translated into the language of quantity, is comparable with an infinite duration. . . . Eternal hell is the state of a soul imprisoned within itself, where the *soul* has no hope of coming out. 'Eternal' means to say 'without hope.' All suicides committed through desperation bear witness to the reality of eternal hell as a state of the soul" ("Meditations on the Tarot" 180).

2. This tenet is consciously and heretically appropriated from the popular Christian phrase "in, but not of," which refers to several cross references in the Bible, including John 8:23: "But he [Christ] continued, 'You are from below; I am from above. You are of this world; I am not of this world.'" Thus, this formulation aims to show that although Cioran's existential philosophy is based in and on the world, its impetus stems from a place not of the (human) world, a place, we will soon show, of horror.

3. The task of this chapter is to provide a thematically driven analysis rather than one inhered by sequential order, but the historicity of Cioran's writing life is nonetheless important.

4. Cioran's nihilistic oeuvre, infused with sophistical idiosyncrasies concerned with the nature of non-being and the language of negation, holds a close relation to the work of Gorgias, the Greek sophist known as "The Nihilist." In *On Non-Existence*, Gorgias developed three successive arguments. He held that nothing at all exists; if existence is, then humans cannot apprehend it; and if one manages to apprehend existence, it certainly cannot be communicated.

5. He also writes that "one always perishes by the self one assumes: to bear a name is to claim an exact mode of collapse" (*Temptation* 34).

6. Cf. Cioran: "I walk across the graveyard. There, under that stone, rests Truth; nearby lies Beauty; not far, Thoroughness, and on top of a pile of slabs covering delusions and hypotheses, the mausoleum of the Absolute: here lie the false consolations and the misleading consolations of the soul. High above, quieter than silence, hovers Error, stopping the wandering sophist dead in his tracks" (qtd. in Petreu 235).

7. Cf. "THE OBJECT OF ECSTASY IS THE ABSENCE OF AN OUTSIDE ANSWER. THE INEXPLICABLE PRESENCE OF MAN IS THE ANSWER THE WILL GIVES ITSELF, SUSPENDED IN THE VOID OF UNKNOWABLE NIGHT" (qtd. in *Bataille Reader* 45).

8. Though we should note she was also an immigrant from Eastern Europe.

9. We will return to this question of meontology later in the section entitled "Zen Pessimism."

10. Cf. "It remains for us to follow the path of facticity, while taking care to ensure that its absolutization not lead back to a dogmatic thesis. . . . Our task was to uncover an absolute that would not be an absolute entity. This is precisely what we obtain by absolutizing facticity—we do not maintain that a determinate entity exists, but that it is absolutely necessary that every entity might not exist. . . . There is no reason for anything to be or to remain the way it is; everything must, without reason, be able not to be and/or be able to be other than it is (*After Finitude* 60).

11. Cf. "Cioran, unlike Nietzsche, Kierkegaard, or Dostoyevsky, did not want to go anywhere. He didn't try to liberate man or bring him back to a 'right' path. He considered with disdain the superman and he had no sympathy for underground men. He didn't try to give sense to the non-sensical. He didn't know, but he didn't want to discover" (Finkenthal 147).

12. On the relation between the weird and veering, Roger Luckhurst articulates that "the weird does necessarily need the apparatus of horror, then: it can manifest in a waywardness that leaves the reader confounded at the slow mutation of the story out of one horizon of expectation and into another" ("The Weird" 1050).

13. Cioran's aphorisms and short essays hold a close relation to the work of Samuel Beckett, whose modernist literary genius was fueled by minimalist expositions on nothingness. Cioran's work could be said to be a partial philosophical counterpart to the work of Beckett, as the two were familiar with one another's work, and yet there remains a stark difference to their aesthetics. Whereas Beckett sometimes utilizes his medium to invent esoteric mythologies, Ciroan seeks to create a non-mysticism, in which he seeks to eliminate mystery rather than uncover it.

14. Cioran's view on poetry is complicated but worthy of note, especially given the fact that it holds a truthfulness for him that mysticism will not. He believes that "poetry expresses the essence of what cannot be possessed. . . . The poet would be an odious deserter of reality if in his flight he failed to take his suffering along. Unlike the

mystic or the sage, he cannot escape himself, nor leave the stage of his own obsession" (*A Short History of Decay* 98).

15. Here we can invoke Kristeva once again, as she writes, "There looms, within abjection, one of those violent, dark revolts of being, directed against a threat that seems to emanate from an exorbitant outside or inside, ejected beyond the scope of the possible, the tolerable, the thinkable . . . the abject has only one quality of the object—that of being opposed to *I*" (1).

16. "Whatever puts me at odds with the world is consubstantial with myself. How little I have learned from experience. My disappointments have always preceded me," writes Cioran (*Anathemas* 79).

17. Cf. Cioran writes: "What is injustice compared to disease? True, we may find it unjust to be sick. Moreover that is how each of us reacts. . . . Sickness *is*: nothing more real than disease. If we call it unjust, we must dare to do as much with Being itself—we must speak, then, of the *injustice of existing*" (*Trouble* 189–90).

18. Bernard Williams identifies several of these systematic philosophers, writing, "Plato, Aristotle, Kant, Hegel are all on the same side, all believing in one way or another that the universe or history or the structure of human reason can, when properly understood, yield a pattern that makes sense of human life and human aspirations" (*Shame and Necessity* 163).

19. One could speculate that the abortive utility of the Cioranian fragment holds a close relation to his own biographical and intellectual history. In a 1983 interview with Jason Weiss, Cioran provides an anecdote about a fit of despair he went through at age twenty-two, after which his mother remarked that "had I known" he was going to be so inundated with melancholy, "I would have had an abortion" (9). Cioran adds, "That made an extraordinary impression on me. It didn't hurt me, not at all. But later I said, 'That was very important. I'm simply an accident. Why take it all so seriously?' Because, in effect, it's all without substance" (9). Whether or not this experience serves as an authorial impetus to his choice of the epigram, a mode known for its poetic yet abrupt endings, is surely debatable. However, the autobiographical argument aside, it undoubtedly serves an emblematic function.

20. Cf. "Involuntary access to ourselves, sickness compels us, condemns us to 'profundity.' The invalid? A metaphysician in spite of himself" (Cioran, *All Gall* 148).

21. Chapter 2 contains a more in-depth analysis of the nature of unreality in relation to the work of Thomas Ligotti.

22. Meher Baba continues: "When spiritual experience is described as mystical, one should not assume that it is something supernatural or entirely beyond the grasp of human consciousness. All that is meant is that it is not accessible to the limited human intellect until the intellect transcends its limits and is illumined by direct realization of the Infinite. Jesus Christ pointed out the way to spiritual experience when He said, 'Leave all and follow me.' This means that man must leave limitations and establish himself in the infinite life of God. A real spiritual experience involves not only realization of the nature of the soul but also a right attitude toward worldly duties. If it loses a connection with the different phases of life, what we have is neurotic reaction that is far from being a spiritual experience" (6).

23. On this point, William Kluback notes that Cioranian pessimism is "a melancholy that gathers everything into indifference" (21).

24. Eugene Thacker notes that "Pessimism would be more mystical were it not for its defeatism. Mysticism is much too proactive for the pessimist, and pessimism too impassive even for the mystic. At the same time, there is something enviable about mysticism—despite its sufferings. There is a sense in which pessimists are really failed mystics ("Cosmic Pessimism").

25. Correlationism is defined as the view that thought cannot have access to a reality of things-in-themselves, only to things as they appear to human beings. As the editors of *The Speculative Turn* remark, "we only ever have access to the correlation between thinking and being, and never to either term considered apart from one another" (3).

26. In *A Short History of Decay*, Cioran writes that "the ideally lucid, hence ideally normal, man should have no recourse beyond the nothing that is in him. . . . I can imagine him saying: 'Torn from the goal, from all goals, I retain, of my desires and my displeasures, only their formulas. Having resisted the temptation to conclude, I have overcome the mind, as I have overcome life itself by the horror of looking for an answer to it" (7).

27. To a certain degree, we can claim to find in Cioran's "obscure and old" two chilling and yet beautifully insightful musings (we shall not go so far as to say they are allusions) of an intergeneric kind: those which echo the Lovecraftian "Old Ones" (here that one is an Old One unto oneself) and of Quentin Meillasoux's exposition of the "arche-fossil" (i.e., substantiation of what existed before the human being). Picking up on this line of thought nearly thirty-five years before Meillasoux's essential text *After Finitude*, Cioran writes that "No variety of literary originality is still possible unless we torture, unless we pulverize language. It proceeds differently if we abide by the expression of the idea as such. Here we find ourselves in an area where requirements have not altered since the pre-Socratics" (29).

28. Cf. As Dienstag notes: "Aphorisms and pessimism are fitted to one another" (*Pessimism* 227).

29. This sense of becoming metaphysically alien to oneself in order to keep oneself in check is aphorized in "Tribulations of an Alien," for example, when Cioran's Alien pronounces, "Release me from this shame of actions which makes me perform, every morning, the farce of resurrection and, every night, that of entombment; in the interval, nothing but this torment in the shroud of ennui. . . . I dream of wanting—and all I want seems to me worthless. Like a vandal corroded by melancholy, I proceed without a goal, self without a self, toward some unknown corner . . . in order to discover an abandoned god, a god who is his own atheist, and to fall asleep in the shadow of his last doubts and his last miracles" (*A Short History of Decay* 101).

30. Cf. "'We suffer: the external world begins to exist' . . . we suffer to excess: it vanishes. Pain instigates the world only to unmask its unreality" (Cioran, *All Gall* 33).

31. In his later writing, Cioran turns away from, as Zarifopol-Johnson calls it, "self-revelatory" writing and moves into a highly stylistic mode of writing that is contingent on the individuation of agony.

32. In *H. P. Lovecraft: A Life* (2004), S. T. Joshi writes that "Cosmicism is at once a metaphysical position (an awareness of the vastness of the universe in both space and time), an ethical position (an awareness of the insignificance of human beings within the realm of the universe), and an aesthetic position (a literary expression of this insignificance, to be effected by the minimizing of human character and the display of the titanic gulfs of space and time)" (319).

33. In this case, Francois Laruelle's criticism of philosophy is helpful in order to frame this point. Laruelle writes, "Philosophy's flippancy with regard to man is unfathomable—it oscillates between a narrowness of perspective, a reductive cosmic prejudice, and a stupid self-assurance pro and contra that caricature called 'humanism.' It has never been made for man, but always for the world in which it incarcerates him, the being into which it throws him, the nature within which it inscribes him, the unconscious to which it subjects him or through which it shreds him up as 'subject,' the society in which it dissolves him, the mathematics of which it makes him a 'function'—here is the most profound alienation of humans, the one that governs all the others. Facile philosophies of alienation took the work only halfway; philosophical alienation would have had to have been excavated all the way down to generic man."

34. "Madness is achieved only by the garrulous and the taciturn: those who have emptied themselves of all mystery and those who have accumulated too much" (*All Gall* 143).

35. On Plotinus's formulation, alone with the alone, and its meaning in relation to the non-philosophical mysticism of François Laruelle, see Nicola Masciandaro, "Secret: No Light Has Ever Seen the Black Universe," *Dark Nights of the Universe*.

36. On the coinage and use of this new term in relation to the study of pessimism, see the release entitled *True Detection* (2014).

37. . Cf. Cioran in *All Gall is Divided*: "Thought which liberates itself from all prejudice disintegrates, imitating the scattered coherence of the very things it would apprehend. With 'fluid' ideas we *spread ourselves* over reality, we espouse it; we do not explicate it. Thus we pay dearly for the 'system' we have not sought" (33).

38. One will note Cioran's critique of philosophy in *The Trouble with Being Born*: "Philosophy is taught only in the agora, in a garden, or at home. The lecture chair is the grave of philosophy, the death of any living thought, the dais is the mind in morning" (188).

39. Cf. "A person who has the misfortune to fall victim to the spell of a philosophical system . . . can no longer see the world, or people, or historic events, as they are; he sees everything only through the distorting prism of the system by which he is possessed" (*Meditations on the Tarot* 42–43).

40. Cioran's early work, for instance, survives within the tradition of the "nihilism of the great sophists" (Petreu 234), and, infused with sophistical idiosyncrasies concerned with the nature of non-being and the language of negation, holds a close relation to the work of Gorgias.

41. "Once we appeal to our most intimate selves," Cioran writes, "we become unconscious of our own gaps. . . . 'Self-knowledge'? A contradiction in terms" (*Trouble* 35).

42. Cf. "No one needs pessimism, though I like to imagine the idea of a pessimist activism" (Thacker, "Cosmic Pessimism" 66).

43. As we will see, this state of mind is a state of no-mind, a self-realized nothingness as opposed to mere apathy or passive nihilism.

44. The usage of this term throughout the chapter can be thought of as a philosophy of undoing and is not to be confused with the non-standard philosophy of François Laruelle,

45. As Cioran sees it, "In this 'great dormitory,' as one Taoist text calls the universe, nightmare is the sole method of lucidity" (*All Gall* 19).

46. In *Dialogues with Scientists and Sages* (1986), Renée Weber remarks that ultimate reality in Buddhism is a state that, similar to Kant's "noumenon," is "beyond human language and thought." "It is from this level of wholeness," she continues, "that true compassion derives. Compassion—the central ethical value of Buddhism—is therefore no mere emotion but rather a force that lies embedded in reality itself" (129).

47. Cf. Cioran: "If we could sleep twenty-four hours a day, we would soon return to the primordial slime, the beatitude of that perfect torpor before Genesis—the dream of every consciousness sick of itself" (*Trouble* 212).

48. On the coinage and use of this new term in relation to the study of pessimism, see *True Detection* (2014).

49. A Nietzschean move of this sort would thus view utter futility as essentially productive (i.e., in a world with absolutely no hope, there is nothing that can harm anyone any longer).

50. "Pejorative." *Online Etymology Dictionary*. Accessed August 30, 2015.

51. Cf. the *Wu Xin Lun* (On No Mind): "It is as if one were to see to the end of the day, and still see not, because in the end there was no mind to see. It is as if hearing all day to the end of day, still one hears not, because in the end there was no mind to hear. It is as if one feels all day to the end of the day, and yet feels not, because in the end there was no mind to feel. It is as if one knows all to the end of the day, and still knows not, because in the end there was no mind to know. For no mind is indeed true mind. True mind is indeed no mind" (qtd. in Saso 4–5).

52. This paradox, arising ex nihilo in the mind of the Zen pessimist, points to itself as a double entendre: to ask nothing of anyone, that is, but their nothingness.

Afterword

Toward the Mystical Death of the Speculative Critic

Each of the writers in this book holds a unique interest in speculatively exposing the limits of human thought—a breaking point in and of itself, to be sure, but one which opens up a new field of potentiality in literary criticism. Their wide-ranging and interdisciplinary interests in horror, mysticism, and philosophy indicate virtuosic writing habits and methodologies that do not function so much to validate each field individually as all-encompassing modes of discourse, but to reveal a continual creative effort to open and renew the potency of more questioning and speculation. Subsequent work in literary and interdisciplinary studies may perhaps benefit from the further study of these three writers who inevitably complicate the relationships both readers and critics have to a given text. Their work tends to blur the methodologies with which some readers and critics might be most familiar, and which are sometimes inadequate to opening up such an interminable questioning. The texts we have analyzed in the previous four chapters attest to these writers' keen attentiveness to literary and philosophic nuance and their impressive ability to utilize negative logic. Because crafting methods to think about mystical inversion and nothingness has been a priority to this book, these authors' commitment to articulating the triumphs and pitfalls of negativity made them invaluable subjects for critical study.

Chapter 4 ended with some remarks about the question of ethics in the work of E. M. Cioran. Though we have tried our best to make a case for Zen pessimism being an ethical move from the standpoints of readership and possible future criticism, it remains that there are limits to criticism and to weird mysticism. Yet, by merging the question of ethics with the notion of mystical death,[1] we might be able to think through, which is also to say, *with*, this limit. This brief conclusion thus sets the stage for thinking how this limit might be overcome by focusing on how executing an apophatic criticism might in turn be a kind of mystical death wherein the critic annihilates herself via doing criticism. And criticism shakes off the chains that bind it to the essay form to become a true writing.

In the weird mysticisms of Bataille, Cioran, and Ligotti, we find a perversion of traditional mysticism, one immanently predicated on authorial anguish and a cosmically contingent self-world negation, in order for any thought of absolute union to be desired at all. Moving alongside

Cioran's figure of the "failed mystic," weird mysticism holds a similar relation to the notion of failure—not necessarily on behalf of an experience of failure but on behalf of the failure of experience. Often, literary critics might earnestly partake in what could be called a subjective fallacy: that the more one works with a text, the more one identifies with it. (And rightly so, for there are always a multitude of reasons which bring readers to certain texts and beg certain readings of texts.) But in the case of the texts in question in this book, this sequence should be inverted: the more one works with a text, the more one is annihilated by it. This is perhaps the maxim of what we might properly call an *apophatic criticism*, a mode by which the critic undoes herself in the act of self-discovery which is really an act of self-dissolution. Perhaps, then, this is the weird moment that points to itself while pointing at the critic—the "me" who has chosen to go by *we*—announcing itself as the very limit-experience of criticism, or at least criticism of this sort. Theorizing a mystical death as such (i.e., the mystical death of the speculative critic) might add to future research on the nexus of mysticism, pessimism, and horror. By being a form of criticism that becomes what it describes, it opens thought back to its absolute origins, a limitlessness unhindered by its own anarcho-mystical liberation: the mystical death of the speculative critic, the one-who-thinks(-not). This mystical death suggests a connection, if not obfuscation, of the recent and arbitrary boundaries between critical theory and creative writing (i.e., theory-fiction, a form of writing where speculative philosophy is translated into a necessary fiction).

Ultimately, this afterword seeks to open the matter of ethics—a topic that, like the spectral figure of the dead critic in the book's introduction, looms like a shadow[2] behind the text—to the possibility of further study. Rather than matter of ethics being unequivocal in nature, this aspect, arising from the alternating spheres of authorship and death, stems from what we could call *weird mysticism's tragedy*. Part of this tragedy may derive from the fact that weird mysticism is ambivalent about ethics. But we could also argue, by calling upon and then utilizing weird mysticism's central mode, negativity, *as a praxis*, that the opposite is in fact true. On this point, the insightful words of Clarice Lispector come to mind: "My spectacular and ongoing failure proves that the opposite exists: success" (*A Breath of Life* 66). The limit, therefore, might be overcome by focusing on how performing criticism of this sort is a kind of mystical death in and of itself, wherein the apophatic critic annihilates herself via a weird, speculative criticism. Thus, the limit becomes the very method or practice with which to overcome itself.

Keeping in mind Lispector's negative logic discussed in chapter 1, let us surmise that weird mysticism's failure shares in this same premise. In this indirect sense, weird mysticism's tragedy can be directly related to the notion of mystical death. Although the writers featured in this book seek to blur the divisions between self/world and world/cosmos, it still

follows that any criticism of the non-experience of horror and suffering is necessarily contingent on its human experience, individually and collectively, just as any mystical experience of the divine is contingent on the intricacies of individuation. Thus, as readers and as critics, we ought to ask the question of how discourse about the inhuman or the divine might potentially deepen or lessen our experience as living, breathing human beings. In short, weird mysticism is a blackened rabbit hole through which the critic must enter by exiting, climbing out of the hole backwards to actually move through it. So, we must account for a critical paradigm in which moving through it necessarily means dying from it and dying from it means opening oneself to the radical, impersonal space of mystical freedom.[3]

Horror's logic of negativity inheres in an aporia whereby self-dissolution and self-realization compete by means of the trope and mode of mystical death. Horror as such is necessarily epiphanic: it confirms that a negative approach to self-realization can happen through a sustained process of self-dissolution whereby one revolts against their own macabre fate. From there, life itself becomes its own auto-commentary on a mystical death whose blackened residue serves as the inverse spark to fuel one's own auto-annihilation, preparing the ground for potential union with the absolute. Mystical death thus *becomes* the ethical move. And a purely apophatic criticism, then, insofar as it might be read by others, serves as a sort of "way of the bodhisattva," a discourse that, through its own annihilation, *moves out of* itself in order to show others how to access such freedom. It calls for a theory of doing what you are reading about, a fiction that gives us what criticism cannot deliver—that is, a theory-fiction that produces a knowledge that erases the knower.

Now, it is a tall task to ask for a theory of a criticism-without-oneself, so at present we will need to conclude by just planting the seed. But if weird mysticism's tragedy is that it wavers on ethics, then we ought to remind ourselves that tragedy, insofar as it is a discourse of mourning, is always about death. Weird mysticism gives us the tools to think about ethics, but it is not yet an ethics. And yet weird mysticism is always a writing. Likewise, true artistic tragedy is also ambivalent about ethics. Evoking both pity and terror, tragedy produces a contradiction of the soul. Tragedy inverts the Stoic device of hiding one's affect by encouraging excessive lament over death. Like tragedy, weird mysticism embraces rather than abjures death, providing a liminal space where one must sit, so to speak, in the mire of ambiguity for a bit. In its classical formulation, this tragic mire is grounded in an encounter with horror. Theatrically speaking, the Greeks often treated those encounters of horror in apophatic fashion, capturing it in language, but denying it on the stage. Thus, the economy of the horror found in death is that there is a freedom in the death.

In these few final words, let us take the leap, then, and proffer, being that a central tenet of mysticism is the death of self/ego/mind, that, on one level mystical death is indeed itself quite tragic. The impact of weird mysticism's tragedy, mystical death, is that it gives us a context in which ethics might happen, that is, it uncovers an ethical potentiality emerging from a space of radical openness without any ideological commitments. However, against the grain of traditional tragic discourse, the negativity of mystical death inverts the horrible experience of ego death into an imperturbable joy. And it is precisely here that our rainstick formulation from the introduction comes full circle. This readerly joy is horror's negative, the condition of possibility for an ethical love that is essentially and properly human because it is divine. And this joy is divine because it is also perfectly unhuman, devoid of the human error of being oneself. The joy, then, contingent on one's meeting with divine horror in the first place, is therefore twice removed and yet two times as powerful. Divine horror eviscerates human error simply by being itself, through the negativity of love. Weird mysticism *must* implore the tragic. This is the paradox of reaping a mystical death: that it will sow love. And so, we will conclude, and so it goes, that death begins, which is also to say, ends, in conversation with Love.[4]

NOTES

1. Meher Baba beautifully articulates the notion of mystical death, noting that one should "die such a death that you will not have to die again. Die, all of you, in the real sense of the word so that you may live ever after" ("The Silence Begins" 643).

2. In *The Pleasure of the Text*, Roland Barthes contends that "the text needs its shadow: this shadow is a bit of ideology, a bit of representation, a bit of subject: ghosts, pockets, traces, necessary clouds" (32).

3. Georges Bataille's writing, if we remember, following Botting and Wilson, was interested in a negativity that is "unemployed, in the service of nothing and no one, inoperative in respect of specified or useful goals" (*Bataille Reader* 4).

4. Let us end, then, with lines from the eighth-century Muslim saint and Sufi mystic, Rabi'ah al-Basri, who so eloquently captures the essential relation between mystical death and Divine Love: "Ironic, but one of the most intimate acts /of our body is death. / So beautiful appeared my death – knowing who then I would kiss, / I died a thousand times before I died. / 'Die before you die,' said the Prophet Muhammad. / Have wings that feared ever touched the Sun? / I was born when all I once feared – I could love" (*Love Poems from God*).

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Index

abjection, 109, 110, 144n15
abyssal cosmic twist, 19
Agamben, Giorgio, 13, 35, 91, 97
alienation, 4, 10, 30, 32, 50, 51, 59n10, 106, 145n33
alienness, 9, 18, 20, 37, 40, 78, 127, 145n29
Aligheri, Dante, 23n12, 26
Angela of Foligno, 22n6, 80, 91
anti-natalism, 107, 110, 113
anti-prophet, 106–107
anti-writing, 128
aphorism, 113–114, 127, 134
apophasis, 7, 11, 14, 36, 38, 87
apophatic archeology, 53
apophatic criticism, 147, 148
apophatic horror, 80
aporia, 9–11, 14
Aurobindo, Sri, 22n7
auto-commentary, 3, 47, 108, 149

Baba, Meher, 118, 144n22, 150n1
Badiou, Alain, 48
Bardon, Franz, 96–97
Barthes, Roland, 27, 150n2
Bataille, Georges: absence of God, 68, 75; *Collected Poems*, 83, 88; dark halo of sorrow, 91; *Guilty*, 69, 71, 72, 79, 80, 93, 97; heterology, 69, 83; *The Impossible*, 76, 77, 89, 90, 91, 96; *Inner Experience*, 37, 63, 66, 67, 70, 71, 72, 78, 85, 87; interest in Nietzsche, 71, 73–74; *Literature and Evil*, 92, 100n12; *On Nietzsche*, 71, 73, 101n30; *The Summa Atheologica*, 63; *Theory of Religion*, 81
Beckett, Samuel, 143n13
Benjamin, Walter, 57n2
blackening, 32, 43; and mystical death, 52, 149; as writing, 9, 50, 120
black universe, 50–52
Blanchot, Maurice, 84, 100n20
bodhisaatva, 109, 137, 149
Boldt, Leslie, 67–68, 70, 81
Bonaventure, Saint, 59n16, 101n26
Botting, Fred, 88, 100n11, 100n16, 150n3
Brassier, Ray, 60n27, 125
Bruno, Giordano, 65
Buddhism, 135, 138, 140, 146n46
Burke, Edmund, 51

Cahn, Zilla Gabrielle, 115
Christ, 122, 144n22
Cioran, E. M. : *All Gall is Divided*, 105, 108, 114, 122; *Anathemas and Admirations*, 110, 111, 117, 120, 128, 129, 140; and cosmic catachresis, 126; and failed mysticism, 104, 117; *On the Heights of Despair*, 111, 128, 142; *A Short History of Decay*, 106, 113, 115, 124, 145n26; *Tears and Saints*, 103, 105, 119, 127, 132, 137; *The Temptation to Exist* 108, 111, 118, 120, 128; *The Trouble with Being Born*, 17, 103, 106, 116, 123, 126, 129, 131; wandering, 103–107; writing life, 104–108
correlationism, 21, 121, 144n25; and horror, 27, 28, 75, 81, 98
cosmicism, 130
cosmic horror, 130–131
Cloud of Unknowing, 5, 20; and perfect sorrow, 31; and negation, 60n28
Clute, John, 58n9
compassion, 140, 141, 146n46
cosmic catachresis, 126, 127, 128, 133; definition of, 128
cosmic wound, 128, 131
Critchley, Simon, 113

dark night of the soul, 44, 46
death, 54, 55, 58n7, 77, 79, 91, 95; of God, 71, 82, 122; of the subject, 64
De Certeau, Michel, 45, 60n26
deject, 109, 110–111
Derrida, Jacques, 57n3, 64
Descartes, 38, 123, 135
désoeuvre, 82, 100n16
detachment, 42, 49, 117
Dienstag, Joshua Foa, 104, 113
Dionysius the Areopagite, 36–38, 52; influence on Bataille, 87–90
disease. *See* sickness
disgust, 101n31, 109, 111, 124
divine darkness, 37–38, 83, 89, 91
Divine Inexistence, 125–126
divine Love, 14, 77, 150n4
doubleness, 2, 11, 13, 18, 30, 35–36, 52, 69, 74, 80, 99n9, 110
dukkha, 135

ecstasy, 31, 45, 67, 70, 71–72, 88, 90, 98, 132
ego-death. *See* mystical death
Elias, Camelia, 108, 113, 127
enlightenment, 13, 30, 142
epigrammatic thought, 47, 95, 127
ethics, 126, 135, 140, 141, 147–150
exscription, 72, 91
extinction, 39, 60n27, 124–125

facticity, 3, 93, 109, 143n10
failed mystic, 104, 118, 120, 121, 122, 137, 148
fiction of being, 133
Fisher, Mark, 9, 57n3
flâneury of the unreal, 26, 27
fragment, 67, 68, 71, 73, 90, 104, 111, 112–124
fragmentation, 69; in Bataille, 73–74; in Cioran, 107, 113, 114; in Ligotti, 28, 59n14
Franke, William, 7, 35
free spirit, 115–116, 123
Freud, Sigmund, 59n11
futility, 119–120, 133–134, 139

glome, 125
Gorgias, 143n4

Hadewijch of Antwerp, 13–14, 77
halos, 91–93, 96–99
Harman, Graham, 20–21
Hart, Kevin, 70
hauntology, 27; in critical discourse, 57n3
Hollier, Denis, 63, 100n15
Hollywood, Amy, 14, 66, 72, 73
holiness: and the weird, 54, 78; and ruins, 55
horror, 2–4, 13–18, 21, 149; in Bataille, 78, 80–82, 91, 93, 94–97; in Cioran, 107–109, 125, 130, 136, 141; in Ligotti, 25–33, 49, 53, 54–56
horror-dwelling, 141
horror of philosophy. *See* Thacker, Eugene

individuation, 9, 11, 18, 59n10, 72, 92, 97, 128, 132
ineffability, 14, 38, 67, 69, 82, 99n4

John of the Cross, 43–44, 46–48, 87
Joshi, S. T., 10, 30, 41, 145n32
joy, 12–13, 34, 96, 142, 150
Joy, Eileen, 9
Julian of Norwich, 47

Kendall, Stuart, 85, 101n25
kenosis, 15, 32, 83, 92
Kierkegaard, Søren, 10, 94
kōan, 135, 142
Kristeva, Julia, 109, 110, 144n15

Land, Nick, 68, 124
Larchet, Jean-Claude, 114
Laruelle, François, 41, 52, 145n33
Ligotti, Thomas, 25; *Conspiracy Against the Human Race*, 32, 39, 47, 49, 53–56; darkness and blackness, 40; macabre unreality, 25; *Noctuary*, 26, 32, 34, 39, 40, 41, 49, 50, 53; self-subversion, 33; *Teatro Grottesco*, 30, 47; writing career, 33–35
liminality, 54, 55, 90, 92–93, 104, 149
limit-experience, 8, 56, 84, 90
linguistic trauma, 43, 54
Lispector, Clarice, 7, 12–13, 68, 136, 148

Lovecraft, H. P., 16–17; and Bataille, 81; and Cioran, 130–131; influence on Ligotti, 30, 40
Luckhurst, Roger, 66, 99n2, 100n10, 130, 143n12
luminous darkness, 52, 57

madness, 29, 41, 56, 59n15, 73, 86, 101n25, 131, 145n34
Mainländer, Phillip, 49
malignant uselessness, 49, 120
Masciandaro, Nicola, 18, 29, 50, 52, 69
McGinn, Bernard, 9, 15, 26, 60n28
meaning event, 14
Meditations on the Tarot, 20, 142n1, 146n39
Meister Eckhart, 37, 61n37, 92, 107
Meillassoux, Quentin, 17, 109, 121, 125–126, 126, 145n27
meontology, 109, 133, 134, 135
Merleau-Ponty, Maurice, 25
monster, 17, 23n11, 25, 33, 94
mushin. *See* no-mind
mystical death, 2, 4, 147
mystical poetry, 83–75
mystical Love, 13, 14–15, 50, 98, 150, 150n4
Mystical Theology. *See* Dionysius the Areopagite

Negarestani, Reza, 19
negation, 18, 34, 113, 126; logic of, 7, 28, 37, 48, 108
New Weird, 30, 58n6, 58n8
Nietzsche, Friedrich, 71, 73, 79, 113, 115–116, 123, 133
nihilism, 106, 143n4
no-mind, 108, 134, 146n43
non-action, 140, 142
non-being. *See* meontology
nouminous life, 54–56
Noys, Benjamin, 71, 74; "horror temporis," 42; "labor of the negative," 8, 22n2

ontology, 27, 31, 57n3, 82, 125, 134, 135
Original Mind, 138
Orr, Gregory, 85
Otto, Rudolf, 54–55
outsider, 11, 18, 107

para-academia, 64, 99n1
paradox: Cioranian, 141; Bataillean, 64, 73; in Zen, 139; "Moses paradox," 61n35; mystical, 11, 12, 13
perversion, 40, 99n2, 128; polymorphous, 88
pessimism, 18; cosmic, 112, 123, 124, 127, 131, 132; existential, 29, 47, 49, 53; metaphysical, 105; Nietzschean, 115–116; Zen pessimism, 133, 138–142
Plotinus, 133, 145n35
poet-philosopher, 111
poiesis, 75, 83
Porete, Marguerite, 26, 87
post-structuralism: Bataille and, 63–64
principium individuationis, 136
purgative contemplation, 47, 48, 49

Rabiʿah al-Basri, 150n4
Radcliffe, Ann, 77–78
rainstick formulation, 12–13, 150
Richman, Michèle H., 99n8
Ricoeur, Paul, 27
Rimbaud, Arthur, 86, 88
Roudinesco, Élisabeth, 40
Rubenstein, Mary-Jane, 11, 38
ruins, 53, 55–56, 64, 105–106

sanctues divinae, 3
Sartre, Jean-Paul, 101n25, 112
satori, 139, 140
Scaligero, Maximo, 59n10
Schopenhauer, Arthur, 105, 118, 135–137
self-dissolution, 76, 95, 148
self-endurance, 103
Sells, Michael T., 14, 38, 87
shadow, 51, 56, 60n24, 148; and Pseudo-Dionysius, 37, 38
Shipley, Gary L., 131
sickness : Cioranian understanding of, 112–116; Julian of Norwich, 47; Ligottian, 46; Nietzschean understanding of, 116
Sickness Unto Death, 94
Silesius, Angelus, 107

Siren of the Outside, 55
skepticism, 106, 108, 127, 129
sleep, 22n5, 41, 67, 95, 140, 146n47; and indifference, 127, 131
Sontag, Susan, 93, 111
sorrow, 12, 31, 91–99, 122–123
sovereignty, 68, 70, 71, 90
Spare, Austin Osman, 3
Spitzer, Mark, 86, 88, 89
spectral, 2, 148
speculative realism, 2, 21, 29, 144n25
St. Armand, Barton Levi, 78
Steiner, Rudolf, 13, 22n8
Stoekl, Allan., 8, 65
suffering, 12, 88, 121–122, 128, 135–137, 139
Suzuki, D. T., 138

Taylor, Marc C., 83, 90
terror, 13–14; horror and, 13, 75–79; Bataille and, 76–78, 79–82; Ligotti and, 47, 54, 59n12; liminal, 54
Thacker, Eugene, 26, 29; cosmic pessimism, 108, 112, 123, 132; "horror of philosophy," 1, 21; *nouminous*, 54, 55–56; world-without-us, 109
Theologia Germanica, 122
Theresa of Avila, Saint, 97
Trafford, James, 30, 36
tragedy, 148–150
true detection, 133, 141, 146n36
threefold ontology, 125
Trigg, Dylan, 61n39
tsalal, 41, 51
Tsunetomo, Yamamoto, 59n20
Turner, Denys, 43; experientialism, 45; self-subverting utterance, 37

Underhill, Evelyn, 22n3
unthinkability, 8, 20, 21, 26, 28, 40, 54, 55, 98, 112, 131

vacuity, 117–118

wandering sophist, 107
Weber, Renée, 146n46
Weil, Simone, 14–15, 61n33, 117
"the weird," 3, 9–10, 21, 28, 54, 58n6, 66, 77, 80
weird mysticism, 36, 65, 78, 112, 134; as genre, 19; as writing, 11, 21; definition of, 8–10, 67; materiality of, 11; theory and practice, 1
Woodard, Ben, 59n13
Williams, Bernard, 144n18
Wilson, Scott, 88, 100n11, 100n16, 150n3
Wittgenstein, Ludwig, 59n19
wyrd, 9, 58n4, 66, 107

Zen, 138–139, 139–140, 146n46
Zen pessimism, 138, 139, 141–142

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